La biografía mercantil de este hombre es tan curiosa como sencilla. Era muy joven cuando entró de hortera en case de Arnáiz; allí sirvió muchos años, siempre bien visto del principal por su honradez acrisolada y el grandísimo interés con que miraba todo lo concerniente al establecimiento. Y a pesar de tales prendas, Estupiñá no era un buen dependiente. Al despachar, entretenía demasiado a los parroquianos, y si le mandaban con un recado o comisión a la Aduana, tardaba tanto en volver, que muchas veces creyó D. Bonifacio que le halbían llevado preso. La singularidad de que teniendo Plácido estas mañas no pudieran los dueños de la tienda prescindir de él, se explica por la ciega confianza que inspiraba, pues estando él al cuidado de la tienda y de la caja, ya podían Arnáiz y su familia echarse a dormir. Era su fidelidad tan grande como su humildad, pues ya le podían reñir y decirle cuantas perrerías quisieran sin que se incomodase. Por esto sintió macho Arnáiz que Estupiñá dejara la casa en 1837, cuando se le antojó establecerse con los dineros de una pequeña herencia. Su principal, que le conocía bien, hacía lúgubres profecías del porvenir comercial de Plácido trabajando por su cuenta.

The man called Estupiñá must have been indispensable to the *tertulias* in all the shops, because when he didn't go to Arnáiz's somebody always asked, "What have you heard from Plácido?" When he appeared, they would receive him with happy exclamations; his mere presence enlivened the conversation. In 1871 I met this man whose vanity rested on his "having seen all of Spain's history" in the nineteenth century. He was born to the world in 1803, and dubbed himself Mesonero Romanos' "birth twin" because they were both born on July 19 of that year. A single sentence of his is enough to prove his immense knowledge of the kind of history one can learn simply by looking around: "I saw José I the same as I'm seeing you right now." And he seemed to lick his chops whenever he replied to a question like "Did you get to see the duke of Angulema and Lord Wellington?" "You bet I did." His answer never varied: "The same as I'm seeing you right now."

He was annoyed if someone interrogated him skeptically. "Did I actually *see* María Cristina when she arrived to marry the king? Why, that was just the other day!"

To substantiate his ocular erudition, he used to talk about "the way Madrid looked" on September 1, 1840, as if it had been a week ago. He had seen Canterac die and Merino being executed—"on his own scaffold, no less"—for being one of those Samaritans who comfort prisoners condemned to death. He had seen Chico (the chief of police) being killed; ... well, not exactly seen him, but he'd heard the shots from where he was, on Velas Street. He had seen Fernando VII on July 7 when he appeared on the balcony to tell the militiamen to "shake up" the Royal Guard. He had seen Rodil and Sergeant Garcia haranguing from another balcony, back in '36. He had seen O'Donnell and Espartero when they embraced. And Espartero once, greeting the people. And O'Donnell doing the same; all on balconies. And finally, he had seen another historical character on a balcony not long ago, proclaiming in a high-pitched voice that it was all over for the kings. The history Estupiñá knew was written on the balconies of Madrid.

This man's business biography is as curious as it is simple. He was very young when he started out as a clerk at Atnáiz's. He served there many years, always highly regarded by the owner for his unfailing honesty and great interest in everything concerning the firm. Yet despite such virtues Estupiñá was not a good clerk. When he made a sale, he kept the customers too long, and when he was sent on an errand or a commission to the Customs House, it took him so long that in many instances Don Bonifacio thought he'd been put in jail. The reason why Plácido, even with all his shenanigans, was indispensable to the shop's owners was that he inspired blind trust. With him in charge of the shop and the cash register, Arnáiz and his family could forget about the business. Plácido's loyalty was as great as his modesty; they could scold him or insult him all they wanted—it didn't bother him a bit. That's why Arnáiz was very sorry when Estupiñá left in 1837; he'd inherited some money and gotten the idea of striking out on his own. His boss, who knew him well, made dire predictions about the commercial future awaiting Plácido once he was his own boss.[11]

Galdós goes on to launch into an account of Estupiñá's multiple daily activities and his busy trajectories about the city. There is no condescension towards this secondary or minor character: Spain is a far more socially egalitarian society than its "advanced" neighbors (except in the upper spheres of its emergent bourgeoisie)—and yet Estupiñá is there for reasons of plot, for it is through him that the young man we will continue for another moment to call the hero—Juanito Santa Cruz—will meet the second love of his love and the first-named eponymous heroine, Fortunata. I think that Galdós needed the accident and the pretext for this chance meeting, but that the richness of imagination was such that he couldn't let it alone, that he compulsively elaborated the necessary link into this extraordinary family dependent (on whom the family truly itself depends) and in whom the deeper genius of Galdós's character elaboration is somehow allegorized, but on the strength of a quasi-familial household relationship. Estupiñá is a member of the family, and he merits all the sympathy and good will we are to bring to this family, from whom, however, we are also distant as from a zoological or biological exhibit arranged for us by Galdós's unique combination of tolerant affection and cold-blooded scientific observation. For Galdós, the most inveterate and archetypal of bachelors, is also a family man and the head of a household, however exasperating it may be: and his construction of his character systems reflect this profound structural dualism and

[11] Benito Pérez Galdós, *Fortunata y Jacinta*, Madrid: Casa Editorial Hernandez, 1968. Translation by Agnes Nancy Gullon, ibid., 34–35.

ambivalence. (In that, Estupiñá can be considered a kind of double of the author himself: but as we shall see, there are many kinds of these in Galdós.)

The evolution of the usurer Torquemada will now offer a virtual allegory of this process: the protagonist of four novels and a minor character in others, he is clearly a fundamental element in this realism in which money is a central fact of life, from inheritances to the condition of beggars, from the anxiety of debt to the frivolity of the spendthrift and the credulous admiration of the multitude for the wealthy.

But the paradox of this thematic centrality is this: that Torquemada remains a protagonist as long as he is technically a minor character; it is when he becomes a protagonist in his own novels that he loses this "protagonicity," if I may put it that way, and truly becomes a minor or flat character in fact, if not in name or appearance. Indeed, Galdós seems himself to have become aware of this strange evolution, for he interrupts the central panel of his Torquemada tetralogy to make the following lengthy digression:

> Zárate ... Pero ¿quién es este Zárate?
>
> Reconozcamos que en nuestra época de uniformidades ya de nivelación física y moral se han desgastado los tipos genéricos y que van desaparaciendo, en el lento ocaso del mundo antiguo, aquellos caracteres que representaban porciones grandísimas de la familia humana, clases, grupos, categorías morales. Los que han nacido antes de los últimos veinte años recuerdan perfectamente que antes existían, por ejemplo, el genuine tipo military, y todo campeón curtido en las guerras civiles se acusaba por su marcial facha, aunque de paisano se vistiese. Otros muchos tipos habia, *calvados*, como vulgarmente se dice, consagrados por especialísimas conformaciones del rostro humano y de los modales y del vestir. El avaro, pongo por caso, ofrecia rasgos y fisonomía como de casta, y no se le confundía con ninguna otra especie de hombres, y lo mismo puede decirse del *Don Juan*, ya fuse de los que pican alto, ya de los que se dedican a doncellas de server y amas decría. Y el beato tenía su cara y andares y ropa a las de ningún otro parecidas, y caracterización igual se observaba en los encargados de chupar sangre humana, prestamistas, vampiros, etcetera. Todo eso pasó, y apenas quedan ya tipos de clase, como no sean los toreros. En el scenario del mundo se va acabando el amaneramiento, lo que no deja de ser un bien para el arte, y ahora nadie sabe quién es nadie, como no lo estudie bien, familia por familia y persona por persona.
>
> Esta tendencia a la uniformidad, que se relaciona en cierto modo con lo mucho que la Humanidad se va despabilando, con los progresos de la industria y hasta con la baja de los aranceles, que ha generalizado y abaratado la buena ropa, nos ha traído una gran confusion en material de tipos.

> Zárate? Who is this Zárate?
>
> Let us recognize that in our time, a time of uniformity and a physical and moral leveling process, generic types have become outworn and that, in the slow twilight of the old world, those traits represented by large portions of the human family—classes, groups, moral categories—are gradually disappearing. Persons born more than twenty years ago, for instance, can remember perfectly that a real military type used to exist, and that every warrior who had been seasoned in the civil wars proclaimed his status by his martial appearance, even though he wore civilian clothes. There were many other types, "ringers for each other" as is popularly said, established by very particular conformations of the human countenance and by ways of behaving and dressing. The miser, for example, had the traits and facial characteristics of his caste and could not be confused with any other kind of man, and the same can be said of the "Don Juan" type, either those who aim high or those who expend their efforts on servant girls and nursemaids. And the exaggeratedly pious person had a face, and a way of walking, and clothing, that were like no others, and the same sort of characterization could be observed in those who sucked human blood, moneylenders, vampires, etc. All this is gone now, and scarcely any types are left who betray the class to which they belong, unless it be bullfighters. Mannerism is disappearing from the world scene, which is probably a good thing for art, and nowadays no one knows who anyone is except by studying the question carefully, family by family and person by person.
>
> This tendency toward uniformity—connected to some degree by the great progress humanity is in process of achieving, with the progress of industry and even with the lowering of tariffs, which has made good clothing more common and cheaper—has caused great confusion in the matter of types. [12]

To be sure, Galdós will go on to propose new kinds of character types, emerging from the levelling democratization of the new bourgeois society and the symbolic integration of the older aristocracy. But it is rather with Torquemada that we can grasp this process more concretely (indeed, the character to whose presentation all this is a kind of introduction—Zárate—is himself something of the instrument of Torquemada's transformation). First, we must think back to the literary antecedents: without going as far back as Molière, we need only confront the larger-than-life usurer who is Balzac's Gobseck, with his terrifying yellow tiger's eyes (characteristically, Balzac transforms him into a source of wisdom).

The story of Galdós's Torquemada, however, comes closer to Molière's "*bourgeois gentilhomme*," for among other things, the eponymous

[12] *Torquemada en el Purgatoria.* (1894) Benito Pérez Galdós, *Obras Completas*, tomo V Madrid: Aguilar, 1967, 1040. *Torquemada*, trans. F. M. López-Morillas, New York: Columbia University Press, 1986, 265–6.

novels show him learning cultivated language, dressing appropriately for his fortune and status in society, and inhabiting a mansion with his now noble family; indeed, the climax of the series is a ridiculously ornate speech which he delivers to the high society of Madrid. All of this Galdós characterizes as "the metamorphosis that has changed the very nature of metaphysical usury, rendering it positivistic."[13] And Casalduero quite rightly describes this change as the evolution from mercantilism (and value calculated in terms of gold) to finance capitalism in its fully developed senses, "from the figure of the usurer to that of the great modern financier."[14] But from our present perspective, this evolution is also an allegory of the evolution of the novel from the Balzacian system to the Galdósian, and from a network of novels in which, according to the famous *retour des personnages*, potentially any minor character can become a protagonist of a novel or tale in his own right, to the new Galdósian system in which even the protagonists are in reality minor characters, and their return as such reveals the new formal truth of their apparent "protagonicity."

(And what of Galdós's other villains if it comes to that? There remains the dissolute priest of *Tormento*, a source of universal harm, for example, and of trouble if there ever was one, under the guise of a voluble and seductive, self-pitying and unquenchably demanding suitor: he reminds me of Fyodor Karamazov in his sudden, unwanted and unexpected reappearances, but above all of the incomparable Jules Berry, in his ultimate role as the newspaper editor in Jean Renoir's epic of the Popular Front, *Le crime de M. Lange* [1936]. Here evil has been transformed into the appearance of evil, its sensory and theatrical attributes, its infinite gestuality: everything it might have meant and done in an older world like that of Balzac, it now shows in the present—"Essence must appear!" as someone once said; but only minor characters have essences!)

These formal developments in Galdós, coming at the end of the nineteenth century and at the climax of the development of its most characteristic form (along with opera), reflect two distinct and opposing trends or tendencies which miraculously complement each other.

[13] *Fortunata y Jacinta*, trans. Agnes Marcy Gullon, 8.

[14] Joaquín Casalduero, *Vida y Obra de Galdós*, Madrid: Gredos, 1970, 115; and see also Carlos Blanco Aguinaga, "De Vencedores y vencidos en la restauracion," in *De Restauracion a Restauracion*, Seville: Benacimiento, 2007, as well as the relevant pages of his *Historia social de la literatura espanola*, with Julio Rodríguez Puértolas and Iris M. Zavala, Madrid: Castalia, 1978.

On the one hand, with the nascent public sphere, there is an increasing fatigue with plot and with the standard narrative paradigms—that is to say, not merely with the chronicles of world-historical figures, but also with the destinies of protagonists generally in whatever form. The repertory of récits (freshened by music in the opera—all those adaptations of Sir Walter Scott's novels!) is no longer so attractive in the longer and longer narrative forms, where the experience of the everyday has begun to assert its claims on our interest and our attentions. The nineteenth century, indeed, may be characterized as the era of the triumph of everyday life, and of the hegemony of its categories everywhere, over the rarer and more exceptional moments of heroic deeds and "extreme situations." The end of Wagner's *Ring* is a virtual parable of the process: the protagonists—gods and heroes alike—all disappear, whether immolated in their conflagration or killed off by one another according to the logic of the curse they have brought upon themselves, leaving behind them nothing but the human world of all the others, the secondary characters and hitherto minor figures, who will now have to find some other form in which to tell their stories: "From the ruins of the fallen hall," Wagner tells us, "the men and women watch, moved to the very depths of their being, as the glow from the fire grows in the sky."[15]

At the same time, another tendency is at work in bourgeois society, and that is social equality. It would be remarkable if this trend, whose other face is what we call individualism, did not leave its traces on the form of the novel as well. And thus we find George Eliot interrupting herself as she patiently follows the events and reactions that define her protagonist Dorothea, and famously crying out:

> But why always Dorothea? Was her point of view the only possible one with regard to this marriage? I protest against all our interest, all our effort, at understanding being given to the young skins that look blooming in spite of trouble; for these too will get faded, and will know the other and more eating griefs which we are helping to neglect. In spite of the blinking eyes and white moles objectionable to Celia, and the want of muscular curve which was morally painful to Sir James, Mr. Casaubon had an intense consciousness within him, and was spiritually a-hungered like the rest of us.[16]

[15] Stewart Spencer and Barry Millington, *Wagner's Ring: A Companion*, London: Thames and Hudson, 1993, 351. Chéreau's centennial production at Bayreuth restores the sense of this ending, when, after the conflagration, the assembled townspeople turn and face the audience.

[16] George Eliot, *Middlemarch*, London: Penguin, 1994, 278 (chapter 29).

It will be objected that George Eliot is here merely seeking to reestablish the protagonicity of a figure hitherto minor and caricatured from the outside. But this attempt at justice and at equal rights for all her characters will not only be pursued further by Galdós, but will also take new and revealing forms in her own work, where they have to do with vocation and with success or failure. She, for whom novel writing was not a profession in the continental sense and for whom the sublime and unclassifiable role of the Poet had been replaced by that—not yet fully codified—of the literary intellectual, had a keen sense of vocation (the secularized version of the Protestant *Beruf* or "calling") which was quite different from the professionalism of a Zola, even though it addressed the same problem of the differentiation of society into new kinds of métiers. For she took the matter at its onset, in the very moment of the discovery of the vocation, which she daringly assimilated to passion and to the *coup de foudre*: "we are not afraid of telling over and over again how a man comes to fall in love with a woman."[17] This novelist's implicit boast is therefore that she will now expand the very conception of passion to include the lightning bolt of the vocation itself. In Balzac, such discoveries were the feverish dawn of the great obsessions and manias; in Zola, when successful, they are more akin to the first stirrings of the artist's creativity (as witness not only Octave's invention of the department store, comparable to Zola's own invention of the Rougon-Macquart project itself, but not excluding Saccard's speculative drives, both sinister and Utopian). Eliot's notion then cuts across the traditional epic alternative—love and war—but it also cuts across that of private and public, and in our own time, between science and the "humanities." Her subtle account, in chapter 15, of the complex preconditions for this concrete vocation (state of medicine, relationship to practice, provincial life, etc.) shows that the narrative category of the vocation can accommodate and organize all kinds of local and empirical narrative data as well.

Meanwhile, it also modifies what can be counted as the outcome of such a vocational destiny, already complicated in advance (as everywhere else) by the emergence of money as the unassimilable element. In Balzac, the alternative remained the simple one of success or failure: the former included fame and fortune ("*à nous deux, Paris!*"), the latter catastrophe, as in the case of poor Lucien (Rastignac, it will be

[17] Ibid., 144.

remembered, becomes prime minister). Zola perpetuates this tradition, where failure is accompanied by even greater and more explosive physical catastrophe (even though, in one of the most delicate of his political touches, we glimpse the shadow of the defeated and physically debilitated Napoleon III behind his bedroom curtain, on his way to exile);[18] while success—Octave again!—leads directly on into the wish fulfillments of the bestsellers.

(We may here open a parenthesis on the effacement of protagonicity implicit in Georg Lukács' discussion of "world-historical figures" in *The Historical Novel*: the discussion is in reality a contribution to historiographic debates of the period, in which Lukács was not himself involved and of which he may have had no particular knowledge, namely the crusade of the *Annales* school against the dynastic tradition of history writing and historical narrative, which was essentially a story of the kings and queens and the achievements of the great, that is to say individuals, who are grasped in our own spirit of the word as the protagonists of historical actions and narratives. As is well known, he believes that such figures must always be seen from the outside and in the distance, save for historical dramas in which, virtually by the definition of theatrical form and performance, they are necessarily seen without interiority, even where they are at the center of the action. For in the theater there can be no question of empathy or point of view, and Lukács' requirement is thus here preserved as well, that world-historical figures must remain minor characters. This withdrawal of protagonicity thus confirms our sense of the formal tendency in which realism is moving in this respect, but it adds something useful to it: namely the historiographic context in which a whole new theory of history is emerging in which such individualism is no longer meaningful. Lukács' diagnosis is astute enough to register the compensation for this withdrawal in the rise of romantic or hero-worshipping biography as a mass-cultural attempt to reinstate protagonicity, as it were in another place and another genre.)

As for the others, Tolstoy's heroes withdraw back into the landowner's country estates, outside society and history, to pass their days in dealing with recalcitrant peasants and projects of agricultural reform;[19] while Galdós's people simply sink back into the modest world of Madrid society, where they are received with comfortable

[18] *La débacle*, Paris: Gallimard, 1892 (La Pleiade, Vol. V).

[19] See his obviously autobiographical story, *Metel* (1856).

and amiable irony. The story of these figures is then that of abdication: they renounce their right to be protagonists of the novel and now cheerfully or with resignation accept their democratic future in the new world of secondary characters as such.

This is of course Lydgate's "destiny" as well (to lose his right to a destiny); and we must also remember that Dorothea has a vocation as well, even though—that of the Saint Theresa evoked in the opening and closing pages of *Middlemarch* alike—it can have no modern name or professional status. But for Eliot this development (a personal dénouement which is also the resolution of a novelistic form-problem) is only apparently to be considered a failure and a loss of fame: or rather it is on those very categories themselves that the work of the novel is to be expended, transforming them into something else, that is to say, their newly theorized position in the "web" of the social totality, of the social interrelationships. Here, it is no longer significant that such former protagonists (including Lydgate as well as Dorothea) "lived faithfully a hidden life," in the memorable last words of the novel, "and rest in unvisited tombs." *Middlemarch* was written, not so much to celebrate or to elegize those forgotten agents as it was to describe the process whereby their protagonicity was slowly dissolved in the name of a very different conception of the social totality, thereby also allowing this last to be represented in one final form, before it becomes so vast as to demand a different kind of evocation—as the presence of an enormous and omnipresent absence, rather than an empirical entity we can still barely glimpse.

(But we must not leave this topic without some final word on Lydgate and the scientific vocation, which can only be compared to the destiny of Zola's Dr. Pascal: both also still, like Balzac's madman Balthasar Claes, in search of the philosopher's stone, the ultimate alchemical element. Lydgate searches for "the primitive tissue" which holds the complex heterogeneity of the individual organs together in an organic totality: he fails in this, and we know that the narrative unity of the web is not to be found in its individual substances or anything they share with one another, but rather with that far less tangible thing, which is sheer relationship. But as we have already seen in an earlier chapter, Dr. Pascal succeeds, for he has been able to isolate, not the totality itself, but the very force of affect which makes the realistic novel possible as a totality in the first place.)

In that case, Dr. Pascal becomes yet another form of the secondary character, namely the author himself: for like Estupiñá at the other

end of the characterological ladder, this eponymous figure comes, by virtue of his all-encompassing knowledge of society—like Zola himself he has researched all the family members of the preceding novels of the series—the afterimage of another new bourgeois vocation, namely that of the professional writer. Indeed, modernism may be said to emerge when the writers of literature begin to resist their assimilation with this professional figure—the poets, who are the direct ancestors of the "great modernists," were never fully assimilated into it in the first place—and claim the supplementary status of a return to "calling" and to genius as such. But even in realism, autoreferentiality emerges in these more elusive signatures of the novelist within his own cast of characters.

Galdós, for example, slyly inserts himself twice over into his novels: first in the nameless first person who went to school with Juanito or met someone else at the club; and then in the delirious novelist and man of letters Ido del Sagrario, who everywhere erupts, turning the prosaic events of the novel in question into the most shamelessly fantastic and commercial fantasies, very much in literary emulation of the paradigmatic Quijote himself. The characters then, including the author(s), now all become minor or secondary, reorganizing themselves into Hegel's "*geistiges Tierreich*"—the zoology of the human differentiation by trades and métiers: a collection in which, however, the professional novelist must take his place alongside everyone else as a minor character.

Still, even with the waning of protagonicity and the more democratic mass assimilation of novelistic characters to the levelling of the minor or the secondary, there remains one actantial exception, and it is a narrative anomaly to which George Eliot's work will most usefully draw attention.

Chapter VI

George Eliot and *Mauvaise Foi*

So even with this structural and as it were evolutionary change in the status of the characters (or perhaps it would be better to say, in our distance from them), there remains one actantial feature that, surviving from out of a distant narrative past, continues to seem indispensable for plot as such: this is something like the other face of the protagonist, namely the villain, the agent of conflict and opposition, the hero's obstacle and the enemy of desire. We recall that the villain remains fundamental to Propp's analysis of the structure of the fairy tale. This function is assuredly distinct from the possibilities of local or minor resistance which this or that secondary character may be capable of offering; yet it is not to be grasped as symmetrical with that of the hero or protagonist either (as when Satan is affirmed as the "true hero" of *Paradise Lost*), even though it does seem possible in most cases to imagine a revisionist work in which the former villain becomes the protagonist of some new revisionary narrative.[1] In some ways, indeed, the villain's function (I continue to use Propp's technical language) would seem to rest on simpler foundations and presuppositions—to operate on the basis of a simpler category—than the innumerable protagonists of literary history, insofar as the sympathy or identification the latter generate (two philosophically vexed and socially extremely problematic processes in their own right) are socially and historically varied and can range from admiration for physical prowess (the *Iliad*) to a fellow-feeling for lovers, a satisfaction in the efforts of the underdog, a respect for genuine innocence, an energizing collective vision of the traits of a given culture hero, and so on.

[1] Thus the hero of the *Niebelungenlied*, the warrior Hagen, has become the villain of Wagner's *Ring*.

But perhaps in fact this situation is less contingent and less complex than what such historical contexts might suggest; perhaps indeed it is simply dependent on the point of view constructed by the narrative voice and lens, so that whoever is given as the initial subject—observer or participant—will project an "identification" and a protagonicity which only a good deal of irony—internal as well as external—can undo. In that case, protagonicity is simply a function of narrative structure, and that of the opponent or villain will follow suit and equally be identified positionally.

But this is where the dissymmetry of the two figures comes in; and I must feel that the narrative position of the villain rests on a very different categorial basis than this positional one of the hero, which I am willing provisionally to accept (at least until the onset of the dissolution we have described in the previous chapter). For the actantial role of the villain necessarily presupposes and depends on a preexisting binary opposition between good and evil (which does not come into play for the hero or heroine: Dorothea is after all not Saint Teresa).

The binary opposition between good and evil is a most peculiar opposition indeed, about which one might well claim that it is the fundamental binary opposition as such, the one that generates all those other innumerable oppositions at work in life and thought, from masculine/feminine to black and white, from intellect versus emotion to the one and the many, from nature and culture to master and slave (by the same token any number of ideologies claiming in their turn to interpret and to derive it from one of these secondary oppositions taken as its deeper underlying cause, as we shall indeed do here).

The ethical binary is nonetheless unusual and powerful insofar as it is a social opposition which can be and generally is expressed in individual terms, absorbing the eudaimonic and the body (pleasure and pain) as its code of expression and organizing the opposition of self and other as its principal terrain of struggle. It can be appropriated by the most complex theologies and philosophies and at the same time serve the mechanism of folk culture and popular entertainment. It is, finally, in my judgement, the object of an immense tendential deconstruction in modern times which can be seen as the last stage in the secular struggle against religion and superstition as well as the most fundamental political drive towards democratization.

But the ethical binary is also, as philosophers from Nietzsche to Sartre and Foucault have insisted, an immense swindle. Nietzsche's

genealogy of morals, arguing from philology, finds the origin of this opposition in social class, in the disdain of the feudal or military elite for the commoners (in middle French the "villains"). By way of the latter's slave religion, Christianity, the commoners then reappropriate this class system and reverse it, undermining and punishing the class enemy by pronouncing strength and violence evil and weakness and humility good. This is a plausible account, but required supplementation by contemporary philosophy, which diagnoses the very concept of evil as a "thought of the other": for Sartre (and for Foucault in a somewhat different way) the good is the center and evil is the marginalized other. It is in the very nature of this phenomenology, then, that the self cannot originally and virtually by definition feel itself to be evil:[2] that is a judgement on me that must necessarily come from the outside and be interiorized as a judgement of other people I perpetuate within myself. The widespread existence, not only of shame but above all of guilt, is enough to testify that such an interiorization is structurally possible; yet the very diagnosis of the social function of the ethical binary necessarily goes hand in hand with the will to eradicate it from a democratic society in which there are to be no "others" in this sense, and in which the category of evil, as it lives on in psycho-social ideologies such as racism and sexism, no longer functions.

The form problem for the novel lies in the very source of the villain's evil as a concept of otherness. The stage villain is all exterior, and can declare his essential villainy as largely as he likes, in spoken language and in gesture. Even the villains of epic must declare themselves in soliloquy: "Which way I fly is Hell; myself am Hell"; "Evil, be thou my Good!"[3] But that is, indeed, the philosophical conundrum par excellence, namely how my "good" could ever be evil. For philosophy, indeed, all evil must be "radical evil," in Kant's sense, evil done for evil's sake;[4] we do it because we like it; a boot in the face for a thousand years! Diagnoses such as those of sadism—clinical attempts to explain radical evil—are all symptoms of the historical dissatisfaction with the ethical binary and the fruitless attempts to replace it with

[2] Sartre's monumental *Saint Genet* is in fact dedicated to demonstrating this paradox.

[3] John Milton, *Paradise Lost*, book iv, lines 75 and 110.

[4] Kant's reasoning on the subject is to be found in *Religion within the Limits of Reason Alone* (1793), trans. T. M. Greene and H. H. Hudson, New York: Harper, 1960; an interesting contemporary discussion of this text is to be found in *Radical Evil*, ed. Joan Copjec, London: Verso, 1996. One may still wonder what difference there can be between radical evil and evil *tout court*.

something else, with motivations drawn from some other system. Perhaps, indeed, only Spinoza's notion of the "sad passions" (along with Nietzsche's of *ressentiment*) count as truly philosophically inventive attempts to square this circle and to produce a concept of evil which is self-motivating and does not depend on a motor force from outside itself, which is to say an explanation still mired in the otherness it was meant to account for in the first place.

For the novel and its progressively enlarging explorations of the inwardness of its characters, then, the representational problem arises in the contradiction between such thought of the other and the self to which it is to be attributed. Contemporary writers have evolved a technical solution to this problem which will be discussed it our penultimate chapter; but in classical narrative the success of representations of villainy as it were "from the inside" has been exceedingly limited. Indeed, one thinks of only a single supreme example; and even here one hesitates to characterize the most remarkable serial killer in all literature, Musil's Moosbrugger, as a "villain," inasmuch as the author has narrated his crimes in the mode of a drop in niveau, a psychic lowering and confusion which cancels them out as crimes in the first place and corresponds to what the lawyers call diminished responsibility.[5]

There thus remains for the serious novelist only the excuse of sheer obsession. How else to explain the characteristic power of Thackeray's Mr. Osbourne, who on the strength of his son's mismatch refuses to acknowledge his daughter-in-law and grandson and pursues the marriage with a hatred as it were beyond the grave:

> It seemed a humiliation to old Osborne to think that his son, an English gentleman, a captain in the famous British army, should not be found worthy to lie in ground where mere foreigners were buried. Which of us is there can tell how much vanity lurks in our warmest regard for others, and how selfish our love is? Old Osborne did not speculate much on the mingled nature of his feelings, and how his instinct and selfishness were combating together. He firmly believed that everything he did was right, that he ought on all occasions to have his own way—and like the sting of a wasp or serpent his hatred rushed out armed and poisonous against anything like opposition. He was proud of his hatred as of everything else. Always to be right, always to trample forward, and never to doubt, are not these the great qualities with which dulness takes the lead in the world?[6]

[5] Robert Musil, *Der Mann ohne Eigenschaften*, Hamburg: Rowohlt, 1952. See especially Book I, chapter 18.

[6] Thackeray, *Vanity Fair*, London: Penguin, 1985, 421.

But Mr. Osbourne is scarcely to be classified as a villain either, even though he functions like one in the narrative; and indeed the whole technique derives from an earlier aesthetic, which I will call allegorical, and in which the psychology of the passions is staged as a gradual possession of the entire personality, a concentration in which the human subject is gradually invested to the point of becoming the very personification of the passion itself: thus Spenser's poor Malbecco, whose wife has gone to live among "the jolly Satyres." He becomes a "hollow shell," a veritable insect, withdrawing into a cave, eaten away by his passion:

> Yet can he never dye, but dying lives,
> And doth himselfe with sorrow new sustaine,
> That death and life attonce unto him gives.
> And painefull pleasure turnes to pleasing pain.
> There dwels he ever, miserable swain,
> Hatefull both to him selfe, and every wight;
> Where he through privy griefe, and horrour vain,
> Is woxen so deform'd, that he has quight
> Forgot he was a man, and *Gealosie* is hight.[7]

Here passion or emotion lose their defining characteristics and become pure reification as such, as it were underscoring the very dynamic of the traditional system, for which the word "psychological" is anachronistic, inasmuch as this system opens up a development in which at least tendentially all passions, all obsessions, are the same.

These obsessives are therefore no longer true villains; Spinoza's theory of the sad passions explains them away and leaves only pity in the place that fear should have occupied. Such representations then reinsert "evil" as a unique category of otherness back into a system of named emotions of which, henceforth reified, each one stands as an allegory and thereby challenges the novel, and realism itself, to dissolve it into relationality. In this sense, then, the novel's most fundamental impulse resists psychology as a system (this was the spirit of our earlier analysis of the affect that comes to replace the named emotions), and the word "psychological" must be used with great care in the characterization of even the most seemingly introspective kinds of narrative discourse.

Nietzsche, to be sure, delighted in his self-ascribed mission as a "psychologist": but he meant thereby the genealogical act that unmasked

[7] Spenser, *The Faerie Queene*, Book Three, Canto X, Stanza 60.

and discredited conventional systems of the classification of passions and the various ethical and moral methods devised to deal with them. His aim was not to construct some new and more satisfactory system of psychology (a construction going on all around him in his academic contemporaries whose research founded a whole new discipline), but rather to altogether preempt and destroy all such emergent forms of introspective reification. It is a program we can best grasp by way of the hostile analysis (by one of Nietzsche's modern followers) of a characteristic passage on the "psychology" of love in a text by the most illustrious of modern novelists (and "psychologists"):

> As soon as the desire to take her away from everyone else was no longer added to his love by jealousy, that love became again a taste for the sensations which Odette's person gave him ... And this pleasure different from all others had ended by creating in him a need of her.[8]

It is true that Proust astutely describes this process as a kind of chemistry ("after having created jealousy out of his love, he began to manufacture tenderness, pity for Odette"), so that the whole passage might well be taken as an elaborate figure. What it reveals, however, is that all such psychological description is in fact figural, positing a "symbolic chemistry" (Sartre) whose reified "elements," separated from each other on the chart or system of the former passions, can only somehow "interact" as "the cloud of cream 'added' to the coffee," (to borrow Sartre's famous analysis). It is, he concludes, "a mechanistic interpretation of the psychic," without adding that virtually all modern psychological descriptions rehearse the same kind of chemical analogy.[9]

For Sartre, then, Proustian "psychology" is to be grasped as a reifying operation in which meaningful acts (it will be remembered that Sartre's own phenomenological theory of the emotions grasps them as intentional forms of behavior)[10] are rewritten as things or substances. In the present book we have emphasized the reification of emotions implicit in the very process of naming as such, as well as the way in which invariably such named emotions then come to form systems, albeit systems which vary according to their historical and cultural

[8] Marcel Proust, "Swann in Love," quoted in Jean-Paul Sartre, *Being and Nothingness*, trans. Hazel Barnes, New York: Washington Square Press, 1956 [1943], 235.

[9] Ibid., 235–6.

[10] *Esquisse d'une theorie des émotions*, Paris: Hermann, 1939.

moments (so that Aristotle's is distinguishable from Descartes', and the latter's from the system of named emotions presupposed by contemporary academic psychology or neuroscience).

Nietzsche's own pathbreaking (historical, genealogical) analyses took as their fundamental target a rather different ideological operation, namely (as his famous title suggests) morality and moralizing as such, something which will swiftly be identified as the ethical binary of good and evil. It is not irrelevant in our present context to remember that one of his choicest objects of critique was the novelist George Eliot (and behind her, the English tradition in general). This was, indeed, by way of returning the favor, since of all nineteenth-century English thinkers Eliot was the one to whom German philosophy meant the most and on whom it had the greatest impact (her literary career began, in effect, with her translation of David Strauss's *Life of Jesus*, which in effect conjoined the German philosophical tradition with the Victorian ethical commitment to religion).

And it is certain that no reader of George Eliot can escape the feeling that her pages are obsessively devoted to an intricate moralizing of the most minute psychological reactions and perturbations. It will therefore seem perverse to argue, as I will, that the moralizing style with which she renders and represents inner movements and reactions can in fact be identified as a strategy for weakening the hold of ethical systems and values as such, and ultimately as a move consistent with modern denunciations of the ethical binary very much in the spirit of Nietzsche or Sartre.

The argument would begin with the archaizing habit of her style, in which what look like psychological explanations are conveyed in the form of folk wisdom and pseudo-proverbial sagacity: the deeper ideological intent here is, I believe, to affirm historical continuity (as against the radical breaks of modernity) as well as to integrate a deeper affirmation of the "people" and the abiding spirit of the yeoman farmer (in a rather different strategy from that of Leavis or a Raymond Williams). This is an essentially political choice which can be seen either as explaining or as resulting from her ideological distaste for overt political practice[11] (as most openly in *Felix Holt*). But this political or anti-political instinct can only be fully assessed in relationship to her conception of community as such.

[11] See my discussion of the political ontology of realism in "The Experiments of Time," below, in the present volume.

This conception is in fact a figural one, insofar as the very content of the novels explicitly details the historical disintegration of the traditional communities, and the political thinking of the period is not yet in a position to conceptualize that "*peuple à venir*" evoked by Deleuze. Yet her famous image of "the web" is a little more complex than mere picture-thinking and in fact constitutes the space in which we can identify a logic of dereification very much in Sartre's spirit. For it emphasizes relationality over substance: the "individual lots," the individual human lives or destinies, are meaningful only in terms of their interrelations, which make up a totality, however local:

> I at least have so much to do in unravelling certain human lots, and seeing how they were woven and interwoven, that all the light I can command must be concentrated on this particular web, and not dispersed over that tempting range of relevancies called the universe.[12]

The philosophical subtlety of the image lies not only in its displacement of attention from the individual (reified) item to its relationship with all the others, but also and above all, as David Ferris has so powerfully demonstrated, in its inevitably deconstructive (or indeed dialectical) function.[13] For one is a part of the web whether included or excluded; disjunction is relationship fully as much as positive interaction. Everything is a part, even when it affirms its individuality against an oppressive whole. This omnipresent collectivity persisting beneath the appearance of fragmentation and disintegration in concrete social life no doubt constitutes a deeper ideological excuse for the abstention from overt and intentional projects of change on the political level; but it also reinforces the decentering and gradual equalization of life on the social one, which we have emphasized in the preceding chapter as a kind of narrative democratization, a waning of protagonicity and a foregrounding of secondary characters as such. For weaving knows no hierarchy, whatever momentary centers the web may seem to throw up; and the tendency of Eliot's novels (particularly the later ones) to have multiple centers, corresponding to multiple "protagonists," is only the outward symptom of this process.

Still, this is the moment at which the question of evil and the form-problem of villains must fatally return. For it is no longer with the

[12] Quoted in David Ferris, *Theory and the Evasion of History*, Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1994, 222–3.

[13] Ibid., 184–90.

centrality of heroes and heroines that we need be concerned here, but rather with Eliot's other moralizing project (in fact identical with Nietzsche's anti-moralizing one), namely her intent to persuade us that there are no villains and that evil does not exist.

This startling proposition is perhaps better grasped in the light of its solution; and no one has expressed it more concisely than her great admirer Proust, who understands her to demonstrate "que le mal que nous faisons est le mal (nous faisons du mal à nous et aux autres), et qu'au contraire le mal qui nous arrive est souvent la condition d'un plus grand bien que Dieu voulait nous faire."[14] The insight is dependent on the ambiguity of the French word "*le mal*," which means evil and harm at one and the same time: "Evil is the evil we do—harm to ourselves and to other people—while the evil (harm, misfortune) that happens to us is often the condition for some greater good God has had in mind for us." It is a formulation which has the added advantage of including that providential turn of Eliot's imagination discussed elsewhere in this book,[15] while at the same time conveying that "*rayonnement*" or benign or malignant emanation, the infection of good and evil, that so many realists attempted to convey in the great webs of collective interrelationship their narratives work to construct.

To grasp the originality of Eliot's solution to the form-problem of the villain or of what we may call "represented evil," we may briefly turn to her first novel, *Adam Bede*, in which one of the great paradigms of eighteenth-century class conflict is again rehearsed. This is the seduction of a peasant or even a bourgeois girl by an aristocratic figure, which results most often in the disaster of pregnancy. Gretchen is indeed executed for this "crime" in Goethe's *Faust*, while the most villainous of such seducers, Richardson's Lovelace, is responsible for Clarissa's death (an abstracted and concentrated version of this "evil" is then dramatized in *Les Liaisons dangereuses*, which Gide thought the greatest novel in the language, for reasons that might be convincingly argued from our present context). Biology can most often be appealed to for the ethical palliation of such "evils"; but guilt must still be dealt with, and Arthur's reflections here may serve as a starting point for what is in Eliot a remarkable new way of dealing with evil as such:

[14] Marcel Proust, "Sur George Eliot," in *Contre Sainte-Beuve*, Paris: Gallimard, 1971, 657.

[15] See "The Experiments of Time" below.

> Gone a little too far perhaps in flirtation, but another man in his place would have acted much worse; and no harm would come—no harm *should* come, for the next time he was alone with Hetty, he would explain to her that she must not think seriously of him or of what had passed. It was necessary to Arthur, you perceive, to be satisfied with himself; uncomfortable thoughts must be got rid of by good intentions for the future, which can be formed so rapidly that he had time to be uncomfortable and to become easy again before Mr. Peyser's slow speech was finished, and when it was time for him to speak he was quite lighthearted.[16]

For the problem lies not so much with the act itself, as with the way in which the subject can be understood to have chosen to be evil, when by definition "evil" is a judgement and a characterization that can only be assigned to the other. Arthur's thoughts may so far be taken as a fairly conventional sort of self-justification, something which it will be important to grasp in the context of an interiorized argument in which one replies to the indictments of other people and of external judges: such replies are then most often made in what we call bad faith.

How this conventional representation unexpectedly develops in George Eliot's work we may then observe in what is often thought to be her transitional novel, her one historical novel *Romola* (1862), which separates the first more rural and nostalgic novels from *Middlemarch* and *Daniel Deronda*. It would be misleading to call *Romola* her only historical novel, as all the others are set in a more recent, yet carefully dated past; yet it is certainly her only costume drama along the lines designed by Sir Walter Scott and conforming to at least two of his principles: 1) the background of a world-historical, generally revolutionary event (in this case the short-lived revolution of Savonarola in Florence); and 2) the inclusion of historical figures familiar from the manuals whose recognition in the novel in question provokes a satisfaction of its own (in flesh and blood: so this is what she looked like, what he sounded like, etc.), a reaction comparable to the present-day passing glimpse of a celebrity in the street. In this case, in the era of the Grand Tour and the first Baedekers, there is also the satisfaction of seeing your favorite Florentine historical streets and monuments as it were set in historical motion and recreated complete with their bustling original casts (George Eliot has done her research very thoroughly indeed, and not only on the scholarly level).

[16] George Eliot, *Adam Bede*, London: Penguin, 1985, 265.

This book is not a favorite with the public today, whose interest in the Italian Renaissance has diminished, and whose appetite for philosophical and aesthetic debate and for intellectual history in general, insofar as it exists at all, has found other channels. Yet Henry James thought *Romola* was "on the whole the finest thing she wrote,"[17] and the astute selection of the historical situation, in Pocock's "Machiavellian moment," shows a keen sense of political significance, even if she fails to shed any new light on the paradoxical emergence of a religious and even millenarian interlude within the most productive constitutional experiment in the West.

Romola is also, as Scott's new genre required, the most melodramatic of all George Eliot's novels and thereby worthy of especial attention in our present context. Yet the complex plot is less interesting than the destiny of one of the protagonists, who is not, paradoxically, the eponymous heroine. Of the three ultimate fates of the nineteenth-century woman (assuming the failure of her marriage), namely renunciation (*Eugénie Grandet*), death (*Madame Bovary*), or sainthood (*Fortunata y Jacinta*), Romola is awarded the last (which might of course uncharitably be seen as the synthesis of the first two). She is for the most part a witness rather than an actor, and one is almost tempted to reprise Leavis's judgement on *Daniel Deronda* and suggest that the novel can in its layers be prised apart into two distinct and uneven narratives: in this case, however, it is the man's story which is far and away the most original one. James himself indeed found this character, Romola's young Greek husband Tito Melema, the most tantalizing figure in the novel, and had this to say about his unique dilemmas:

> In Tito we have a picture of that depression of the moral tone by falsity and self-indulgence, which gradually evokes on every side of the subject some implacable claim, to be avoided or propitiated. At last all his unpaid debts join issue before him, and he finds the path of life a hideous blind alley.[18]

It is a true Jamesian subject, perhaps more stark and violent than anything the author himself ever undertook.

The implication that Tito and his drama constitute the central plot line of the novel finds confirmation in Romola's concluding summing up:

[17] Henry James, *Literary Criticism, Volume II: European Writers; Prefaces to the New York Edition*, New York: Library of America, 1984, 1006.

[18] Ibid., 931.

> There was a man to whom I was very near, so that I could see a great deal of his life, who made almost every one fond of him, for he was young, and clever, and beautiful, and his manners to all were gentle and kind. I believe when I first knew him, he never thought of anything cruel or base. But because he tried to slip away from everything that was unpleasant, and cared for nothing else so much as his own safety, he came at last to commit some of the basest deeds—such as make men infamous. He denied his father, and left him to misery; he betrayed every trust that was reposed in him, that he might keep himself safe and get rich and prosperous. Yet calamity overtook him.[19]

We will come back to this judgement later on, which seems to exonerate Tito from much that is villainous in the role he plays in the plot, selling her father's monumental library (we are here in full Humanism), betraying the Savonarolan experiment and conspiring with the Medicean counterrevolution, and finally bringing destruction on his own father (and on himself in the process).

But Romola's excuses are not at all what was meant by the weakening of melodramatic trappings here; and if that were all that was wanted we might have proposed a kind of Freudian splitting in the way in which the attractive son has been separated from the ferocious father, a former humanist whom Tito has abandoned to Turkish captivity and who returns in the form of a veritable allegory of old-style Elizabethan vengeance (only a chance military venture has freed him to search out and punish his guilty son). But Tito does feel guilt (without remorse) and he is also anxious to conceal this episode (and other equally shameful ones later on) from his virtuous spouse. A good deal of psychological complexity is thus to be found here, and it is in the dynamics of that complexity, rather than in her assignment of what are relatively conventional motivations, that the originality of George Eliot's novelistic solution is to be found.

We must begin its examination by declining the terms of Romola's own explanation, which we have just read and which she shares with the author, who tells us that Tito "had simply chosen to make life easy to himself—to carry his human lot, if possible, in such a way that it should pinch him nowhere" (219). "And the choice had," adds the novelist in George Eliot, "at various times, landed him in unexpected positions."

These positions, indeed, will make up the novel's plots, but the reproach of a lack of strenuousness and self-discipline will lead on

[19] George Eliot, *Romola*, London: J. M. Dent, 1907, p. 566. Hereafter all page numbers in the text refer to this edition.

into something worse: "What, looked at closely," thinks Tito, "was the end of all life, but to extract the utmost sum of pleasure?" (113). This lazy hedonism is then quite enough, for minds possessed of the Protestant ethic, to account for whatever corruptions destiny has in store for Tito: but it is not enough to make the character interesting, and indeed, if it does not seem enough to qualify him for the role of the villain in melodrama, there remain enough other stock parts available for an innocent misled into this or that reprehensible deed. But Tito's character is a little too complicated for that stock role as well.

Still, we may begin with this "innocence," this blank slate on which George Eliot will begin to write something new. It is first of all an innocence for other people, as Sartre might put it: "gentle and kind," as we are told in Eliot's summary; or, following the impression of another minor character, "it was not less true that Tito had movements of kindliness towards her apart from any contemplated gain to himself" (293). Indeed, from the very first page (where we begin the novel with Tito's arrival in Florence) his joyousness and charm, his sympathies and good impulses, are underscored at some length.[20]

What happens to these qualities is then unexpected: first, he becomes a type, but a new type, not altogether unknown in nineteenth-century realism (see, for example, the ubiquitous Dobbin of *Vanity Fair*), but one relatively untheorized and certainly unnamed in the way Eliot does it: "His face wore that bland liveliness, as far removed from excitability as from heaviness or gloom, which marks the companion popular alike amongst men and women—the companion who is never obtrusive or noisy from uneasy vanity or excessive animal spirits, and whose brow is never contracted by resentment or indignation" (83–4). In short, the minor character par excellence, except for the fact that this minor character is the protagonist.

What becomes of this curious modulation of Tito's initial innocence is then even more curious: the handsome blandness of his features slowly becomes negative; the lack of vanity, resentment, indignation now becomes a more suspect expressionlessness:

> On the day of San Giovanni it was already three weeks ago that Tito had handed his florins to Cennini, and we have seen that as he set out towards the Via de' Bardi he showed all the outward signs of a mind at ease. How should it be otherwise? He never jarred with what was immediately around him, and his nature was too joyous, too unapprehensive, for the hidden and the distant to grasp him in the shape of a dread. As he turned out of the hot sunshine into the shelter of a narrow street, took off the black cloth berretta, or simple cap with upturned lappet, which just crowned his brown curls, pushing his hair and tossing his head backward to court the colder air, there was no brand of duplicity on his brow; neither was there any stamp of candour: it was simply a finely formed, square, smooth young brow. And the slow absent glance he cast around at the upper windows of the houses had neither more dissimulation in it, nor more ingenuousness, than belongs to a youthful well-opened eyelid with its unwearied breadth of gaze; to perfectly pellucid lenses; to the undimmed dark of a rich brown iris; and to pure cerulean-tinted angle of whiteness streaked with the delicate shadows of long eyelashes. Was it that Tito's face attracted or repelled according to the mental attitude of the observer? Was it a cypher with more than one key? The strong, unmistakable expression in his whole air and person was a negative one, and it was perfectly veracious; it declared the absence of any uneasy claim, any restless vanity, and it made the admiration that followed him as he passed among the troop of holiday-makers a thoroughly willing tribute. (100)

[20] He is also given an attractive physique: "Tito's bright face showed its rich-tinted beauty without any rivalry of color above his black sajo or tunic reaching to the knees. It seemed like a wreath of spring, dropped suddenly in Romola's young but wintry life" (57).

And now, by some peculiar dialectical transformation within the novel's raw material itself, this indifference of Tito's features, their expressionlessness, which the description certifies to be "veracious," turns out to be the very expression of secretiveness and concealment itself:

> Tito had an innate love of reticence—let us say a talent for it—which acted, as other motives do, without any conscious motive, and, like all people to whom concealment is easy, he would now and then conceal something which had as little the nature of a secret as the fact that he had seen a flight of crows. (92)

Thus, by a mysterious alchemy known only to Eliot herself, the joyous openness of the innocent youth has been transformed by a touch of the wand into a suspect secretiveness and a propensity for concealment (and thereby for intrigue and conspiracy) which will not long wait for the appropriate context. Indeed, it is never altogether clear which comes first, the secret or the secretiveness, or perhaps this is in the very nature of this particular vice (and its concrete existence as a habit, or as what habit itself perpetuates and nourishes). But with this we are already within the multiplicity of Tito's motives alluded to earlier: he does not feel like saving his father (this is itself already a feeling that has been overdetermined); while now he does not want Romola to know about this betrayal (and for purposes of

the plot, it will be her long-lost brother, become a monk, who brings him positive news of his father's captivity which will then infallibly be transmitted to her once the brother realizes his identity, etc.). But this particular secret has been multiplied in other areas (such is indeed the inevitable consequence of the "channel" deepened by so many "little rills of selfishness"); Tito has rescued a peasant girl and found her a lodging—all quite innocently, but inexplicably undivulged to his spouse; he has also sold her father's library, something she is bound to find out about; and his numerous friendships have led him into relationships which in the current revolutionary situation cannot but take on a political, and thereby conspiratorial, function, thereby securing for him the guilt of the overthrow and execution of Savonarola.

This multiplicity of sins and secrets is in the very nature of George Eliot's conception of the nature of what was formerly called evil:

> Under every guilty secret there is hidden a brood of guilty wishes, whose unwholesome infecting life is cherished by the darkness. The contaminating effects of deeds often lies less in the commission than in the consequent adjustment of our desires—the enlistment of our self-interest on the side of falsity; as, on the other hand, the purifying influence of public confession springs from the fact, that by it the hope in lies is for ever swept away, and the soul recovers the noble attitude of simplicity. (99)

The notion of infection is no doubt also part and parcel of a late Victorian episteme (Marc Angenot's discussion of the period's medical obsessions is illuminating):[21] in this instance, however, it is also the other face of what is perhaps the most luminous vision in her late work of the providential web, the way in which the good is also infectious, and radiates outward across the network of social relations (at least those of the traditional community).[22]

But in the present instance, the immediate result of this multiplicity is quite different. On the one hand, all these multiple motivations not only perpetuate each other, but reciprocally ensure each other's existence. It is preferable, indeed, to state this peculiar consequence in a negative way, by insisting on the way in which each one prevents the other from being removed or neutralized. But she says it much better: "He had made it impossible that he should not from henceforth

[21] On the ideological rhetoric of disease and infection, see Marc Angenot, *1889*, Longueuil, Quebec: Le Préambule, 1989; see also my discussion of this remarkable book in the *Ideologies of Theory*.

[22] See "The Experiments of Time" below.

desire it to be the truth that his father was dead; impossible that he should not be tempted to baseness rather than that the precise facts of his conduct should not remain for ever concealed" (99).

A remarkable construction of negatives, achieved by Tito's own inner efforts—by his own free choice, Sartre would say, albeit a choice that remains unknown to him. Yet how can one's free choice remain unknown to one's self?

The answer lies in Eliot's narrative anticipation of what is only much later theorized as a philosophical concept, namely Sartre's notion of *mauvaise foi* or bad faith. The technical expression is borrowed from daily life and in particular from those disputes in which one of the interlocutors (or even both, as the case may be) produces one after the other reasons and demonstrations palpably in contradiction with one another for the sole purpose of winning the argument (and not even of persuading himself, since he henceforth no longer believes in any of those reasons and demonstrations). In Sartrean bad faith, this argument is interiorized, and consists in a struggle against my "being-for-another," namely the trauma of my image in other people's eyes which I am powerless to modify.

It is this mechanism which, in the absence of anything like a Freudian notion of the unconscious, must be grasped against the background of the phenomenological theory of consciousness as an essentially impersonal state which for that very reason cannot *be* anything, whether good or evil. These attributes are then somehow related to the construction of the self, an object for that impersonal consciousness. For Sartre, therefore, it becomes a paradox and a fundamental philosophical problem how and why any consciousness would judge itself to be evil, would even go so far (in cases of "radical evil") to affirm itself as such ("Evil, be thou my good!"). For, as we have already suggested, evil is a judgement rendered from the outside, a sentence passed on the Other: in order to feel myself as evil, I must have interiorized that judgement in a way that remains to be explained.

Sartre's critique of this concept therefore faces technical difficulties more complex than those confronted by his great predecessors (or competitors) in this problematic—Spinoza with his notion of the "sad passions" and Nietzsche with his idea of "*ressentiment*." Sartre's is an ontology and must for that reason somehow show how an entity which has no being (or has the being of not-being)—namely human reality or *Dasein*—can convince itself of its possession of that attribute of being which is badness or evil; and we speak here not of

hypocrisy or the feigning of appearances, as when a villain pretends to be good and righteous, but rather of the deep and agonizing inner conviction of being wrong, sinful, born to do harm, cursed by sheer otherness and outcast from the society of the righteous. (Presumably a similar drama would lie in wait for those who are persuaded of their own goodness; yet here hypocrisy does seem to propose itself more insistently, even though, as in the contemporary instance of "celebrity," positive judgements by other people can no doubt be no less traumatic. Sartre's own "self-sequestration" in later life would seem to have been his own solution to just such a trauma.)

In any case, this interiorization of an external judgement is explicitly registered here in *Romola*.

"This first distinct colloquy with himself" (99): so George Eliot names and dates Tito's initial pangs of conscience, as they are traditionally termed; and we will suggest that this moment is also the one in which George Eliot invents the concept of mauvaise foi avant la lettre. We here illustrate the discovery with Tito in order to mark the emergence of the new... shall we call it "technique"? (For I will later on want to discuss it on the level with "*style indirect libre*" and point of view as an alternative means of representation.) Yet it comes into its own only in the great moments in *Middlemarch*, in the agonies of Casaubon and Bulstrode; and recedes again somewhat in *Daniel Deronda*, where for reasons yet to be suggested, Grandcourt marks something of a return to the old-fashioned romantic—and I may even say eighteenth-century—villain. Casaubon and Bulstrode are, so to speak, former villains: and what they do and do not do for the plot in that status forms the supreme proof and example of that dissolution of melodrama I am here arguing for, with all its results for the classic form of novelistic realism which it fulfills and undermines at one and the same time.

"Colloquy with himself": Eliot here betrays traces of her Hegelianism with this positing of an initial moment of self-consciousness ("I = I," as Hegel terms it), in which the self becomes divided and confronts itself in some novel and fresh, historically new mode of awareness, one which seems to mimic and to reproduce the encounter of two separate individuals with each other. (Hegel indeed describes it that way, in the famous encounter of what will become the Master and the Slave; an encounter which comes first and phenomenologically precedes the inner split as which the subsequent "self-consciousness," whatever that may be, is described).

At any rate, it is clear that for Sartre (the source of the well-known Lacanian "split subject") the word "self" will be technically quite inappropriate and misleading for such a description (and in the preceding paragraph), inasmuch as self-consciousness does not proceed from some doubling within the self but can rather better be characterized as the very production of the self as such. Self-consciousness is my way of dealing with that "object for consciousness" which is the self, and which I can live, Sartre says, in shame or in pride, but which is not really me, in the sense in which the "me" in question is an utterly impersonal consciousness which cannot *be* anything in the strong sense, nor can it have any properties or characteristics which might occasion shame or its opposite.[23] Such impersonal consciousness could never feel itself to be evil (or good) inasmuch as it cannot feel itself to *be* the way things (or other people) are, to have attributes to which we might attach such adjectives in the first place. What impersonal consciousness can feel is the unjustifiability of its existence.

So mauvaise foi in this respect will involve a peculiar kind of inner prestidigitation, in which I manage to talk myself into *being* something: the process seems to involve speed—I must work very fast indeed in order to prevent the whole construction from falling apart (Sartre's description in *Saint Genet*, a veritable case study of this kind of construction), in order to confuse myself into momentarily believing the things I want to affirm or deny about myself. Self-justification? Yes, in a sense; and yet it is about my very self that I have to affirm the matter, and although the self may well be imaginary (in the Lacanian sense) or a mere object of consciousness (in Sartre's), it is nonetheless real and something I can scarcely my whole life long do away with. Sartre has had the terminological good fortune to find a technical term in the language of everyday situations, so that (like Hegel's notion of self-consciousness) it has an interpersonal relationship sedimented within what looks like a philosophical nomenclature.

This ambiguity entitles us to insist on the representational, rather than the philosophical, nature of Sartre's concept. It is organized around a dualism we can express in any number of ways: facticity versus freedom, matter and spirit, what can't be changed and what can, thing and process, or finally, the body and consciousness. But we must

[23] Already outlined in Sartre's first philosophical work, *La Transcendance de l'Ego*, Paris: Vrin, 1936.

also understand that representationally, the Sartrean demonstration is staged as a confrontation between a judge and a defendant (whether these are embodied in separate individuals or within a single mind); and also that, as befitting an ontology, the accusation is couched in terms of being. The casuistry of the defendant, then, his mauvaise foi or bad faith, consists in shifting the terms of the accusation back and forth across this basic dualism which is human reality. To the accusation of betrayal, then, the subject replies that he has indeed done this or that, but that he is not a traitor in the way in which things (facticity) *are*; and that he is always free to change and to become something different (to become loyal or trustworthy). To which the judge replies that he knows that the defendant is not ontologically untrustworthy in the manner of the being of things, and that we have here to do with freely chosen acts rather than essences and static properties or qualities; and yet the judge remains convinced that the defendant will nonetheless never change and become anything other than a traitor.[24] And so an endless, impossible argument continues, which is in mauvaise foi reproduced within the mind of the character seeking self-justification and claiming that it is always within his power to change and to become someone different. Sartre also insists on the tempo of this inner argument, which must rotate from one term to the other with such dizzying rapidity that the subject is himself never able to grasp the deceitfulness of this ontological double standard: and the speed of this flight is tantamount for Sartre to the unconscious as such. "In bad faith there is neither cynical lie nor knowing preparation for deceitful concepts ... the first act of bad faith is to flee what it cannot flee, to flee what it is."[25]

Sartre's characters, then, taking mauvaise foi here as a representation of consciousness rather than a philosophical concept, tend to couch their arguments with themselves at a high philosophical and ontological level, one not particularly appropriate to the more traditional religious vocabulary of sin, shame and guilt which would have been available to any of George Eliot's characters. In the latter's "colloquys with self," that nimble leaping back and forth between two incompatible alternatives which is mauvaise foi tends to take the form of a substitution of incompatible motives, which is why I have insisted above on the structural significance of a multiplicity of such

[24] *Being and Nothingness*, trans. Hazel Barnes, Part One, Chapter Two.
[25] Ibid., 115–6.

motives in Eliot's novels. Guilt can indeed be evaded by playing these motives off against each other rapidly enough for each one to excuse the other. Thus betrayal can be justified by the need for secrecy, secretiveness and lying by the shamefulness of the betrayal, and so forth. It is a demanding process, something one must keep in constant circulation all the time, not without its affinities with Brecht's unhappy demon: "the swollen veins of his forehead testifying to the effort it takes to be evil."

And this is why the procedure, whether in real life or in its representation, is no longer adequate for the construction of those genuine villains on which the structure of melodrama depends. In Sartrean terms, we might have said that there can be no villains because no one can *be* evil as a thing is (brown, solid, heavy, large or whatever); even though anyone can freely commit evil acts (something with obvious consequences for any Sartrean politics, which must replace moralizing judgements with the act of commitment [*engagement*]).

Eliot is perhaps more Spinozan in her insistence on the toll of psychic misery to be exacted by the "sad passions." Yet, this is precisely what allows her to resolve her fundamental form-problem: how to prevent the denial of the category of evil from leaving her with a sanitized world, an idyllic fantasy à la Rousseau or Bernardin de Saint-Pierre, in which all her characters have no other recourse than to be "good" in the most uninteresting fashion. To neutralize the effects of her own pedagogical and moralizing temperament, to steer a course between the two formal alternatives of melodrama and the most saccharine Utopian fantasies—this is Eliot's fundamental technical dilemma, and one to whose triumphant solution, after the crucial experiment of Tito in *Romola*, the characters of Casaubon and Bulstrode in *Middlemarch* offer remarkable testimony.

We cannot deal with them in the detail they deserve: suffice it to say that they incarnate the two types of oppression to which George Eliot was the most sensitive—the first, that of women, and the second, that of money: and the context of their respective dramas having the added advantage of allowing her, in the first case, to raise the issue of intellectuals, and in the second, of religion. Meanwhile, their contrast also allows of another ironic contrast, namely the common fate reserved for failure and success alike, when both are lived in bad faith.

Mr. Casaubon's misery, no doubt, finds its occasion in the failure of the great work, indeed its impossibility (and the bad totalization projected by the Key to All Mythologies is perhaps the caricature

and distorted mirror image of Eliot's own achieved totalization in *Middlemarch* itself). But in reality it finds its deeper source in the intersection of two other feelings (if we may hastily call them that), which the traditional psychology of the named or reified emotions ordinarily terms vanity and jealousy.

Both are complicated; and the first is no doubt related to the great project and to the "morbid consciousness" related to it "that others did not give him the place which he had not demonstrably merited"[26] (417). But this wounded vanity crystallizes around the sense that Dorothea does not herself give him that place, and indeed that he has underrated her intelligence, which now houses itself within his mind as a place of implacable, inescapable judgement on him.

The other feeling is a more conventional and not unjustified jealousy for Will Ladislaw and the interest he has palpably awakened in Dorothea. "Suspicion and jealousy of Will Ladislaw's intentions, suspicion and jealousy of Dorothea's impressions, were constantly at their weaving work" (419). The point is that either of these preoccupations might well, if only briefly and intermittently, lead to moments of self-lucidity for Casaubon, moments in which mauvaise foi might have given way to self-knowledge. But the ruse of mauvaise foi lies in the way in which each obsession then excuses itself on the grounds of the other, turning round in that inexhaustible perpetual motion we have already identified.

As for Mr. Bulstrode, his case has more to do with deeds than with suspicions: indeed, it bears an uncanny resemblance to Tito's situation, in the existence of a long-lost relative thought to be dead and the moral laziness with which Bulstrode justifies his failure to follow up the traces of this claimant on his fortune as well as the secrecy with which he keeps his wife ignorant of the matter, and of his own culpability. The whole situation is then overdetermined by the shameful origin of the fortune (usury) as well as by the consolations of self-righteousness provided by his religion, neither of which particularly obtain in Tito's case. Still, Eliot goes out of her way to distinguish this complex and agonizing state of mind from simple hypocrisy:

> The spiritual kind of rescue was a genuine need with him. There may be coarse hypocrites, who consciously affect beliefs and emotions for the sake of gulling the world, but Bulstrode was not one of them. He was simply a man whose desires had been stronger than his theoretic beliefs, and who had gradually explained the gratification of his desires into satisfactory agreement with those beliefs. If this be hypocrisy, it is a process which shows itself occasionally in us all, to whatever confession we belong, and whether we believe in the future perfection of our race or in the nearest date fixed for the end of the world; whether we regard the earth as a putrefying nidus for a saved remnant, including ourselves, or have a passionate belief in the solidarity of mankind.
>
> The service he could do to the cause of religion had been through life the ground he alleged to himself for his choice of action: it had been the motive which he had poured out in his prayers. Who would use money and position better than he meant to use them? Who could surpass him in self-abhorrence and exaltation of God's cause? And to Mr. Bulstrode God's cause was something distinct from his own rectitude of conduct: it enforced a discrimination of God's enemies, who were to be used merely as instruments, and whom it would be well if possible to keep out of money and consequent influence. Also, profitable investments in trades where the power of the prince of this world showed its most active devices, became sanctified by a right application of the profits in the hands of God's servant. (419)

[26] George Eliot, *Middlemarch*, London: Penguin, 1994, 417.

This is the point, before moving on to consider the survival of melodramatic elements in George Eliot, to open a terminological digression which will also be relevant for topics discussed in Chapter VIII, most notably *style indirect libre* and point of view.

We can stage the problem dramatically by asking our question in this form: is mauvaise foi, which we have found to be a specific narrative mode (however occasionally or rarely put to use), to be called a narrative technique? In a technological age like our own it is clear that words like "technique" or "method" arouse their own kind of suspicion and vigilance; they seem at once to reify their content, the procedure they seek to describe or name, and by the same token they tend to transform their content, the narrative material which they organize and distribute, into a kind of industrial raw material, which can be processed by certain technical methods alone (or which at least convey a kind of progress in the invention of ever newer and more efficient technical methods). In this respect, it cannot be said that what we have called mauvaise foi was a very successful innovation; examples of its later use are infrequent; meanwhile the systems of reified or named emotions it was supposed to neutralize certainly returned with a vengeance and are very much with us.

Meanwhile, the very notion of a technique standardizes all these literary procedures, and accounts for the surprise we may feel when a formation like mauvaise foi is ranged in the same category of that of *style indirect libre* (and indeed, when the latter is considered on the

same level as point of view, as we will be doing in Chapter VIII). The empirical classification systems implicit in such technological thinking at once exclude the kinds of dialectical comparisons opened up by focusing on the philosophical, or better still, the phenomenological meanings of such "techniques," on the way they organize experience, and the rivalry they pose with other comparable forms of the organization of experience. The very fact that mauvaise foi as such takes its origin in the production of a philosophical concept testifies that both meaning and the nature of the raw material (experience) have been omitted from notions of technique or method.

On the other hand, the exclusion of the latter permits the text in question to slip back into pure conceptuality and the promotion of ideological or didactic theses, the history of ideas, or the specific storehouse of idiosyncratic opinions and values of the writer in question. Both faces of the textual object, then—its production as a specific moment of narrative production (of the solution of a narrative problem) and its phenomenological and ideological content—need to figure in any adequate theorization of the object in question.

Indeed, such language then raises yet a third dimension that needs to be present in our account, and that is its coherence and density as a particular kind of discursive object, which can be identified as such (and thus itself named and theorized). Such is the implication of terms like *style indirect libre* or point of view: their very presence can be detected at certain moments of the narrative discourse, allowing them to be studied as structural phenomena, and not only as symptomal production or historical ideology.

This is indeed one of the sources of effectivity of recent French theory, to have sought to name such objectal states, whether as *appareils*, *agencements*, *dispositifs*, and the like—words which have the advantage of professing a certain materialism in the approach (the objects so named are not mere ideas, nor are they mere technical skills), at the same time that their connotations suggest combination, and the conjuncture of various features of complex machinery. (Of the few German equivalents, we may compare Heidegger's notion of the *Gestell* or standing reserve, meant to convey a conception of how the forces of nature are appropriated and stored.) These seemingly technical terms borrowed from the age of industrial machinery are unrelated to the earlier conceptuality of technique and method, if only because the latter imply a far greater activity on the part of the human agent or manager. What we may call the machinic notions,

many of them derived from or in cinema theory, presuppose a wellnigh physical apparatus such as the camera or the projector, which are interposed between the narrative and the human agent; I believe that it is proper to separate the latter's know-how decisively from the objectal status of the object in question (which may be linguistic or narrative as the case may be).

Cinema theory has obviously been attractive in what it seems to furnish of a scientific or at least technological objectivity; only a few "literary techniques" have seemed to lend themselves to this kind of approach, even though the critic and analyst may so often yearn for equipment of this empirical and objective type. At any rate, I believe we have said enough to posit at least three dimensions which need to be present and satisfied or fulfilled in any "technical" discussion of this kind; in other words, which need somehow to be theorized in their mutual interrelationship. Those three dimensions are then 1) the object as a technique; 2) the object as a phenomenological meaning; and finally 3) the object as a kind of apparatus.

But we have still not named that "object" with the kind of specificity it demands; I propose, without much hope of any general consensus on the matter, to call it a "narrative formation." Mauvaise foi is thus a narrative formation among others, and yet to put it this way is also to glimpse a shadowy fourth dimension beyond the ones we have already discussed, namely its function in a given historical situation. What is this particular narrative formation for? Why has it been evolved? What is its function or purpose?

But at least in this instance we know the answer to these questions: mauvaise foi exists in order to undermine the ethical binary and to discredit the metaphysical and moral ideologies of evil at the same time that the latter's uses in plot formation and construction are replaced with at least some rough equivalent.

Chapter VII

Realism and the Dissolution of Genre

1.

We have not yet done, however, with evil. For the problem of the villain is not only a philosophical one, nor even one of subjectivity and representation, but also one of plot itself and of those codified narrative structures we call genres. To be sure, there has been a long-standing and desultory debate about whether the novel itself should be classified as a genre in its own right: its differentiation from the lyric, the dramatic and the epic would seem to be decisive, and yet also peculiarly dialectical, insofar as (not only for Lukács and Bakhtin) the novel has seemed to be a very different kind of animal from those, and something peculiarly associated with a modernity from which most of the earlier triad have waned. Meanwhile, however, we often speak of sub-genres of the novel, such as the letter novel or the mystery story, a usage which would seem to return us to some generic genus of which those are the species. This is indeed the feature that will interest us here and motivate us to dismiss the entire terminological debate by simply calling these last the "genres" of the novel as such, genres which not only disappear under modernism, but whose disappearance indeed is at one with their construction and emergence in realism itself, as I will show in the present chapter.

So there is a perspective in which the problem of the villain can now be rethought in terms of just such genres or kinds of the novel itself; at which point it is transformed into a different kind of discussion, namely that of melodrama, and predictably brings with it a new set of terminological confusions which seem uncannily to mirror the old ones of generic classification. Early on, we counted melodrama among the numerous foils (such as romance or modernism) against

which realism was often defined. Now, however, we must admit that all these oppositions are somehow also internal: and that (to take the inaugural moment itself) realism is opposed to romance only because it carries it within itself and must somehow dissolve it in order to become its antithesis: the *Quijote* is a laborious work on the romance it still contains, and the later Spanish tradition[1] might cause us to wonder whether the dissolution of romance leaves us with something radically different or merely with an *Aufhebung* of the impulse onto a higher and perhaps unrecognizable level.

Here at any rate we are confronted with innumerable projects and research programs, insofar as each consequent realization will demand analysis in its own right as well as an experimental laboratory of its own in which to inspect the processes at work in the slow purgation of that reified generic structure with which it is threatened. The analysis is then immeasurably complicated by the supplementary requirement that it also register the way in which the novel in question must first construct the structure whose dismantling is the primary work of its narration in the first place.

Melodrama might offer some first key insofar as its villain is quintessentially a prototype of those marked characters and destinies we earlier associated with the récit as such. In this sense, melodrama—and perhaps the other novelistic genres or sub-genres with which we are about to associate it—can be identified with that narrative impulse in whose quintessential struggle and inseparability with its affective opposite number we saw the very emergence of realism (or of the novel as such). The mission of affect in that case would lie in the very weakening of the melodramatic structure, the gradual effacement of the villain (as we have just observed it in George Eliot), and the systematic dismantling of its rhetoric, its specific address to the audience and the demands it makes on their reactions—terror, pity, fear and sympathy, breathless anticipation, and the like. In this sense, melodrama might also be theorized as the literary equivalent of that "theatricality" in painting which Michael Fried opposed to the

[1] One notes in Spain, particularly after 1898, the emergence of all kinds of "philosophies of the Quijote" (Ortega, Unamuno) and evocations of the "Cervantine," in which even the shape of the master's sentences project a whole *Lebensphilosophie*: I know of nothing comparable in any other nation's literature. Meanwhile, it would be ill-advised to underestimate Cervantes's literary impact down through the ages: all of Galdós, for example, is suffused with the fundamental themes of the *Quijote*.

turning away from the audience of its figures and the abandonment of its rhetorical appeals to their emotions.[2]

Is Fried's "absorption" then to be identified with what we have been calling affect, or does it result in the end of realism altogether and the emergence of modernism and of non-figuration? Such questions would also lead us into the multiple meanings and uses of the term "melodrama" itself, which we have associated almost exclusively with the villain and the narrative of evil. But Fried's terminology reminds us that melodrama can also be associated with the theatrical as such, both in its origins in drama and it its afterlife in silent movie acting (along with a parallel existence in music, as its etymology suggests; and particularly in opera and its arias, and thereby in a whole aesthetics of expression closely linked to the system of named emotions).[3] Meanwhile, contemporary film theory[4] and production has thrown up what seems to be yet another influential usage in the genre of sentimental film organized around women's films—Douglas Sirk—and that return of the lachrymose so closely identified with its eighteenth-century form.

Yet the very notion of a dissolution of melodrama can clearly enough take as many forms as melodrama itself does; and the current chapter can scarcely claim even to theorize those, let alone explore them. Thus, if melodrama is taken to be a mode whose essence is theatricality, paths and approaches are thrown open which lead to the problem of rhetoric on the one hand and to the evolution of painting on the other. The denunciation of rhetoric in emergent modernism is already present in the repudiation by Wordsworth and Coleridge of allegory and decoration in the language of the ancien régime; and perhaps the florid acting of opera and the silent film deriving from theatrical texts may also be ranged under this category, which seeks first and foremost to make an effect on its public. Unexpectedly,

[2] Michael Fried, *Absorption and Theatricality*, Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1988. We should also note the implications of this position for modernism (Fried, *Art and Objecthood: Essays and Reviews*, Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1998) as well as its return in unexpected contemporary practices such as that of photography (Fried, *Why Photography Matters as Art as Never Before*, New Haven: Yale University Press, 2008).

[3] The classic work on the meaning of melodrama is that of Peter Brooks, *The Melodramatic Imagination*, New Haven: Yale University Press, 1995.

[4] Here, the inaugural text is that of Thomas Elsaesser, "Tales of Sound and Fury," in *Movies and Methods*, Volume II, ed. Bill Nichols, Berkeley: University of California Press, 1985.

then, Michael Fried will diagnose these same motives at work in eighteenth-century painting and in modernity as "conceptual art," and will identify what he calls absorption as the process of rejecting this equally rhetorical "theatricality." There is yet one final possible meaning of the word I wish to reserve for plot construction as such and to which I will return later in this chapter.

But let me now come at this question of genre from a very different perspective, namely from Auerbach's work on realism (quite different from this one). I have in mind the way in which Auerbach's notion of *sermo* and the three levels or modes of style can supplement and reinforce our argument about genre.[5] In fact, Auerbach's scheme is a simplified one, in which the high style of Roman rhetoric and the *sermo-humilis* that characterizes early Christian texts and that is based on the models of the New Testament open an intermediary space for a so-called mixed style. In his discussion of modern realism, then, of which the prototype is the analysis of *Madame Bovary*[6] which probably initiated the project of *Mimesis* (without, paradoxically, being included in it, save for a passing comment), the deployment of this mixed style is essentially defined by what it is meant to exclude or prevent in advance. We may translate Auerbach's enumeration of these stylistic exclusions in any number of other sets of terms—as modes or voice, as social points of view and distances taken, as tone, as preexisting rhetorical categories, and so forth: in fact we will here take them as the starting point for various genres and the opening up beyond them of a narrative discourse which is not a genre, namely what will become the realistic novel itself.

The excluded tones are conveniently summarized by Auerbach as follows: "the tone can be tragic, sentimental, idyllic, comical or burlesque."[7] The example of this new subject-matter, which eludes all of the above possibilities, is a scene in which Emma and Charles have a perfectly ordinary evening meal, through which Emma's nameless dissatisfactions are conveyed, ("*elle n'en pouvait plus*," "*toute l'amertume de l'existence*," etc.). Auerbach's list of possible alternative tones projects all the alternative genres in which the drama of such a scene might be staged: the high tragic dissatisfaction of Clytemnestra

[5] Erich Auerbach, *Literary Language and its Public in Late Latin Antiquity*, New York: Pantheon, 1965.

[6] Erich Auerbach, "On the Serious Imitation of the Everyday," in Flaubert, *Madame Bovary*, Norton Critical Editions, ed. Margaret Cohen, New York: Norton, 2005.

[7] Ibid., 427.

(on stage rather than in narrative prose) might there rub elbows with a peasant girl's idyllic yearning for an ideal lover very different from this one (something which in its turn is easily imaginable in terms of comedy—the eighteenth century—or even burlesque, from Shakespeare back to medieval fabliaux, etc.) All such genres, we might say, insist on the meaningfulness of the scene, whether tragic or comic: it is not only that it becomes easily classified literarily (and thereby socially) in genres which then reflect a conventional class differentiation of the situations in life and the status of the characters involved (higher than us, lower than us, as Frye might have put it).[8]

The more crucial point in Auerbach's differentiation of this "everyday" reality from all the other traditionally named and categorized situations lies precisely in the fact that there is no name for what this one represents, for it does not seem to convey any of the lofty metaphysical themes nor is it suitable for vaudeville humor, nor for idyllic distraction and restful contemplation either. The dinner scene (it contrasts both with the interrupted supper in *Manon*—a different chapter of *Mimesis*—and with the various lunches enumerated in Chapter I) is the occasion for a feeling of Emma's which escapes all easy categorization. It is not boredom in any strict sense, nor frustration, she does not as yet have any precise object of desire, she has not even worked out in her own mind the disillusionment Flaubert conveys by way of objective details.

But we have to be sure that we do not ourselves too readily identify this dissatisfaction after the fact, and add in diagnoses which, old or new, tend in advance to reify something it was the very intent and burden of Flaubert's art to leave unidentified—better still, to identify as being unidentifiable and unavailable in the first place. Thus, a new disease called "*bovarysme*" was named and described by Jules de Gaultier in 1892, long after the publication of Flaubert's novel; the case is interesting in as much as it would seem to ratify the disease itself as nameless in the very act naming it. More recently, Flaubert has rightly been celebrated as having discovered the way in which desire is itself shaped by its own representation in novels and other media, which displace some simple idea of (inner and outer) reality by a preexisting stereotype: Mme. Bovary is unsatisfied because she has read novels in which true satisfaction is supposed to exist (Girardian

[8] Northrop Frye, *The Anatomy of Criticism*, Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1957, 33–4.

mediation, other media theories all the way to poststructuralism).[9] But when this theme threatens to become a causal theory in its own right, it threatens the fragile equilibrium of the novel, which precisely takes affect, and the unnamable, as its fundamental subject.

It is therefore this flight from classification that Auerbach so brilliantly describes in his essay, then himself naming it with the words "everyday" and "existential." Insofar as one has nonetheless to talk about it, these words are as harmless as possible, since they designate the two faces of that unnamable thing which we have ourselves named as affect—the everyday as the outside, or *Stimmung*; the existential as the lived or inside, namely affect as such. The point is that both depend absolutely on the avoidance of genres which would tend to reify and thereby to explain this lived material by associating it with this or that prototype of a destiny which is enshrined in the plot-type of a specific genre.

It is precisely against just such a reification of destinies that the realist narrative apparatus is aimed, which reaffirms the singularity of the episodes to the point at which they can no longer fit into the narrative convention. That this is also a clash of aesthetic ideologies is made clear by the way in which older conceptions of destiny or fate are challenged by newer appeals to that equally ideological yet historically quite distinct notion of this or that "reality," in which social and historical material rise to the surface in the form of the singular or the contingent.

Such is then the way in which all the great realists have thought of their narrative operations as an intervention in the "superstitious" or religious, universalizing conceptions of life, and as the striking of a blow for truth ("reader, this is not a fiction") which is still part and parcel of the whole Enlightenment secularization of the world. But in each historical situation, the claim for truth will be a somewhat different one; the overall strategy or argument for realism in general and as such (the word only really enjoys a brief literary currency around the mid-point of the nineteenth century)[10] is nowhere near as durable and as powerful as its modernist equivalent, in which notions of formal innovation are able to be transferred from one generation

[9] René Girard's "mimetic desire" (*Desire, Deceit and the Novel*, Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1976) is only the most striking exemplification of this kind of theory, of which simulacrum theory and spectacle-society theory develop other aspects.

[10] With Duranty and the supporters of painters like Courbet.

to another over what turns out to have been a period of about a century.

But now it is time to observe that, despite this attack on the very system of the genres as the realists find it still in place when, in the early eighteenth century, they begin their work in various national situations, realism as a formal strategy gradually begins to form new genres in its own right: hardening over, as it were, in a few tale-types, genres which the novel sometimes inherits but most often invents or reinvents, in a process in which they serve as a scaffolding which must in turn be dismantled. It is a curious and dialectical process which may be identified as the increasing tension between universalism and particularity (or even singularity) in modern times, where the genre eventually comes to be identified as the universal and thereby the target of critical isolation and eventual demolition, particularly insofar as such genres work virtually by definition with social and ideological stereotypes. Any consequent realism will therefore aim formally at dispensing with such stereotypes, at penetrating to the unique situations, cityscapes and individuals which make up the reality of a given moment of language, nationality and history. Yet this is a drive that will eventually reveal itself as one of the sources of modernism, insofar as it seeks to arrive at this or that unique phenomenon which bears no recognizable name and thereby becomes utterly unrecognizable: names and the familiar are of course themselves humble forms of the universal, and stereotypes its disreputable family members. It is, if you prefer, a matter of repetition, and later on mass culture will inaugurate a whole aesthetic of repetition, based on that same generic recognition, which in Lukács' high theorization bore the characterization of the typical.[11]

But, returning to the temporal categories with which we began this whole analysis, we may also describe the process in terms of reification, where some new attention to scene and to the present proves incompatible with the reifications of the older tale or story types in which general images of the various shapes of a reified destiny were vehiculated. Thus the story or tale will select this or that reified turn of events—a comic quid pro quo, a tragic accident, an ironic outcome, the woman scorned, the braggart given his comeuppance,

[11] See Georg Lukács, *Writer and Critic*, London: Merlin, 1970; and *Studies in European Realism*, London: Merlin, 1972. It is important to add that for Lukács, the "typical" was what ultimately registered the subterranean movements of History itself and not the merely stereotypical.

and the like—as the reified narrative form along which to string a set of contingent exemplifications, in such a way that the actual story becomes predictable and even formulaic, motivating later realists (not to speak of the modernists themselves) to subvert and destroy those in their turns. Unfortunately, however, as the history of nominalism testifies, new universals always begin to form around the wreckage of the old ones, and what had deservedly been revealed to be unnamable inevitably gets named and generalized in its turn. Such are then the new plot-types that begin to emerge within realism itself and to be codified and marked in their turn for narrative deconstruction.

2.

Besides melodrama as such (considered as a genre), I will briefly touch on four more of the new genres or sub-genres characteristic of realism. These are the *Bildungsroman*, the historical novel, the novel of adultery, and naturalism—taking this last now as a new type of narrative, rather than as a perfectly natural and evolutionary expansion of realism itself.

The ideological hesitations and compromises of the *Bildungsroman* have been too extensively documented by Franco Moretti for me to have to dwell on here,[12] save to say that his analysis raises for me another question about realism which turns on its ontological commitment to the status quo as such. This is not so much an overt political commitment (although the personal conservatism of most of the great realist novelists can be demonstrated biographically) as it is an artistic one: realism requires a conviction as to the massive weight and persistence of the present as such, and an aesthetic need to avoid recognition of deep structural social change as such and of the deeper currents and contradictory tendencies within the social order. To posit the imminence of some thoroughgoing revolution in the social order itself is at once to disqualify those materials of the present which are the building blocks of narrative realism, for from the revolutionary perspective they become mere appearances or epiphenomena, transitory moments of history, a sham calm before the storm, habits which are merely those of an ephemeral social class and which are about to be swept away forever. Realism can accommodate

[12] Franco Moretti, *The Way of the World*, London: Verso, 2000.

images of social decadence and disintegration, as already in Balzac; but not this quite different sense of the ontology of the present as a swiftly running stream. I have argued elsewhere at some length[13] that this structural bias is visible in the satiric portraits all the great realists offer of intellectuals as such, a discrediting of all such radical commitments to history, to change and to social reform.

But the *Bildungsroman* also suggests a different reason for this unexpected reemergence of genre within a narrative mode seemingly dedicated to replacing such reified forms by a different kind of representation. For the young man of the *Bildungsroman* is as it were an instrument for the exploration of the new possibilities of bourgeois society, a kind of registering device, the establishment of a laboratory situation in which those possibilities can be acted out before our eyes. The protagonist is then not exactly a new social type, but rather a recurrent space in the new society which offers the way in for the new realist narrative.

The other three generic possibilities are to be regarded in the same way. The historical novel isolates the new sense of history emerging at the time of the French revolution, a historicity which determines the very emergence of modern historiography from the older chronicles and corresponds to the new dynamisms of capitalism after the industrial revolution. One can surely argue that all great realist novels are in some sense already historical ones: and Balzac's are already always situated in dated historical time as well as in a specific region or named space, while the others, even if they are not officially about past time, eventually become historical documents on the very strength of their ... dare I say it? ... realism.

Thus one can argue, as Lukács does,[14] that the realist novel is already itself profoundly historical, its new sense of everyday life now transforming the latter from the static sketches of custom or folkloric urban scenes into a sense of change—destruction, rebuilding, ruins, scaffolds, new and unrecognizable quarters, a feeling which will famously become ever more pronounced when one gets to Baudelaire and Haussmann (and Zola!). It is a feeling of change, already present, imminent, threatening, sometimes warmly anticipated, which will be underscored in any number of ways—debts accumulating and the interest fatally coming due, as everywhere from Balzac to Galdós; the

[13] See "The Experiments of Time" in this volume.

[14] See note 11 above, as well as Lukács, *The Historical Novel*, Lincoln: University of Nebraska Press, 1983.

crises of inflation; ageing and the generations (*La Cousine Bette*);[15] changes of regime; the notations of fashion (it being understood that change is inherent in the very concept of fashion): the external forces buffeting the stability of the married household and the domestic foyer. This is then the historicity already present and active within the new everyday, and offering the secondary stimuli of the narrative construction, impelling the central plot forward like an uneasy restless element through which it must move.

The historical novel as such and as a specific subgenre then constitutes something like a hypostasis of this inner historical reality: isolating the virus of historical change as though in a test tube and attaching this "history in a pure state" to something like the *images d'Epinal* which bourgeois households hang on their walls. The intersection between daily life and the great historical Event—most often political rather than economic—is one of the marks of the new historicity of the realist novel as already in Scott's *Waverley* (1811). It is as though the historical novel reverses this intersection and follows the historical Event through to the various intersections with private life rather than the other way round. This specialized form obviously has other determinants, which we cannot deal with here.[16]

As for the novel of adultery, Marcuse has observed[17] that it is the very space of negativity in nineteenth-century bourgeois life. Women, not yet fully absorbed into capitalism and the vehicles of unpaid labor, are more likely narrative occasions for revolt and resistance than men. The latter, unless they are young and dissatisfied (thereby becoming the narrative occasions for the *Bildungsroman*), are more likely to be absorbed into the dynamics of business, and by way of success to open up the paradigms of the mass-cultural bestseller, as in Zola's Octave (in *Au bonheur des dames*) or Maupassant's *Bel ami*. (Masculine failure is rather the province of naturalism, as we shall see in a moment.) But women cannot be successful in this sense (unless domestic contentment and satisfaction is considered to be something

[15] I hope the lamentable absence of any discussion of Balzac in the present work will be remedied by a reminder of the two chapters of my *The Political Unconscious* (Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 1981) on *La Cousine Bette* and *La Rabouilleuse* (*The Black Sheep*), respectively.

[16] But see "The Historical Novel Today," below, as well as Perry Anderson's provocative and stimulating survey of the history of this genre in "From Progress to Catastrophe," *London Review of Books* 33:15, July 2011.

[17] Herbert Marcuse, *Eros and Civilization*, New York: Routledge, 1987.

positive, at which point the woman character falls to the second rank of minor character and of Dickensian "angel of the hearth" or Mediterranean matriarch). The novel of adultery (taken in the largest sense) is thus a unique space in which the negation of the social order can be narrativized in the person of this other half of "mankind": it is paradoxical and even a contradiction that women figures, like the great dancers of nineteenth-century ballet, become the great stars of the nineteenth-century novel—only compare Madame Bovary to the ineffectual Frédéric, or Anna Karenina to the vacillating Pierre!—a situation in which the role of the adulteress becomes the negative or privative one of showing that there is no place for them in that bourgeois society whose representation was to have been the object of the novel in the first place!

As for naturalism, it will then be the literary slot assigned to the fourth great new player in nineteenth-century society—alongside the young man, the political "world-historical individual," and the woman, naturalism opens a space for the worker and along with him the more heterogeneous population of the "lower depths," of lumpen-proletarians and outcasts generally. The perspectival distortion of this new naturalist sub-genre can be measured by comparing naturalism with the sentimental accounts of the poor in Dickens or Victor Hugo, in which the threat of collective *déclassement* is not present (despite Dickens's own childhood trauma). Philanthropy and its pity and sympathy turn out to be quite distinct from this late-nineteenth-century panic as it confronts a sinister and radically different space. Yet is it appropriate to characterize naturalism as a sub-genre of realism? Certainly its relations with realism have been much debated, and as a form the category of the naturalist novel does not quite seem "on all fours" with that of realism: where the stereotype of the latter involves social observation and the detailed rendering of urban settings, the naturalist text, with its *nostalgie de la boue*, seems rather to breathe a kind of *Stimmung* or affect associated with pessimism or melancholy, to the point where Deleuze's association of naturalism (Norris's *McTeague*) with the surrealism of Buñuel, with its shuddering symptoms of the unconscious and of deep impersonal volcanic forces, offers a welcome twist on these old theoretical debates.[18]

But is the naturalist movement and the unique expressivity its texts seems to breathe to be associated with a specific plot-line in such a

[18] Gilles Deleuze, *Cinéma I*, Paris: Minuit, 1983, chapter 8.

way that it can be classified as a sub-genre? My proposition is that naturalism's various and quite distinct exemplifications all share in a more general narrative paradigm, which could be described as the trajectory of decline and failure, of something like an entropy on the level of the individual destiny. And this is a phenomenon to be sharply distinguished from whatever representations of death or finitude are to be found in the mainstream realist novels. For this falling curve of the naturalist narrative shares in that more general late-nineteenth-century ideology which Marc Angenot has described[19] as a simultaneous belief in progress and a conviction of decadence and of a well-nigh biological deterioration, which expresses itself socially in the panics about degeneracy and widespread decadence. Here a fundamental contradiction is articulated in which the dynamic of capitalism is registered as progress (in urbanism, technology, business, civilization) at the same time that the deepest social anxieties take the form of an omnipresent perception of entropy on all social levels.

It is important for the understanding of naturalism, however, to identify this curiously contradictory ideology as a class perspective, reflecting the bourgeoisie's doubts of its own hegemony and its fears of a rising working class, of immigration and the populations of the colonies, of the overwhelming competition from the other imperial nation-states, and finally of its own inner loss of nerve. What stands at the center of the naturalist narrative paradigm is the perspective of the bourgeoisie and its vision of the other (lower) classes. Nor is this a purely epistemological matter: for included in this collective "point of view" is a desperate fear, that of déclassement, of slipping down the painfully climbed slope of class position and business or monetary success, of falling back into the petty bourgeoisie and thence on into working class misery itself. Indeed, the very perspective of misery with which the observing bourgeoisie envelops its image of lower-class life (in naturalism almost indistinguishable from marginality) expresses that anxiety of immanent decadence and decline, the condition into which Gervaise sinks back and from which Hurstwood saves himself by suicide. This middle class and the way in which it realizes its fantasies in the form of a clear-cut narrative paradigm is a better and more striking example of the relationship between class and literature than any of the vaguer and more triumphalistic expressions of the trajectory of the "rising" class in the Balzacian success stories

[19] Marc Angenot, *1889*, Longueuil, Quebec: Le Préambule, 1989.

(themselves intermittent—Rastignac wins offstage, as it were—and carrying conviction only by the multiplicity of tales of failure that accompany them). For this reason, naturalism is far more class marked and localized than realism in general, and strikes the reader as far more specialized than the latter to the degree that the public no longer shares those particular fin-de-siécle terrors.

What the special case of naturalism also suggests is that, in an era of the differentiation of the various reading publics and of the increasing fragmentation of a general bourgeois reading public into a multiplicity of more specialized readerships (for whom the "niche" production of more differentiated sub-genres is designed), the other three basic realist narrative paradigms will themselves be reified and become more distinct sub-genres, with a tendency to find themselves degraded into mass-cultural forms and versions. At the same time, they become targets for the defamiliarizations of the various emergent modernisms, which stigmatize their conventions in the form of satire or absorb and sublimate their narratives into generalized allusions, transforming what were still narratives in the heyday of realism into so many synchronic literary connotations.

It is thus instructive to reread *Ulysses* as a compendium of these residual realist narrative lines and as an extraordinary new combinatory play with such residues. The presence of the *Bildungsroman* is the most obvious of these well-nigh extinct remanent forms, inasmuch as Joyce had explicitly walked Stephen through that form on his way to the brief teaching stint in Dalkey. We do not have to decide whether a later Stephen will fail in his pretentious *symboliste* literary ambitions or will on the contrary become Joyce himself, for the perspective of the single day radically interferes with the temporality of the older form which it effectively cancels, while leaving its negation behind as a trace.

It cannot be said that *Ulysses* is a parody of the *Bildungsroman* even if one takes the revisionist view that Stephen is a caricature and not to be estimated by his own manner of gravity and self-consciousness. Yet it is a diversion of that older form into a new combination, in which the novel of adultery is also inserted. Indeed, if supplied with the final point of view of Molly (and strengthened by the evidence of Brenda Maddox's *Nora*, which makes it clear that this book is not mere male writing but rather a collaboration in which Nora's own voice very much has its share), *Ulysses* can be seen as modernist afterimage of *Madame Bovary* itself. That Molly stands as a cruder (yet

more artistically gifted) version of the latter's protagonist, and Mr. Bloom a more comical yet more sympathetic version of Charles, may be obvious. But if one takes Blazes Boylan to be a version of Rodolphe and Stephen of Léon (always admitting that the latter's ultimate courtship is only realized in Molly's [and Bloom's] fantasies), then the entire complex of Flaubert's novel is as it were copied onto *Ulysses* and amalgamated into it in much the same way an old pair of blue jeans is pasted onto a Rauschenberg canvas; or better still, the way one photographic perspective is distorted by its anamorphic reproduction. Here the narrative of *Madame Bovary* has been projected onto another kind of plane surface, and the resultant segments then added into the new construction in various ways. It is as though Flaubert's realism survived in the form of a ruin, which a new (modernist) building then incorporated, as allusion, as memory, as museum piece, as derisory potsherd.

As for the historical novel, to be sure *Ulysses* is doubly a historical novel, in Joyce's own setting (eighteen years before publication) and for us, as a memorial to the pre-war colonial metropolis in general. But two dates mark it internally and externally: from the outside it is less the unexpected event of World War I which is unsuspected by the characters (but not by us), a war in which Irish regiments fought for the crown; but more especially that other utterly unanticipated event (in part itself a reaction against the War) which was the Easter Rising of 1916. Internally, deep history is embedded, not so much in Stephen's prehistory (which exists outside the book in other books, so that it can be taken by us as external historical fact), but also by the fitful glimpses of the Central European and Palestinian past of the Jews in Mr. Bloom's reveries.[20]

But what is centrally marked in the text as a different dimension of time is the anarchist violence of the Invincibles, the assassination in Phoenix Park twenty years earlier, which survives in the public sphere of gossip and rumor, and of folk memory, and is resurrected in the form of one of the ancient survivors of the guerrilla band, who makes an appearance in the cabman's shelter late at night and late in the book. Here history intersects, not with the present, but with the past—although it can be said that the governor general's procession (relayed by Woolf in the form of the king's limousine in *Mrs.*

[20] The non-Irish reader perhaps needs to be reminded of the precedent of Hungary, as described by Arthur Griffith in 1898 in *The Resurrection of Hungary: A Parallel for Ireland* (1904).

Dalloway) marks the imperial presence around which the administration of the colonial city, if not its real society, is organized. The newer postcolonial readings of *Ulysses* have served to translate it back into this sub-genre of the historical novel far more effectively than did the earlier standard mythical ones.

Naturalism, as we have said, is not exactly a sub-genre of realism, but Joyce's debt to the naturalists has often been evoked,[21] in the lower class status of most of his characters as well as in the uncensored urban detail and the journey through a nightmarish underworld or "*bas fonds*." I would myself prefer to evoke a naturalist perspective in the suggestions of a temporal prolongation and in Bloom's presentiment of his own future and decline, his own proletarianization (which I have discussed elsewhere).[22]

Such is then the afterlife of the sub-genres that emerge from realism and become visible in its breakdown. To be sure, Joyce was obliged to unify these remnants of the older synthesis by imposing a new and pseudo-mythic narrative structure (the *Odyssey* parallel) upon this heterogeneity in order to hold its multiplicities together.

Here genre is itself hypostasized and projected outside the novel by the *Odyssey* parallels: the synchronic structure of the single-day novel does not really allow us to read Stephen's brief contact with Bloom in any really familial or psychoanalytic way, whatever the latter's fantasies. That "theme" is, however, projected out of the novel into an unwritten narrative version, which is seized and absorbed by the Odysseus/Telemachus plot and as it were projected, reified, out into legend, much as humans were frozen and lifted into the stars' constellations in ancient times. The *Odyssey* parallel preserves the diachrony of these interpersonal situations, as it were *pour mémoire*, while we are reading and observing them in a quite different dimension: it is as though generic structure, no longer current or available, were acknowledged only as a memory from the distant epic past. And this is then a reified generic essence in which both later sub-genres of realism—the *Bildungsroman* and the novel of adultery—find their place, historicity itself floating above the text in the form of the ancient catastrophe of the Trojan War.

It is as though the idea of genre had taken the place of its practice in this ultimate moment; and that a series of powerful affective moments

[21] Harry Levin's pathbreaking *James Joyce* of 1942 described Ulysses as a synthesis of symbolism and naturalism.

[22] See my essay "Joyce or Proust?" in *The Modernist Papers*, London: Verso, 2007.

of an all-immersing present could only be unified—whether at the level of the chapter or the work itself—by way of an idea of unification symbolically concentrated in an ancient, classical, pre-novelistic form.

Yet perhaps another tendency—less a breakdown than a glimpse of some deeper textuality beneath the narrative forms—can be deduced both from Joyce's simultaneous narrativization and denarrativization of *Madame Bovary* and from Auerbach's initial reading of it: this is the persistence of some non-narrative everyday behind the structures of the narrative genres. This non-narrative "reality," which Auerbach also calls "existential," is at one with that impulse towards scene and the present which we initially associated with affect as such. But we may also identify it with another tendency at work within the triumphant realist paradigm, and that is its increasingly episodic character, which will eventually mark the supercession of plot by scene, of imagination by fancy, and of narrative by a kind of non-narrative perceptuality. A reversion to beginnings no doubt, in one sense: for the novel is an omnibus form cobbled together out of heterogeneous materials, chief among which is the sketch (as Dickens called it) or Balzac's *physiognomie*, the newspaper columns on the various and colorful sights of the big city, the journalistic observation and notation which adds to the very density of the narrative text itself. But with serialization, this centrifugal tendency is then once again intensified; and the installment, with its recurrent internal dynamic and its relative autonomy, encourages a tendency once again to break up the continuity of the narrative or story-telling process, albeit in a new way.

We may call this new tendency one towards autonomization; here what Luhmann called "differentiation" is at one with reification itself as process. But where in poetry reification results in the increasing transformation of words into objects, as in Baudelaire's strict forms, in the novel it can better be detected, not only in the emergence of descriptive set pieces, but even more in the tendency of the secondary characters to move forward and to eclipse the relationships of the main characters around whom narrative itself is chiefly organized and Imagination invested and rehearsed. Galdós offers the supreme illustration of this process whereby the novel becomes a kind of tour around the secondary characters of the city and its narrative space, at least insofar as the city is most fully realized and externalized form of the narrative space towards which the realist novel tends. Here again *Ulysses* casts a privileged light backwards on the older form, whose

multiple plots and intersections prove to be something like narrative cities in their own right.

3.

A final return to melodrama may be instructive here; but not to the generic substantive; to the melodramatic as such, which we have also consistently identified with the theatrical and with the rhetorical. What is most commonly associated with these epithets, particularly when they are used in a critical or negative spirit, is not so much their effect as the sense that they constitute something like narrative supplements, structures which are superimposed or added on, the survival of an outdated aesthetic of expression which is called upon to compensate for a different kind of chemical deficiency.

For Fried's own discussion (and that of many of the theatrical discussions of melodrama as well) makes it clear that the association of melodrama with theatricality raises the more general issue of rhetoric in modern times and its repudiation (as in Verlaine's famous poem), not only in modernism as such but also in the course of the development of the realist novel. Rhetoric here means not only the theatricality of an essentially expressive language (based as we have already shown on the primacy of the named emotion), but also, from Scott and Hugo on down, the shorthand explosive devices whereby a plot can be begun, turned in a new direction, or brought to a timely end (in an untimely fashion). This is essentially the function of a kind of narrative rhetoric in Zola, as we have seen: the need to finish it all off with a catastrophe, or the insertion of grotesque figures à la Hugo, such as Saccard's demon child in *L'argent*, in order to give a forward momentum to events easily seduced into lethargy by the suffusion of affect (and eschewing any great interest in introspection or psychology as such).

Yet Zola's melodramatic moments not only remind us that he is the inheritor of Hugo fully as much as of Balzac; they also mark a significant disjunction in his raw material. We are inclined to deplore these narrative excesses at the same time that we admire them (if only in the thrill of the execution): which is to say that already in the very reading of the text they project themselves as supplements, the raw material acts out its own inner rifts and discontinuities. It seems to want to demonstrate, on its own, the gap between the lavish,

indeed libidinous and garish *jouissance* in daily life and in routine, in the great lists and catalogues of objects, the body's swoons and its *bonheur*, its exhilarations and ecstatic glimpses; and on the other hand the gratuitous explosions, the fires, the bankruptcies, the monstrosities and gratuitous (yet "fatal") catastrophes, which are the price we have to pay for the novel's closure. The excess lies thus in the very subject-matter itself rather than in its creator's bad taste. It foreshadows as it were some future distance between the two temporalities of iteration and Event, of boredom and historical cataclysm; but it also announces the imminent breakdown of narrative as the form in which such "reality" can be registered and conveyed.

As far as George Eliot is concerned, the assertion of some resistance to melodrama cannot but seem paradoxical in the light of the innumerable melodramatic elements in her novels, from the seduction of Hetty in *Adam Bede* to the trials of Gwendolyn in *Daniel Deronda*, from the mysteries of the birth of that novel's hero to Romola's drama of vengeance, from the fortunes and bankruptcies of any number of these stories to their accompaniment by secrecy and blackmail so persuasively documented by Alexander Welsh.[23]

Yet the significance of such elements needs to be grasped in the light of the heterogeneous construction of these works, where a variety of narrative paradigms (and not only those of melodrama) have been superimposed in omnibus constructions which do not betray carelessness or inexperienced workmanship so much as they suggest a will to the inclusion of multiple impulses, a variety of social and psychological types, and an ambitious multiplicity of themes.

The *costumbrismo* of *Adam Bede* is thus combined with a class tragedy à la *Faust I*, the disastrous fraternization of the girl of the people with a young aristocrat (who assuredly occupies the place of a certain kind of traditional villain). *The Mill on the Floss* is an even greater hodgepodge of "subjects" (as Henry James liked to call them) and of plot lines, not all fully explored or brought to conclusion. *Romola*'s status as a historical novel demands a heterogeneity as distinct from the relative single-mindedness of purpose of *Silas Marner* or, in its different way, of *Felix Holt*. Only *Middlemarch* triumphantly succeeds in fusing its plot strands into a coherent landscape, while the unusual upper-class milieu of *Daniel Deronda* equally unexpectedly

[23] Alexander Welsh, *George Eliot and Blackmail*, Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 1985.

opens a large fissure in this work and encouraged Leavis outrageously to propose that its political half (the tale of Deronda's ethnic identity) simply be excised.[24]

Yet it is more instructive to see this variety of Eliot's forms as so many exercises in technical experimentation. Indeed, of the other great nineteenth-century novelists, only Flaubert is comparable in the strategic deliberation of his projects and in their limited number. Neither Eliot nor Flaubert were professional novelists of the type of Dickens or Zola, of Balzac or even of Henry James; and each of their works can be seen as a laboratory experiment which poses a distinct form-problem in its own right, however satisfactory the solution.

It is therefore not surprising that the problem of melodrama should find a self-conscious working through in Eliot: in this work a narrative dilemma has come to historical fruition and at the same time has encountered a philosophical motivation to sustain it. We do not need to speculate on the timeliness of the dilemmas of ethics for a Victorian and evolution-minded public (Nietzsche is there to document its wider cultural resonance).

David Ferris has indeed pointed out, with great acuity, that *Middlemarch* itself contains a significant autoreferential digression on melodrama as a form, in the interlude (chapter 15) which recalls Lydgate's early affair in Paris with a young French actress.[25] The moment involves a melodrama in which an unfaithful wife kills her jealous husband on stage: yet in the moment in question the heroine really does kill her counterpart (who is or was in fact her husband "in real life"). Here the separation between melodrama as a genre and the realism that must always resist it, cancel it, unveil something more real behind its formulaic stereotype, is absolute. What "realism" then adds in the process is the revelation that the next layer of representation —her foot slipped, it was an accident—is also false and that the young woman in fact meant to kill her spouse in the first place. This minor discovery is in fact rather momentous for George Eliot's work in general, and we will come back to it.

A more serious objection to the theory of the effacement of melodrama confronts us in the very existence of George Eliot's last great work, *Daniel Deronda*, in which melodrama is inexplicably reinstated

[24] "As for the bad part of *Daniel Deronda*, there is nothing to do but cut it away," *The Great Tradition*, London: Chatto and Windus, 1948, 122.

[25] David Ferris, *Theory and the Evasion of History*, Baltimore: Johns Hopkins Univsersity Press, 1993.

in all its glory, with an implacably victimized yet admirably energetic heroine and a villain whose cold passion equals anything the eighteenth century might have bequeathed us. In the case of Grandcourt, indeed, Eliot has availed herself of none of those representational techniques of bad faith which might have made this character more attractive to the reader, or at least more comprehensible: the few brief flashes of his inner life (and the memory of his love for Mrs. Glasher and her children) are scarcely enough to mar this powerful image of the libertine-villain, whose coldness, from Laclos and Sade, from Lovelace, to Byron and Balzac, is the traditional sign of the energies of vice. Nor does the secondary foil of Lush (the corrupt domestic familiar from the Don Juan legend onwards) account for everything that is inexplicable about the existence of this archetype of a certain evil: the inexplicability of radical evil as that is indeed reflected in Grandcourt's manner, which is the unforseeability and capriciousness of the refusal, the unexpected affirmation of the unjustifiable demand, the serene conviction as to the necessity of dominating the other.

When seen in this light and replaced in this particular cultural tradition, the figure of Grandcourt, surely one of Eliot's most fully realized characters, belongs unmistakably in the cast of characters of archetypal melodrama. Yet what can account for this remarkable formal regression on George Eliot's part, in a work which otherwise in formal and stylistic energy and intelligence is in no way inferior to *Middlemarch*? Surprisingly enough, I believe that the reasons are political, and that they also account for that seemingly unrelated development of the Deronda plot, which we have seen a reader so eminent as Leavis suggest its surgical removal from the Gwendolyn half, which he greatly admired.

James's pronouncement on Eliot's conservatism—"Both as an artist and a thinker ... our author is an optimist; and although a conservative is not necessarily an optimist, I think an optimist is pretty likely to be a conservative"[26]—needs some revision, particularly when coming from so apolitical a writer as James himself, whose characterization suggests nothing particularly progressive on his part, but merely that in her "conservatism" he still detected something political, a survival of political impulses and values in what should have been nothing but art. I think it might have been better to characterize these remnants

[26] Henry James, *Literary Criticism, Volume II: European Writers; Prefaces to the New York Edition*, New York: Library of America, 1984, 933

of the political in Eliot as anti-political, or better still, as anti-activist. Certainly she had a keen sense of oppression, and just as obviously she deplored both working-class agitation (*Felix Holt*) or militant feminism as such, without for all that ceasing to deplore the wrongs they (mistakenly) set out to correct by outright political action. The providential[27] lent a Utopian glow to such contradictory situations without diminishing the damaging critical vision she exercised in the portrayal of intolerable confinements such as the marriages of Dorothea or Gwendolyn.

Might it not be suggested that the outright political conflicts and social struggles she wished to avoid in contemporary social life, with their taking of sides and the antagonistic structure they necessarily generated, were for her not without their relationship to those melodramatic structures she sought to minimize in her novelistic constructions?

Meanwhile, idyllic visions of an older rural and village life become less and less "realistic" with the development of industrial capitalism, and neither reform bill seems to justify the reconciliation of "progress" with that rural and nostalgic restoration which an optimist like George Eliot might have been expected to hope for. Instead, everywhere in Europe, nationalist movements unexpectedly begin to take the place of the kinds of internal social conflicts that had left their traces in her earlier work. To encompass this new and larger world, a new kind of political thinking is required, which we find Gwendolyn confronting with dismay and good will alike. *Daniel Deronda* as a novel does the same; and it seems plausible enough that, whatever discomfort George Eliot may have felt with the relatively separatist movements of workers or women, her keen sense of the "web" of community and of collective relations would have found the nationalist movements in principle more congenial.[28] Yet they are not to be activist, whence the choice of the Jewish revival as the most appropriate vehicle for this new and evolving political consciousness. In evaluating it we must utterly put aside anachronistic connotations of a later political Zionism (let alone the *Realpolitik* of the state of Israel) and grasp it as a purely cultural nationalism (leaving aside the later connotations of this phrase as well), or in other words a collective

[27] Once again, see "The Experiments of Time" elsewhere in this volume.

[28] Her idiosyncratic interest in Zionism is to be sure not the only form of political rethinking to be observed in this latter half of the nineteenth century, after the triumph of representational politics and the onset of imperialism.

national movement wholly organized around the cultural tradition and without the activist political program Eliot so systematically eschewed.

This Eliot, whose interest in the continental nationalisms is, like her philosophical commitments, so far in advance of the more parochial British concerns, may then be seen as revising her view of local social life as well; and here we return to the question of melodrama, but now in order to underscore its political content as a symbolic act. For the tradition in which we have ranged Grandcourt is inescapably, along with the Gothic in general, an expression of the Enlightenment critique of the aristocracy and the ancien régime. The villainy of the libertine protagonists is a class oppression; politics and sexuality are both conjoined in the fundamental eighteenth-century signifier of "virtue"; and Grandcourt like all the others is the quintessential aristocrat battening on commoners. *Adam Bede*, for the Germanophile who was George Eliot, is as we have said a replay of *Faust I*, with its tragedy of the seduced peasant girl; *Daniel Deronda*, is more akin to the Gothic, and to the tyranny of the nobility over its imprisoned female victims. At any rate, I suggest that the deeper plot structure of this last of Eliot's novels consists in a conjuncture between the melodramatic denunciation of the persistence of an English ancien régime and the Utopian vision of another kind of organic community now set, not in the English past, but in some unfamiliar future landscape in which, with Deronda himself, our lives and selves may be utterly transformed.

Yet in all this we have overlooked as it were the other melodrama, the other villain. For surely one of the theatrical (and operatic) staples of melodrama was always the family romance, which is to say the rediscovered paternity of the orphaned child, the dramatical revelation or the birth of hero or heroine, the anagnorisis whose cries of joy and amazement allow the work to be completed and the plot to be finished off (we will return to this matter of narrative closure in a moment). Meanwhile, we also seem to have forgotten that the villain can very often take the form of the other sex, persisting from time immemorial (as in the Chinese tradition of "white-boned demons" and evil princesses) all the way down to the femmes fatales of Hollywood film noir.

It is a reminder that must at once draw our attention away from Grandville (in Eliot's first plot) to the Princess Halm Eberstein, the true melodramatic center of the second plot line: the bad mother,

who abandons her son Daniel to become a world-famous diva, and who radiates the coldness conventionally associated with the actantial villain. But we cannot properly evaluate this figure and her climactic position in both plots without returning to its "*mise en abyme*" in that little anecdote of the earlier novel, the tale of Lydgate's first love and disillusionment. For there, in passing, we find enunciated what is really explosive and political in George Eliot's work, in the offhand explanation of his actress lover after the admission of guilt: "'You are a good young man,' she said, 'But I do not like husbands and will never have another.'"[29] In this sentence, and not in any of her moral sententiousness, nor even in sympathetic figures like Dorothea, we find the beating heart of George Eliot's work and the place in which the conventional sub-generic narratives both of melodrama and of the drama of adultery are revealed to be the merest of disguises and fronts for an unequalled drama of liberation. Just as the male villain, the seducer, constituted the civilized avatar of the age-old cannibal ogre (Freud's master of the primal horde), and the coldly villainous woman that of the witch and evil sorceress who kills her own offspring (Medea), so the work of realism lies in dissolving these archetypes (and not, as the old myth criticism tried to assure us, of staging their survival) and in appropriating their archetypal plots for new acts of freedom.

Still, we must also not forget that, emptied of its content and traditional meaning, melodrama, as well as the other tale-types we have mentioned here, is also an empty form, which survives to supply the structure of narrative and in particular that by which it can be set in motion and that with which it can find closure: the ending itself, the catastrophe—explosion, conflagration, flood, financial cataclysm, or indeed, in some cases (*Fidelio*) the providential rescue, the "*reitender Bote*" of Brecht, the Queen's pardon, hope against hope. In all these cases, negative or positive, what is then reinforced is the fundamental category of Ending as melodramatic closure and ultimate satisfaction —if not the destruction of the villains then at the very least the end of the world.

But we have repeatedly argued that realism does not mean the utter effacement of that manifestation of destiny and its récits which is the melodramatic mode: but only its weakening and tendential attenuation in the face of its opposite number, the scene, affect, the eternal present, consciousness or whatever form indeed that

[29] George Eliot, *Middlemarch*, London: Penguin, 1994, 154

incomapible impulse might take. Zola's cataclysms, Balzac's frantic denouements, all testify to the persistence of this temporal structure and its indispensability to a form which, particularly in the mode of nineteenth-century serialization, would be sorely challenged without some such device, some such signal of closure and completion.

Is it necessary to add that in this respect George Eliot is herself a master of the melodramatic ending? The great flood that sweeps away the protagonists of *The Mill on the Floss* is surely as Zolaesque as anything in Dickens; and it is no accident, surely, that both *Romola* and *Daniel Deronda* conclude with drownings that are highly melodramatic indeed. Fear death by water. It is that fear, and the formal innovations she devised to conjure as well as to satisfy it, that make George Eliot so interesting an overnight stop on the path from realism's emergence to its dissolution.[30]

Yet there exists one final form of genre which it is virtually impossible for realism to dissolve without completely undoing itself in the process: and that is the novel itself. One of Barthes' central literary observations was the idea that the novel as a form was less to be defined by plot and structure than by the "*romanesque*" itself, by a novel-ness that extended down into the very pores of the language and the individual sentences, transforming even ostensible fact and alleged nonfiction into the inescapable connotation of the supplementary declaration, "I am a novel." I have elsewhere used the following sentence from a nonfictional journalistic work as an example, and it remains a dramatic one:

> The morning air was frigid in Greenwich, Connecticut. At 5:00 a.m. on March 17, 2008, it was still dark, save for the headlights of the black Mercedes idling in the driveway, the beams illuminating patches of slush that were scattered across the lawns of the twelve-acre estate. The driver heard the stones of the walkway crackle as Richard S. Fuld Jr. shuffled out the front door and into the backseat of the car.[31]

Now this is an opening sentence, and thereby all the more significant insofar as it programs the reader and proposes a certain narrative and

[30] The two classic studies of endings and beginnings are of course Barbara Herrnstein Smith, *Poetic Closure*, Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1974; and Edward Said, *Beginnings*, New York: Columbia University Press, 1985.

[31] Andrew Ross Sorkin, *Too Big to Fail*, New York: Penguin, 2009. It is important to note that even if all the details of these sentences are factually true and not merely *vraisemblable* (the snow, the headlights, etc.), the sentences remain no less "fictional."

ultimately novelistic stance on what follows. But if this is so, and if "the novel" is at one and the same time Barthes' "novelistic" and the last genre to be dissolved in realism's struggle against reification and reified form, then it becomes paradoxically clear that realism's ultimate adversary will be the realistic novel itself.

Chapter VIII

The Swollen Third Person, or, Realism after Realism

> What determined the speech that startled him in the course of their encounter scarcely matters, being probably but some words spoken by himself quite without intention—spoken as they lingered and slowly moved together after their renewal of acquaintance.
>
> James, "The Beast in the Jungle"

Until now, we have been telling this story in terms of the largest and most manageable categories: plot, character systems, genres and the like; only the traditional conception of description or ekphrasis has seemed to introduce any attention to style, or rather, to be more precise about the nature of this analysis, to rhetoric. The division, however, already suggests some split between macro and micro, fable and *syuzhet*, story and treatment, which suspiciously echoes the opposition between object and subject, if not even between telling and showing; and which demands scrutiny, that is to say, historicization. The preceding chapters have indeed consisted in an effort to historicize the larger categories mentioned above, and to replace generic plots and systems of characters within a process of change in which their functions undergo fundamental restructuration. It should be obvious enough that the very narrative language in which these materials are staged and conveyed is no less subject to historical modification or evolution; and more than that, necessarily also furnishes clues, when properly scrutinized, as to the transformations underway.

Once again, however, we are confronted with a properly dialectical ambivalence in which the very syntactical machinery that was fundamental to the construction of realism at one and the same time turns out to participate in its deterioration (and then, perhaps, to its rebirth as something else, as yet to be named). Auerbach's great lesson in this area was, to be sure, the correlation between the conquest of ever more complex syntactical forms and the "representation of reality"

as such; he was less interested in the appropriation of such syntactic constructions for what we might call anti-realistic tendencies, and it is on this dialectic of ambivalence that we will be concentrating here.

We will find, for example, that Irony (normally listed as a trope and perhaps unduly enlisted and overworked in their practice by tropological thinkers such as Paul de Man and Hayden White) cannot be divided quite so neatly and dialectically into stable irony (good!) and unstable irony (bad!) as it is by Wayne Booth.[1] Above all, however, we will have to come to terms with perhaps the most notorious, or at least the most exhaustively studied forms of linguistic and stylistic innovation in the nineteenth century—"*style indirect libre*," free indirect discourse or *Erlebte Rede*. Such "unspeakable sentences" (Ann Banfield) are preeminently associated with Flaubert, even though scholars have traced their ancestry as far back as Jane Austen (if not Ariosto); and their emergence clearly marks a fundamental event in the history of language. This event has in my opinion most often been misinterpreted; but it would be wrong to underestimate its importance or to relegate it to a marginal state, as Pasolini reminds us ("its presence for a diagnostician is the proof of an ideology that cannot appear in only a few extreme cases but which completely characterizes the entire work").[2]

For the moment it suffices to associate it with the gradual primacy of another category, which it is as difficult to characterize as a linguistic phenomenon as it is as a narrative technique. This is the "law" or norm of "point of view," now taught in creative writing courses, and erected as a hegemonic ideology under the authority of Henry James and by innumerable literary censors, who scan texts for its infringement, which they might as well have discovered on every other page of Tolstoy or Zola. The emergence of this ideology then also demands historical explanation.

But I begin here with a linguistic phenomenon far less often remarked, no doubt on account of its apparent triviality, which (like a virus) primarily affects the pronoun: "The speech that startled him..." It would be tempting to speculate on the practice of the pronoun in traditional (oral) storytelling, in social situations in which its opposite number—the proper name—is itself the locus of no little

[1] Wayne Booth, *The Rhetoric of Fiction*, Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1983; and especially *A Rhetoric of Irony*, Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1975.

[2] Pier Paolo Pasolini, *Heretical Empiricism*, Washington: New Academia Publishing, 1988, 82.

significance (where it comes from, is it a new name given by circumstances, or a secret name, does it designate kinship, and so on and so forth). But in the modern languages it has become, we are told, a "rigid designator,"[3] and the pronouns which take its place from time to time must therefore be equally rigid. The classical word for such substitution is "*anaphora*," namely the reference of the term—generally a pronoun—back to the named object for which it stands. But in our reference text—the opening sentence of a novella—no named object is given.

This very structure participates in the dialectical ambivalence we have already anticipated: for nothing is more ancient and more traditional than the "*in medias res*" recommended by Horace and surely practiced well before Homer, a narrative procedure equally effective on the microlevel of the sentence itself and its syntax. Modern linguists or rhetoricians have reasonably enough baptized this construction "cataphora":[4] yet its very absence from the ancient manuals is suggestive. For just as the ancient mariners feared the approach to an edge of the world from which they fantasized a drop into nothingness, so this peculiar beginning seems to betoken a nothingness, a void, before the opening of the text itself. The cataphora articulates some inauguratory mystery, some absolute darkness before the voice begins, which no doubt carries intimations of all the primal fears of beginnings, creations, the waking up without a memory or an identity, birth itself. But in fact, the cataphora, far from being a rarity, has been elevated, in much contemporary literature, to the status of an incipit:

> He was there, waiting. He was the first one, standing, lounging, trying to look occupied or at least innocent.

The cataphora, however, rarely succeeds in looking innocent; nor does it really mean to. For this kind of sentence most often announces a thriller of some kind, and the unidentified pronoun stands in fact for the unidentified serial killer of the novel in question. Nothing further, indeed, from the classic opening sentence, in all its nominatory solemnity:

[3] The expression is Saul Kripke's, in *Naming and Necessity*, Cambridge: Wiley-Blackwell, 1991.

[4] Most notably in the work of A. J. Greimas.

> Those two girls, Constance and Sophia Baines, paid no heed to the manifold interest of their situation, of which, indeed, they had never been conscious.
>
> Alexey Fyodorovich Karamazov was the third son of a landowner in our district, Fyodor Pavlovich Karamazov, so noted in his time (and even now still recollected among us) for his tragic and fishy death, which occurred just thirteen years ago and which I shall report in its proper context.
>
> Detective Inspector Napoleon Bonaparte, of the Queensland police, was walking along a bush track on his way to Windee Station.[5]

To which we should add that sometimes this named character with whom the novel announces itself is in fact a named landscape (through which, for example, a distant horseman is riding).

The reader will anticipate the relationship to be established between these two kinds of actantial openings (with or without the proper name) and the "namelessness" we have been attributing to affect in earlier chapters. For the moment it is important to insist that what is at stake here does not concern the matter of narrative beginnings only, but as Pasolini put it, betrays the working of a deeper and more general ideology at work throughout the narrative text as a whole, most visibly detectable in the system of pronouns and their stable or unstable relationship to names and nouns as such.

But we cannot evaluate changes in pronominal use without forming such a larger view of the status of narrative sentences as such, a view I wish to adapt from Käthe Hamburger's well-known but perhaps today little read study *The Logic of Literature*.[6] On the face of it, Hamburger's 1957 treatise (much like that of her adversary Roman Ingarden, whose *Literary Work of Art* of 1931 reached English at much the same time in the early 1970s)[7] constituted a phenomenologically oriented aesthetics, with particular attention to the status of language in literature, which she called "fictional." This is,

[5] The four openings can be identified as follows: William Faulkner, *Intruder in the Dust*, Random House, 1948; Arnold Bennett, *The Old Wives' Tale*, London: Penguin, 2007 [1908]; Fyodor Dostoyevsky, *The Brothers Karamazov*, trans. Richard Pevear and Larissa Volokhonsky, New York: Farrar, Straus and Giroux, 2002; Arthur Upfield, *The Sands of Windee*, London: Hutchinson, 1931.

[6] Käthe Hamburger, *The Logic of Literature*, trans. Marilynn J. Rose, Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1973.

[7] Roman Ingarden, *The Literary Work of Art*, Evanston: Northwestern University Press, 1979.

however, not a work of linguistics, and is only distantly related to the great German school of romance philology (with its distinctive "style studies" such as are to be found in Spitzer or Auerbach), but is rather more distantly inspired by the exchange between Goethe and Schiller on "epic" language (it being understood that the German *episch* most often simply means narrative, as also in Brecht's "epic" theater).[8] The crisis in philosophy in recent years, and not least the evident plunge in the prestige of aesthetics as a subfield (in the context of an immense enlargement of culture in general in postmodernity, with the recent exception of a doubtful ideological revival of the essentially aesthetic question of "beauty"), has reduced scholarly interest in problems of aesthetic ontology, such as the nature of fictive language, and along with it in treatises like those of Hamburger (or Ingarden) respectively. Although I generally share the distaste for the word "fiction," I will not argue the merits of this neglect further here.

Yet we thereby lose the benefit of everything paradoxical or scandalous in Hamburger's positions in this seemingly conventional work: and it is precisely those heretical judgements that will be most useful for us here. Her articulation of the nature of the narrative sentence for example—what she calls the "*Aussage*" or "statement"—can easily be confused with more traditional formulations of the nature of "fictive" language: that of dematerialization (Hegel), intuition and expression (Croce), quasi-judgements or pseudo-statements (Ingarden) or neutralization (Husserl and Sartre). But the conclusions she draws from her view of the narrative statement are startling, and quite different from those of her predecessors. To be sure, she will dwell insistently on Schiller's idea of literature's *Vergegenwärtigung* or presentification; but she radically detemporalizes the idea:

> Here and now, i.e., presentified, the action in narrative literature unfolds, but this Now, this presentification, must not necessarily have the sense of the temporal present, although it can assume this sense—rather easily, too—as a fictive present. But if literary art, as Schiller, in disagreement with Goethe, believed (and many shared this notion), necessitates that even the epic poet "presentify," this concept nevertheless becomes erroneous once one means, as did Schiller, that "something which has happened," something past, must be made present. The preterite in narrative literature no longer functions to designate past-ness solely because literature does not presentify in a temporal sense. The concept of presentification is in its ambiguity not only inexact, but, as a designation for the structure of fictional,

[8] See the exchange of letters between Goethe and Schiller in April and May of 1797.

> mimetic literature, it is also incorrect and misleading. What it means here is fictionalization. And it does not stand in contradiction to this when we nevertheless say that the action of a novel unfolds "here and now." For "here and now"—and with this we close the circle of our proof of the preterite's loss of temporal function—means epistemologically, and therefore also in terms of theory of language, primarily the zero-point of the system of reality, which is determined through the coordinates of time and space. It means the I-Origo, in reference to which the Now has no precedence over the Here and vice versa. Rather, all three terms designate the originary point of experience. Even if a "present time" (which in the temporal sense is not a series of points, but rather a duration which is arbitrary, extended according to subjective experience) is not indicated at all, such as by the word "today" or a specific date, etc., we experience the action of the novel as being "here and now," as the experience of fictive persons, or, as Aristotle said, of men in action. In turn, this means nothing other than that we experience these fictive persons in their I-originarity, to which all representational particulars, including all possible temporal ones, are referred.[9]

We will return to the interesting question of the use of words like "here" or "now" later on. What is far more unsettling is the consequence, implacably drawn by Hamburger—that the narrative (or fictional) *Aussage* is distinguished by its suspension of the subject-object relationship: it is a statement without a subject (unlike ordinary reality-statements). The power of the distinction can be measured by her ingenious reversal of the traditional terms of the problem: fictionality does not depend on the existence or not of the object, but rather on that of the subject position.

At any rate, it is evident that Hamburger's seemingly perverse yet absolute position here at one stroke frees us from the interminable literary-theoretical theorization of Implied Authors, Implied Readers, and the like, which only add unnecessary entities to such discussions; while at the same time preserving a kind of literary or narrative objectivity from those realms of fantasy and fantasizing, of the imaginary or of the imagination, in which at length this activity seems indistinguishable from that idle daydreaming with which the first readers of novels were so often taxed. Narrative thereby, without ceasing to be fictional, ceases to be unreal: and it is perhaps a consequence of the society of the spectacle, and the simulcrum, a society invested at all points with images and the Imaginary, with daydreams, wish fulfillments and other quasi-fetishistic intensities, that such a position will today seem less paradoxical than it once was.

[9] Hamburger, *The Logic of Literature*, 96–7.

Without wishing to resituate Hamburger's work altogether in that poststructural universe in which an Althusser can evoke science as a writing without a subject, the association must be made with Stanley Cavell's view of film as a world without me, that is, a world viewed as though in the absence of the viewer:[10] for it is with this conception of the aesthetic object that Hamburger's notion of narrative ("fiction") has its kinship. This is also the moment to place it in relationship with phenomenology, and in particular with Sartre's notion of an impersonal consciousness for which "I" or the ego is not a subject but rather an object, and indeed an object among others, although of a very special kind.[11] The reading of narrative is thus impersonal, and if we could find some equivalent for this formula in the realm of temporality we would also have solved the seemingly intractable dilemma of a temporal present with which the narrative conception of presentification (as we have seen) confronts us; in other words, we might find it possible to avoid terms like "eternal" which, tainted as they are, seem alone to offer an alternative to every purely temporal vocabulary.

Still, these are not the only dilemmas with which Hamburger's radical position leaves her. The problem of lyric is easily resolved by hiving lyric language off into a separate genre, one which accommodates the first-person pronoun and its subject position without any great difficulties. But there is also first-person narrative, and this is a more difficult nut to crack. I quickly resume Hamburger's unexpectedly satisfying solution: first-person narrative is distinctively fictive, not in its unreality but rather in that other root sense of the fictive which is the *feigned*. First-person narrative is therefore a form of acting, of posing, feigning, taking up positions, before that spectator who is the reader. The I-narrative thereby imperceptibly finds itself ranged in another category altogether from that of narrative prose: namely, the theatrical, whose relationship to rhetoric and melodrama we have already touched on in the previous chapter (as it was theorized by Michael Fried).[12] Despite the eminent examples of first-person literary narratives in German, from the eighteenth-century letter novel all the way to Thomas Mann, it is difficult to escape the impression that for Hamburger this essentially histrionic

[10] Stanley Cavell, *The World Viewed*, Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 1979.

[11] Jean-Paul Sartre, *The Transcendence of the Ego*, trans. Forrest Williams and Robert Kirkpatrick, New York: Hill and Wang, 1960, [1934].

[12] Michael Fried, *Absorption and Theatricality*, Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1988.

and self-posing, self-dramatizing kind of narrative is somehow aesthetically inferior to the third-person classics: this is not an opinion which need be binding on us, but it does obligate us to argue the case for such narratives in a different way, which may require the theorization and opposition of two distinct systems rather than simply judgements of value on individual writers and individual texts.

We must however forestall a simplification which would inevitably put a premature end to the current discussion. We have had occasion in the course of the preceding chapters to denounce from time to time the false symmetries inevitably proposed by the inescapable opposition of subject and object. Garden-variety film criticism demonstrates that we face this temptation again at this point, since our two kinds of narratives—third and first—seem immediately to lend themselves to the Hollywood classification of objective and subjective shots, camera work that proposes itself as the scanning of an objective world (substituting its own apparatus for the position of the human spectator) and views arranged so as to approximate what a given character in the film sees (an impression carefully constructed and codified by editing practices such as the matching shot and shot-reverse-shot, which now pass themselves off as natural). This is the point at which we approach problems like point of view and even (following Pasolini) *style indirect libre*. We will postpone them for the moment.

It is enough at this point to repudiate this facile distinction and to suggest that both "objective" or third person narrative and subjective or first-person performances are far more complicated—the he or she of the third person being based on a reifying system of names and external personifications we can no longer accept today, while the first-person narrative position itself, on closer inspection, proliferates into a host of distinct subject-positions that cannot readily be subsumed and contained back into a single category. Thus, in the case of Mark Twain, perhaps the most eminent of modern practitioners and the one from whom, according to Hemingway (as Dostoyevsky said of Gogol for the Russian), modern American literature emerged, a wild succession of first-person dramatizations echoes restless self-transformations, and self-dramatizations challenge traditional boundaries between public and private life. Indeed, it is as though "Mark Twain" were himself a laboratory in which these structural confusions were richly and experimentally exhibited.

I must here open a philosophical parenthesis on the relevance of this seemingly generic discussion to contemporary psychoanalytic views

of consciousness and personality. I have already observed that Sartre's first publication[13] lays the groundwork for a theory of impersonal consciousness for which ego or self are as it were "objects" in Husserl's sense. *Being and Nothingness* (1943) was then elaborated out of this first conception of impersonality, to which is added the revolutionary theory of the Other and our alienation by the Other (neither impersonality nor the Other are present in Heideggerian existentialism in this form). Lacanian psychoanalysis, with its structural account of the "big Other" and the latter's formative relationship to the "subject of desire," then transforms the Sartrean picture of our traumatic alienation by the other into a whole permutation scheme, as it were a system of subject positions, which modify and vary unduly the sense of self or identity. Without wishing to overburden a discussion whose topic is the effect and function of pronouns in the narrative system of the novel, we may quickly detour Lacan's confusing distinction between the ideal ego and the ego ideal by suggesting that the sense of self depends on the mutilation and humiliation (I also evade the charged term "castration") of one or the other of these key positions of subject and Other. This presumably gives us four logical possibilities: the relationship of the mutilated self to the full Other ($\mathbf{s}$/O) is one of dependency and subalternity, when not abjection; that of the ideal ego to the mutilated Other (S/Ø) is one of jubilation and euphoria; that of mutilated self to mutilated other ($\mathbf{s}$/Ø) one of absolute melancholy and devastation; while that of full self or ego to unmutilated Other (S/O) can probably only be an imaginary relationship, but one which, imagined, might range from aggressivity and competition to some joyous and active celebration of collectivity (but discussion of such collective selves, which anticipate Sartre's *Critique of Dialectical Reason*, cannot be pursued any further here).

At any rate, we may hopefully now return to the question of first-person narrative with a suitably enlightened, if not chastened, sense of its possible complexities. Significantly, Hamburger identifies humor or the comic as a primordial form of first-person storytelling, while from another quite different perspective we may recall Sartre's own description of the way we act out our alleged identities in relationship to other people (the waiter "playing at being" a waiter)[14] as evidence that there is always something secretly comical in all public affirmations of

[13] See note 11 above.

[14] Jean-Paul Sartre, *Being and Nothingness*, trans. Hazel Barnes, New York: Washington Square Press, 1956 [1943], 101–3, 131.

identity (including the gender ones). And since we have mentioned Mark Twain, one cannot but be struck by the traumatic way in which his unexpected emergence as a public person made of him, his whole life long, a kind of privileged spectacle of the combined necessity and impossibility of "being" someone. For the "I" is at first a shame-faced kind of revelation, as though a character reluctantly stepped forward into the glare of the footlights to receive an unknown, unpredictable yet unavoidable judgement from those unseen others who constitute the public, hidden in darkness. Humor is then a fundamental weapon in this struggle with other people, and few anecdotes are more revealing of its aggressive powers than the story of Mark Twain's jubilation at making his quintessentially laconic friend General Ulysses S. Grant laugh out loud in public: "I fetched him! I broke him up utterly!... The audience *saw* that for once in his life he had been knocked out of his iron serenity... I knew I could lick him... I shook him up like dynamite."[15]

Such are the rhetorical and theatrical powers of the first person; yet even a cursory reading of *Huckleberry Finn* reminds us how distant and mysterious the first-person narrator is from even the most mysterious third-person subjective of narrative. In the former we do not confront the world side by side with the protagonist, looking along with him at the prospect, but are rather ourselves confronted by a mask that looks back at us and invites a trust that can never be verified. Yet this is a dialectic that is itself played out within many first person narratives such as this one, and the episode of the Duke and the Dauphin rehearse virtually all the subject-positions outlined above. At first, of course, they constitute the big Other for Huck and Jim alike (and Jim is there to articulate Huck's own subject-position, otherwise easily lost behind the first person). Royalty always thus demands the status of the big Other; and Twain's Americanism, in *Innocents Abroad* and even the first-person *Connecticut Yankee*, easily becomes an adversarial one, as does Huck's own: "It didn't take me long to make up my mind that these liars weren't no kings nor dukes, but just low-down humbugs and frauds."[16] The demotion of the Other by symbolic castration is thereby at once assured, and Jim and Huck freed from their position as subservient listeners and servants.

[15] Justin Kaplan, *Mr. Clemens and Mr. Twain*, New York: Simon and Schuster, 1991, 227.

[16] Mark Twain, *Huckleberry Finn*, in *Mississippi Writings*, New American Library, 1982, 747.

Theatricality enters the picture insofar as the Duke and the Dauphin are theatrical twice over: in their fraudulent public performances and in their private role-playing with Huck and Jim. Nor is Twain's anti-theatricality the only period expression of an exposure of the absurdity of contemporary European opera and stage-play: realists from Flaubert to Tolstoy inserted tell-tale scenes of the defamiliarization and a comic "making strange" of such spectacles, which leave their traces in the melodramatic "theater" of silent film as well (giving the would-be film realist of the next generation—Griffith straddled both—material to defamiliarize in its turn).

But what now needs to be laid in place is a fundamental complication of this first-person scheme: for this episodic narrative will seemingly turn on a series of two-step episodes—gullibility/disenchantment—which replicate the rhythm and structure of jokes themselves:

> Miss Watson told me to pray every day, and whatever I asked for I would get it. But it warn't so, I tried it. Once I got a fish-line but no hooks... I set down one time, back in the woods, and had a long think about it... No, I says to myself, there weren't nothing in it.[17]

Later, when "spiritual gifts" are on the agenda, Huck thinks about it again: "but I couldn't see no advantage about it, except for other people—so at last I reckoned I wouldn't worry about it any more, but just let it go."[18]

"Advantage" might be money or it might be making General Grant laugh. Either way, seeing through the joke no longer puts the subject at an advantage, but reduces him to the same mutilated condition as the now unmasked big Others themselves, so that the lot end up fleeing the townspeople's wrath all together, in the universal rout of the theatrical first person.

It is a paradoxical and contradictory situation which can be clarified by the realization that "lies" and "lying" are Mark Twain's technical terms for storytelling and narrative, at which point it will become obvious that storytelling in this situation is not only an autoreferential meditation on storytelling but a will to unmask it as such, as "lying." First-person theatricality is then an Enlightenment impulse to unmask everything spurious, from individual egotism and pretension

[17] Ibid., 635.

[18] Ibid., 635.

or mythomania to religion and collective delusions and derangements of all kinds: an impulse that preeminently characterizes Mark Twain's progressive politics. But it also raises the question of what to salvage out of the universal bonfire of all those innumerable stories and narratives which inevitably turn out to be little more than lies in the first place. Here the very meaning of the word "fiction" turns against itself and would seem on the point of destroying its own rationale in the process, and with it art in general. How to get back out of theatricality while saving everything that made it art in the first place? This is, of course, Michael Fried's question, and his answer—the painted figure who seemed to address you rhetorically from the painting and to solicit your response, your tears or your sentiment, must now turn away from the audience and become "absorbed" in his or her own being or "self"—this answer must now guide us in our search for what follows the first-person narrative in the novel.

Yet the unexamined third logical possibility in Fried's scheme—the Brechtian "first-person" turn of the character back to the public, which the actor addresses directly (as in the speech of the Fourth Knight in Eliot's *Murder in the Cathedral*)—does not seem endowed with the force and the shock it still has in a painting such as Picasso's *Demoiselles d'Avignon*. The latter's successive versions gradually divest themselves of their "third-person" and male fictional elements—the medical student carrying a skull, and the sailor ensconced at the heart of the brothel—and thereby determine a dramatic movement of the women towards the viewer, in the form of five enormous alien gendered beings whose gaze at us, not necessarily hostile or aggressive, is intense and yet unidentifiable: not so much that blast of raw sexuality as Leo Steinberg would have it, so much as the neutral presence of the Other, the impersonality of alien consciousness registered yet still aloof and denying us all recognition.

The fictional answer can thus only be a return to the third person, but with a difference; and it is a difference which will ultimately unravel the realist conjuncture we have been describing here and bring that uniquely realistic moment to an end. I am of course alluding to the difference between what we may now call the objective third person and the subjective third person, the swollen or blank unidentified third person with which we began this chapter. For it will now seem as though this new form (in some Borgesian sense absolutely identical to its predecessor at the same time that it is incommensurable with it) consists in the incorporation of everything we have attributed to

the first-person narrator in order to reach some richer representation of subjectivity and thereby a more multidimensional representation of reality itself. The restructuration of this pronoun, the emergence of this new narrative entity, is related to that of several other literary phenomena—most notably *style indirect libre* and Irony—with which we will then subsequently deal, in order to form a more complete picture of what happens to realism as the initial realist synthesis begins to dissolve.

The most promising approach to this new (swollen or impersonal) third person will continue to be its effect in the beginnings of a given narrative, where its essential mystery can be felt most strongly. But this mystery has already been identified in our discussion of the first person, for it is that same blank wall of the mask or the face-to-face confrontation which has now been transferred to the third person and substituted for our sense of sharing the privileged point of view of the protagonist familiar from classical novelistic or realistic storytelling. I offer a few further illustrations:

> The telephone waked him. He waked already hurrying, fumbling in the dark for robe and slippers, because he knew before waking that the bed beside his own was still empty, and the instrument was downstairs just opposite the door beyond which his mother had propped upright in bed for five years.
>
> If he had been thirty, he would not have needed the two aspirin tablets and the half glass of raw gin before he could bear the shower's needling on his body and steady his hands to shave.
>
> The hard round ear of the stethoscope was cold and unpleasant upon his naked chest; the room, big and square, furnished with clumsy walnut—the bed where he had first slept alone, which had been his marriage bed.[19]

[19] All beginnings are taken from Faulkner's *Collected Stories* (New York: Random House, 1950). The first is "The Brooch" (647), where the main character (Boyd) is not named until well into the second paragraph. The second is "Golden Land" (701), where the name (Ira Ewing) only emerges many pages later. In the third, "Beyond" (781), the hero, Mothershed, is only named three pages later. I sense some deeper relationship between this pronominal development and the evolution described in G.R. Hamilton's curious essay *The Tell-Tale Article* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1950), which traces the evolution in poetry from the indefinite article to the definite, grasping it as a sign of modernity and its abstractions (his references are principally to Eliot and Auden): "the superior wink of the shared secret" he calls it (40), in other words the attempt of the isolated subjectivity to summon an elect collectivity around itself.

In effect, this kind of beginning incorporates our own confusion and perplexity, our own narrative curiosity, into the plot to come; and as such it supplements the growing plotlessness of the new narrative with a superimposed plot of its own. We have indeed seen how Zola's narrative conquest of the everyday needed to be supplemented (in the strongest philosophical sense) by a melodramatic and explosive dimension that reintroduced the Event back into the repetitions of the everyday. The new structural and pronominal mystery is a different, yet no less influential, solution to this same intensifying problem; and much of the power of the new Faulknerian narrative comes from the force of this cataphora, which is operative, not only on the micro-level of style, but on that of plot itself, as in the opening of *Sanctuary*, where we begin in the middle of an unexplained situation, where the secret to be revealed is not "profilmic" (that is to say, buried in the complexities of the narrative reality itself), but rather the result of the decision of the author.

This is the deeper structure of Faulknerian cataphora, to construct a secret and a mystery which is the result only of the author's withholding of information, rather than latent in the plot itself. The author of a detective story withholds the identity of the criminal no doubt, but this mystery is part and parcel of the plot itself, as all the characters experience it. In Faulkner, only the reader is inflicted with this mystery, inasmuch as the author has not seen fit to provide information which would at once make it clear what the situation is: and nameless third person or not, this peculiar beginning "*in medias res*" is characteristic of most of Faulkner's novels. They thereby bear witness to a modern necessity of constructing a narrative out of what were not initially narrative materials: in other words, they testify to the weakening of the pole of the récit, of the past-present-future system itself, by the dominance of an eternal present which seeks then to disguise itself as récit and narrative to be told and story or destiny to be revealed.

In Michael Fried's sense, then, we have here to do with an attempt to make absorption theatrical, to reannex the modernist moment of absorption—which Fried sees as the very logic of modernism itself as it more and more turns away from its spectators—to that "rhetoric of fiction" inherent in classical narrative.

The relationship of this modification of our distance from the characters then accounts for the kinship with detective stories, thrillers and commercial literature of all kinds, where the dual narrative—

formerly *syuzhet* and fable—now rearticulated as past criminal narrative and present narrative reconstruction by the detective, is simply an extrapolation of this structure.

So-called free indirect discourse then comes as a new solution to the problem of the unidentified consciousness of this "fourth person," as we may call the new narrative pronoun. For it is an unusual synthesis of third and first person which allows the latter's first-person thoughts to be represented in a way which avoids mimicry, dialectic, dramatic monologue and the like—in other words, which seems to evade precisely that theatricality from which the modernizing novel would like to turn away. What is unique about free indirect discourse can then be captured by the linguists' analysis and in particular by the incompatibility of present or deictic time words with sentences narrating the past.[20] The Faulknerian "now" is the most frequent and obvious signal of the lifting of this taboo in the new system ("now he was lifting the bale, now he was beginning to sweat," etc.).

And it should be clear from our earlier discussion that such a synthesis of the past (récit) and the present (scene) would seem to offer an ideal solution to the realist problem par excellence—except for the fact that realism was constitutively founded on an ineradicable tension between these two temporal realities, a tension that begins to dissolve into a facile practice of narrative mind-reading when free indirect discourse becomes the dominant sentence structure of the novel.

For Pasolini, in his idiosyncratic development of a theory of free indirect discourse (one which he ingeniously applied to film as well), the fundamental characteristic of this new stylistic device was the incorporation of an altogether different class discourse into the unavoidably bourgeois discourse of the novel as a form. Yet in order for its use to approach something like a Bakhtinian polyphony (not his reference), or something like a faithfulness of the form to the class structure (and struggle) of society itself, the radical otherness of the incorporated discourse must be retained—something not easy for bourgeois writers with a training in their class-specific style to achieve. The problem can be conveyed by a return to the simple-minded film-theory distinction between the objective and the subjective shots, whose images are sometimes

[20] Ann Banfield, *Unspeakable Sentences*, London: Routledge & Kegan Paul, 1982, 154; and see E. Benveniste, *Problèmes de linguistique générale*, Paris: Gallimard, 1966, 262 et passim.

"objectively" ambiguous, so that we cannot decide whose viewpoint we are adopting—that of the character or that of the camera apparatus. (Meanwhile, the exploitation of this uncertainty in horror films underscores the usefulness of the new procedure for commercial culture and its sub-genres). Pasolini's rage at the weakening of this constitutive tension and the loss of the class possibilities of the new stylistic device may not be misplaced here:

> The most odious and intolerable thing, even in the most innocent bourgeois, is that of not knowing how to recognize life experiences other than his own: and of bringing all other life experiences back to a substantial analogy with his own. It is a real offense that he gives to other men in different social and historical conditions. Even a noble, elevated bourgeois writer, who doesn't know how to recognize the extreme characteristics of psychological diversity of a man whose life experiences differ from his, and who, on the contrary, believes that he can make them his by seeking substantial analogies—almost as if experiences other than his own weren't conceivable—performs an act that is the first step toward certain manifestations of the defense of his privileges and even toward racism. In this sense, he is no longer free but belongs to his class deterministically; there is no discontinuity between him and a police chief or an executioner in a concentration camp.[21]

On the other hand, any evocation of *style indirect libre* in a discussion of realism surely has an obligation to come to terms with Flaubert himself, to whom traditional accounts (rightly) assign the merit of having invented both. But we cannot even pronounce the name of Flaubert without noting the multiple evaluations his writing objectively contains within itself. Read at different speeds, Flaubert successively becomes a realist (the content), a modernist (Joyce's master by way of his paragraphs) or a postmodernist (in the gaps and silences between his sentences described by Sartre and Nathalie Sarraute alike).[22] From the standpoint of production, I retain Barthes' account of Flaubert as essentially a handicraftsman, working in precious metals and jewels, and intent on making each sentence into an aesthetic object in its own right.[23] Flaubert's practice of free indirect discourse can in that case be seen as an attempt to withdraw thought (wordless or not) from the vague formlessness of subjectivity and endow it with all the materiality of an object of value (just as

[21] Pasolini, *Heretical Empiricism*, 87.

[22] See in particular Nathalie Sarraute, *The Age of Suspicion*, New York: Braziller, 1990.

[23] Roland Barthes, *Writing Degree Zero*, New York: Farrar, Straus and Giroux, 1977, Part Two, chapter two.

Baudelaire did for the effusions of romantic poetry). That one of the consequences of this willful aesthetic reification was the transformation of Balzacian allegory into the bodily contingency of affect we have already claimed. But it is difficult to argue for any durable innovation of Flaubert in the area of novelistic forms. Zola learned the uses of the chapter as a form from *L'Éducation sentimentale*, no doubt, but we must also register Henry James's intense dissatisfaction with the ever-sameness and empty flow of that novel's pages.[24]

Instead, I offer the following parenthetical sketch of the novel's history as a form that can be reproduced and successfully exported, an apparatus which, like film later on, or the automobile, can open up new lines of manufacture in a variety of traditional internal and external cottage industries. Scott's historical novel, combining adventure, the past, the romantic costume drama and the great national heroes all together, may be said to be the first form of the successful and influential novelistic apparatus of the nineteenth century. But its progeny know a number of distinct outcomes: alongside Balzac, there is opera; alongside the feuilleton there is also Victor Hugo and Dickens. It is within this popular efflorescence that Flaubert marks a break and a decisive restructuration (remember how Proust compared his deployment of tenses with Kant's invention of the categories: it is a historical paradigm whose suggestiveness might well be further extended).[25] Flaubert's legacy was the new status of the novelist as artist, and not some new form, a task whose Edison or Ford was Émile Zola.

For naturalism quickly became the fundamental new form of the novel all over the world, and, as we have argued here, the fundamental form of novelistic realism. Beyond Europe, all the "first novels" in the various national traditions are indebted either to Scott's model or to Zola's, depending on their stage of industrialization. It is not until after World War II that a third export model of the novel becomes available (modernism having offered more than the Flaubertian example of the single "book of the world" and the ideal status of the great writer).

This model was the one Faulkner offered, and the Chinese reception

[24] Henry James, *Literary Criticism, Volume II: European Writers; Prefaces to the New York Edition*, New York: Library of America, 1984: "elaborately and massively dreary" (176), "an epic without air" (328).

[25] Marcel Proust, "À propos du 'style' de Flaubert," in *Contre Sainte-Beuve*, Paris: Gallimard/Pléiade, 1971, 586.

of Faulkner may be considered paradigmatic: before the Cultural Revolution, indeed, Chinese novels were specialized according to what may be termed professional genres—novels of the peasantry, novels of the military, novels of the party, and so forth. After the intellectuals returned from the countryside they could no longer sustain this segregation of the novel into class and social categories, which in any case themselves no longer existed. But of the many varieties of democratic or urban mass interaction available, Faulkner offered the additional advantage of a regionalism in which the life of the province subsumed land, town and city alike, and in which, most important of all, deep history existed and the memory of traumatic defeat subsisted into the present. The Faulknerian "now" at this point becomes something more than a feature of free indirect discourse and is transformed into a whole vision of the interpenetration of temporalities in a non-chronological experience of what is still place.

Faulkner's model thus breaks open a variety of traditions and enables the Latin American boom, with its magic realism, fully as much as all kinds of American "writing program" novels[26] all over the world, the Faulknerian sentence now becoming the excuse for a rebirth of rhetoric and its excesses (which take the place of any rebirth of melodrama or theatricality as such). These possibilities, for good or ill, allow for a flood of novelistic production—artistic and commercial alike—well beyond the bounds of the realistic structure described here.

Yet the weakening and dissolution of the latter must be documented in at least one additional way, by some account of the relationship of Irony to the transformation of the third person and the emergence of free indirect style we have been discussing here; and it is appropriate that this additional feature also be associated with the name of Flaubert. For it is noteworthy that in his account of the two stages of irony described by Wayne Booth in his *Rhetoric of Fiction*, the author of *Madame Bovary* is expressly singled out as the very fountainhead and source of that second "unstable" type[27] which Booth came to

[26] See Mark McGurl, *The Program Era*, Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 2009, along with my review of it in the *London Review of Books* 34:22 (November 22, 2012).

[27] Along with Céline. See *The Rhetoric of Fiction*. He reacted with anger to my characterization of him as "conservative" (I never saw the denunciation in the book's second edition), but I meant it in a purely literary and formal sense, in just such anti-modernist judgements as these.

abhor in his quest for those more stable moralistic judgements he found (paradoxically enough, as we shall see) in the fiction of Henry James. On his interesting narrative of the destinies of this literary phenomenon, what began life as a linguistic trope—stable irony as an effect—is with Flaubert transformed into something like an ideology and a nihilistic worldview; nor do I really wish to tell this story very differently, except for historicizing the change and for replacing the moral judgement with a structural description, in the process assigning Henry James a rather different historical role.

For if Flaubert is to be considered the inventor of unstable irony, as much on the strength of his "invention" of free indirect discourse as of anything else, then Henry James must be considered its ideologist, and its spokesperson throughout the literary landscape. This involves, no doubt, the substitution of the reproach of relativism for that of nihilism in the judgement that has been referred to; but such judgements are, in my opinion, like all political moralizing, simply category mistakes. We have here to do, not only with history, but with the history of forms; and it is better to begin with that kind of historical investigation rather than with taste and ideology.

Irony is to be sure intimately related to the emergence of point of view and its theorization; and the latter in turn to free indirect discourse and the feeling that the individual subject of perception and experience is an intelligible entity in its own right whose boundaries need to be respected. There thus arises a new kind of multiplicity, not that of objects and sensations, but of individual subjects. Free indirect discourse will mark the thoughts and perceptions of the subject in question on the level of the sentence; point of view will identify their mutual interrelationship on that of narrative as such. Both of these techniques, therefore, reflect that more general emergence of the subject of consciousness which we call individualism on the social level, as well as on the ideological one; and their codification as literary norms is then equally ideological.

If Flaubert is historically identified with the practice of *style indirect libre*, it is certainly Henry James whose name remains indissolubly related to the concept of point of view. But I think this association has less to do with his own narrative practice than with his critical and theoretical reflections on the art of the novel, which have been as fundamental for narrative analysis in modern times as Aristotle's for the classical world. James, indeed, wanted to be a professional writer, rather than an artist in Flaubert's sense, and I think it

might clarify our view of his work—revived and virtually inescapable in the post-war period, with its elaboration of an ideology of modernism—if we step back to recognize that he was essentially a writer of short stories or of their longer cousin, the art-novella—both quite different in their requirements than the novel itself, where James's few great achievements are perhaps better considered to be accidents of the content rather than the triumphant demonstration of his talent as a born novelist. The aesthetic of the short stories then turned on the discovery of that unique anecdotal material he called a "subject," but which for clarity's sake in the present context it might be better to identify more vaguely as "inspiration," starting point, narrative kernel, *Einfall*, or suggestive anecdote. At any rate, few are as reflexive and revealing, as autoreferential as the "Beast in the Jungle" (whose opening sentence I quoted at the beginning of this chapter): yet its premise, a man whose destiny is to have no destiny, underscores the continuing significance, for Jamesian storytelling, of that older fundamental category of the récit, which is destiny itself and its (more stable) ironies. It is therefore immensely revealing that when James brings his own practice to bear on the theorization of the novel itself, this category of the uniqueness of the individual destiny (or at least of that of the "subject" of the individual story or tale) should mutate into the requirement of point of view as the form in which the individuality of each character should be framed. (I leave aside the question of voyeurism, central to James's own life, and obviously one component of the insistence on seeing, on presence, on scene as such.)

The mutation of irony into Irony is, however, a development closely related to this one (if it is not, in fact, simply the same phenomenon seen from a different formal perspective): for here too a stable irony in the content has been transformed into the irony of form as such. For this new unstable Irony is a matter of moral judgement, rather than one of the appreciation of the "ironic" contingencies and coincidences of life; and it depends on being able to compare as it were the inside and the outside of a character, which is to say, on being able to step back out of the text itself.

I want to argue that this particular narrative operation is not possible in classical realism, that is, in Hamburger's third-person narrative. It is certainly unavailable and unperformable in the classical tale, where characters are almost exclusively seen from the outside, so that if any divergence in judgement takes place it involves a distance from

the text itself and the author, and not merely from within the text and from the character. In the older tale, such judgements generally fall into range of a melodramatic typology, in which there are, as we have shown, heroes and villains, secondary characters, helpers, lovers jealous, deceitful or devoted, comic caricatures and so forth.

This is a typology organized along the lines of traditional ethics and ruled by the ethical binary of good and evil; and it can of course undergo discovery—as when a villain is unmasked as a true friend, or a true friend unmasked as a villain; or in texts of increasing complexity, it could posit the slow development or transformation of a positive character into a negative one, as when a promising youngster goes bad, or a wastrel develops wisdom in his old age. But these are all functions of an external perspective, and they persist on into the nascent "true" realisms of the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries, where at best they are neutralized (by the attempt to eliminate melodrama and its standard plots and characters) and replaced by stretches of a greater introspection and a psychological notation which reduces our distance from the protagonists' thoughts and feelings without substituting new kinds of moral judgement for the older melodramatic ones.

The new developments to this early realism, then, are movements towards the impersonality of consciousness rather than towards irony. Lucien's weakness is still an external fact and judgement; and in that sense Balzac is always remorseless towards his own characters, however much from time to time he may sympathize with them: he has enough of them for the sympathies to go around, and if one falls short or goes to pieces, there will always be another one available. Stendhal would seem to be the exception here, yet his "ironies" are similarly based on side-taking, and on his identification with the protagonist, whom he constantly urges on, encouraging him even when he disappoints the author.

The point here is that judgements in the classical novel are made by the characters on one another, whether the author approves or not. Here in Jamesian point of view, we are so fully sealed into the protagonist's consciousness that we can scarcely see them from the outside: at best the outside judgement is an event within the story, a revelation and a shock, as when the father shows the protagonist of Kafka's "Judgment" what he really is. But in the Jamesian system, we have to step outside the text altogether in order to appreciate the fact that Densher is a gigolo and Kate a designing woman and a bird

of prey. But is this judgement really the one *The Wings of the Dove* wants us to make? Is it extra-literary? And if you like moral judgements, does this form strengthen the practice and the habit, or on the contrary gradually do away with it? I will hazard the guess that it is only by association with the last traces of the traditional narrative category of destiny or the irrevocable (Milly dies, after all, the "crime" has been committed) that such moral reactions and evaluations remain possible, and that thereafter, in the floodtide of the everyday, they are quickly swamped by the sheer multiplicity of points of view, which clearly do render them relative, in the sense of irrelevant.

At this point, then, a parting of the ways becomes unavoidable. The "serious" writer—that is, the one who aspires to the distinction of literature—will keep faith with what alone authentically survives the weakening of all the joints and joists, the bulkheads and loadbearing supports, of narrative as such, of the récit on its point of submersion: namely affect as such, whose triumph over its structural adversary is that bodiliness that alone marks any singularity in the everyday, and which now turns to engage its new literary adversary in lyric and language. Its fate is henceforth the fate of modernism, and no longer has any place in this particular story.

As for narrative, however, we have seen how a new kind of third person, along with point of view and all its newly available techniques, allows a rough substitute for the older vehicle to be maintained. This is no longer the realism I have been describing here, as the preponderance of dialogue over description in the interest of easy reading may testify. I am tempted to call this new and omnipresent narrative form the "existential" novel, insofar as it stands as a grim caricature of Sartre's diagnosis of an inauthentic narrative temporality and his prescription for an open work, in which the future remains in suspension—a work that turned out unexpectedly to harmonize with a late-capitalist and consumerist present eager to persuade us that nothing is irrevocable and that everything is possible. This is indeed the context in which, in the illimitable standardization and repetition of the everyday, categories of the Event began to emerge, as if to testify to their own absence, their own structural impossibility.

What secures the inexpensive mass production of such novels and their efficient functioning is a conjuncture of point of view, *style indirect libre* and the loosely named stream of consciousness. One does not evade the subject-object gap by way of philosophical

neologism and invention or by ingenious syntheses or the peremptory declaration that one side or the other does not exist: but one is also hesitant to endorse and reinforce it by using its terminology with abandon. Subjectivism is not the most useful reproach here, but rather the facile free association and the ease and speed with which a character can be shown to think when the truly ontological obstacles of objects and otherness have been evaded: a stream of perceptions, thoughts, desires, which are neither telling nor showing, but a performance that purports to offer both, at the same time that the novelist's narrative gets itself continued and then finished off. Such is the omnipresent production of realism after realism, as it lends its motor power to "serious" literature and the commercial kind alike.

It is not by adding a few metaphors, or interrupting these self-indulgent streams of consciousness with fragments of an alleged objectivity, that this historical situation and dilemma, which is that of contemporary literature, can be productively addressed. One does look back with a certain wistfulness at those mixtures of subject and object in which narrative carefully threads its way through the objective, its subject-centers brushing against this or that, luminously and momentarily transforming each passing thing into a flare of perception. So Galdós's multitude, with their varying mentalities, make their way cautiously and respectively through the new house, bestowing the admiration characteristic of the point of view of each, and pausing as is only fit to gape as follows at the bridal suite:

> They viewed the bridal chamber; the dressing-table, which in Doña Cándida's opinion was a *sweet little museum*; they rested in the rose-coloured boudoir, which seemed like one great open flower; they inspected the dining-room with its walnut chairs and sideboards in imitation of the old style; they admired the glass cabinets, in the dark depths of which there gleamed with a strange iridescence the silver and silver-plate. But what most interested the ladies was the kitchen range, one great cumbersome mass of iron, entirely of English manufacture, with a variety of plates, doors and divisions. It was an imposing contraption. "It only wants wheels to be a railway engine," said the knowledgeable Bringas, opening one door after the other to look inside this prodigy.[28]

It's too late to do this again, although it would be better than nothing: it has henceforth become the generic "novelesque," and

[28] *Torment*, trans. J. M. Cohen, New York: Farrar, Straus and Young, 1953, 215.

little is gained by redoing it in some *neue Sachlichkeit* or writing it up as a poem. Yet, historical destinies still exist somewhere and it is to be wondered what their literary fate may be now that affect has deserted them.

Chapter IX

Coda: Kluge, or, Realism after Affect

We have suggested that the breakdown of realism in the sense in which we have described it had essentially three historical outcomes: the first was clearly enough modernism, about which Roland Barthes' strategy of "tactical-style operations"[1] and local interventions seems the most prudent one. (In *A Singularity Modernity* I chose the option of describing a common situation from which the innumerable and varied modernisms all sprang, rather than seeking to invent some general theory under which they were all somehow subsumed.)

But who says modernism in the arts also says mass culture, since the two are dialectically and historically interdependent and arise at much the same moment. In the last and final chapter of this essay I showed how the breakdown of the realist tension between narrative and affect released uncontrolled linguistic production calculated to blacken endless pages of pseudo-realistic narratives classifiable by way of a return of the old genres and sub-genres that realism itself had attempted to dislodge (and had succeeded, but at the cost of its own destruction). At its best, the result, for which I could only find the term the "existential novel," now peoples the chain bookshops and the bestseller lists.

Yet beyond this symbiotic emergence of high modernism and mass culture, there now of course lies the postmodern and its narrative production (which in my opinion it is misleading to reduce to those playful autoreferential forms for which the intellectual media generally reserves that term). I want in conclusion to offer one remarkable example of a realism without affect: an utterly unpredictable one,

[1] Quoted in Alain Robbe-Grillet, *Why I Love Barthes*, trans. Andrew Brown, London: Polity, 2011, 39.

which has no parallels elsewhere in the world and is scarcely a paradigm for some generalized theory of the return of narrative or storytelling, but which may suggestively round out this particular literary-historical narrative.

In our mass cultural times the philosophical loftiness of Goethe's formula the "*unerhörte Begebenheit*" might better be rendered by Ripley's "Believe It or Not," which certainly offers an apt characterization of many of Alexander Kluge's tales. Let's illustrate it with his "Mass Fatality in Venice,"[2] of which I quote the opening lines:

> In the summer of 1969 the sun beat down for weeks without end on the urban and watery landscape of Venice. Steamers and motorboats plowed through green lagoons that surrounded the houses like thick soup. Some hundred elderly people were sheltered in the old people's home of San Lorenzo, a stone palace. They got no air. Twenty-four elderly residents died within a few hours on one of the last days of July. The survivors, taken unawares by these sudden events which they had no time to digest, refused to permit the removal of the bodies. They killed the director of the institute, Dr. Muratti, a respected gerontologist, equipped themselves with knives and lead pipes, as well as two revolvers which they found in the director's office. They drove the inmates of the home as well as its nurses and kitchen personnel into a capacious groundfloor room which seemed the coolest room in the building. Here several of the elderly, physically the strongest, established a dictatorship, promoting themselves to popes and cardinals.

As might be expected, the city brings in troops, the building is retaken and its leaders killed, and in a final twist, the few elderly survivors of the massacre are shipped off into the Tyrol, where they die of the cold.

This nasty little story will serve to illustrate, not postmodernism in general, which takes many forms and shapes, but at least what happens to both narrativity and affect after the end of their brief union. We will make two observations about narrativity as such in connection with the present illustration.

The first is a generic one: this is not a short story or *Novelle*, nor does it correspond to any of the official literary categorizes of the tradition. It has no author, for example, not even an implied one; and might well have merely been a clipping from a newspaper. This indeed puts us on the track of its structural identity: it is what the journalists call a *fait divers*, and what conversationalists might identify

[2] Alexander Kluge, "Massensterben in Venedig," in *Chronik der Gefühle*, Frankfurt: Suhrkamp, 2004, Volume II, 461, translation mine.

as an anecdote. Most of Kluge's narrative work (at least in writing) falls into that no man's land between the two.

At best, from narrative analysis, we may retain a paradoxical intersection of two story lines: what the city government tries to do in this emergency of the heat wave; what the inmates do in the closed world which is their social home, presumably their last one. If there is any paradigmatic metaphor here it calls up the image of the prison revolt (and whatever meaning the fait divers has—or that we are tempted to assign it—comes from that analogy).

But the fait divers—and in gossip in general the anecdote as well—is also defined by its historical reality: it did really take place ("elderly woman robbed and killed for two dollars!"). The signed anecdote called *Massensterben in Venedig* raises the question I think we do not ask ourselves during the reading of it—namely whether such a thing really happened at all, or whether Kluge, in the seemingly infinite fertility of his imagination, made it all up in the first place. Is the generic frame of the fait divers a guarantee of its actuality? Does the absence of authorial presence make the attribution to a real individual named Alexander Kluge irrelevant? The evident futility of such questions confronts us with a unique development, namely the utter effacement of any separation between the fictive and the non-fictive. If this text is characteristic of the survival of an older récit impulse after the end of affect, then it also testifies to the disappearance of "fiction" as such, as a meaningful (narrative) category.

Indeed, the impending crisis of the fictional, and its consequences for art in general, was anticipated by Thomas Mann, in *Doktor Faustus*, where the devil warns the protagonist (a composer) about the public's increasing discomfort with *Schau* ("aesthetic appearance," here weakly translated as "pretence"):

> "The historical movement of the musical material has turned against the self-contained work. It shrinks in time, it scorns extension in time, which is the dimensions of a musical work, and lets it stand empty. Not out of impotence, not out of incapacity to give form. Rather from a ruthless demand for compression, which taboos the superfluous, negates the phrase, shatters the ornament, stands opposed to any extension of time, which is the life-form of the work. Work, time, and pretence [*Schau*], they are one, and together they fall victim to critique. It no longer tolerates pretence and play, the fiction, the self-glorification of form, which censors the passions and human suffering, divides out the parts, translates into pictures. Only the non-fictional is still permissible, the unplayed, the undisguised and untransfigured expression of suffering in its actual moment.

Its impotence and extremity are so ingrained that no seeming play with them is any longer allowed."[3]

We could easily make connections with Freud's identification of our resistance to other people's fantasies and daydreams,[4] or on the other hand to the exhaustion of narrative itself, as well as the increasing attention to minute segments of the everyday, however narcissistic this may be. The intellectual's perpetual guilt about his preoccupation with art in the midst of universal suffering and starvation is also relevant here: Bourdieu's analyses, following the Sartrean notion of ontological self-justification, insist on the way in which all professional activities today (including intellectual labor) demand a kind of institutional vindication for their importance, and indeed their very existence. Meanwhile, after the short-lived bubble of the "nonfiction" novel, new defenses of reality and the factual have begun to reappear;[5] and we may well wonder whether "fictionality" or *Schein* plays any great part in the contemporary visual arts, which insist so strongly on our attention to their materials as such.

But the most interesting theoretical counterposition with which to place this one of Thomas Mann (which can be imagined to derive as much from Adorno) is the defense by Gilles Deleuze of the "*faux*":[6] the pleasures of the false and the counterfeit, of sheer appearance ranging all the way to delirium, a kind of ultimate apologia, in the face of that grim duty of realism to which Lukács seemed to summon us, of what we now call the postmodern in the more limited sense of the word: simulacrum, image, model or imitation without an original. Nor does it seem to me impossible that one form of contemporary narrative will consist in the absolute superposition of Deleuze's "*faux*" upon the strictest empirical fact.

I myself think, however, that the weakening of the fictional also tends to undermine its opposite number, the category of the factual;[7]

[3] Thomas Mann, *Doctor Faustus*, trans. Helen Lowe-Porter, New York: Knopf, 1948 [1947], 240.

[4] In Freud, "Creative Writers and Daydreaming," *The Standard Edition*, volume IX, London: Hogarth Press, 1959.

[5] See, for example, David Shields, *Reality Hunger: A Manifesto*, New York: Vintage, 2011.

[6] Gilles Deleuze, *Cinéma II*, Paris: Minuit, 1985, chapter 6, "Puissances du faux."

[7] Catherine Gallagher's dramatic identification of fictionality—Barthes' "romanesque"—with the novel itself ("The Rise of Fictionality," in Franco Moretti, ed., *The Novel, Volume 1: History, Geography, and Culture*, Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2006) usefully refocuses this issue and helpfully complicates it—the purpose of theory being not to invent solutions but to produce problems in the first place.

and that this is the point where we find ourselves on the threshold of a new world, which Kluge may be entering here.

But what about that disappearance of affect, what could possibly validate such a claim? Irony is not, to be sure, exactly an affective phenomenon in the ordinary sense of the word, but its utter absence from this blank text is revealing, and makes characterizations such as "terrible," "grotesque" or even the word "nasty" I myself used here with all due precaution—it makes all such characterizations absolutely irrelevant. Pity and terror? If so, then only in the form they might take in the mind of some glacial intelligence observing these events from over a great distance, as a researcher might examine a battle to the death of ant armies.

I want to stress the irrelevance as well of another category frequent (and quite appropriate) in much of contemporary criticism, and it is that of minimalism. How else is minimalism described in its essence than in the radical, even ostentatious omission of emotion and affect from the surface of the narrative, as in Hemingway or Raymond Carver? (Even though, as I should remark here, it is the absence of affect from their dialogue that is the most striking: while there is no dialogue at all in this narrative of Kluge, as indeed in many of his short narratives of this kind.)

But the withholding of emotion or affect (the dividing line between the two in both minimalist writers would also merit some discussion) is meant in them to make such feeling and inner turmoil emerge all the more powerfully for the reader. The absence is as profoundly expressive as its overt externalization in other writers, particularly those of a "maximalist" persuasion.

Here in Kluge there is nothing, not even a judgement on one of the players. We could imagine a denunciation of state bureaucracy, or an indictment of the irrepressible lust for power of human nature, or an arraignment of the social services which confine the elderly in this way, let alone a more metaphysical lament about man's vulnerability to natural catastrophe or to the elements; but none of those themes or interpretations takes with any plausibility on the icy surfaces of the text.

Nor is Kluge himself, the author (often with Oskar Negt) of numerous works of social theory, without ideas or philosophical theses to

defend. His political interests have tended to turn on pedagogy (as the title of the original collection from which our story is chosen—*Lernprozesse mit todlichem Ausgang*, or *Learning processes with deadly outcomes*—suggests): the proposition would seem to imply a capture of energies, their direction and investment in negative or positive activities. It is at best a quantitative rather than a qualitative concept, one of the measurement of intensities rather than any content-laden value. Indeed, in this sense this thought of Kluge seems closer to the affective intensities evoked earlier in these chapters; and perhaps indeed this is the last remnant of the affective dynamite persisting in a narrative in which the pure récit has somehow been reestablished.

I would also want to argue that the neutrality of the newspaper-style report also reflects a new and immensely heterogeneous global readership (not that Kluge himself enjoys this kind of reception): a massed population for which context and its explanations and interpretations is useless, their omission giving rise to the abstraction of the pure empirical facts themselves, the fait-divers in all its shocking and contingent immediacy. No doubt such radically meaningless anecdotes are the result of the dissolution of both realism and modernism together, and an appropriate ending for the present speculative history; but they are unlikely to be the only kinds of narratives the future has in store for us.

PART II

THE LOGIC OF THE MATERIAL

Chapter I

The Experiments of Time: Providence and Realism

1.

Happy endings are not as easy to bring off as you might think, at least in literature: but they are in any case a literary category and not an existential one. It is much easier to have your protagonist end badly; but perhaps here the perils of an arbitrary authorial decision are even more evident, and the outcome has to be more openly justified by some larger ideological concept—either the aesthetics of tragedy or that metaphysics of failure that dominated the naturalist novel and still very much govern our imagination of poverty and underdevelopment.

Nor is the happy ending quite the same as the "living happily ever after" with which youthful adventures so often terminate. Comedy, on Northrop Frye's account the phallic triumph of the younger generation over the older one,[1] is a theatrical sub-set of that plot-type; but its novelistic equivalents already tend in a different direction, the providential one, which is our topic here.

Not only does the *Aethiopica* add a reconciliation with the father to the reuniting of the lovers; it also (paradigmatically) separates them by way of a multitude of plots that must all be resolved in their individual stroke of good luck:

> "The child you regarded as your daughter, the child I committed to your keeping all those years ago, is safe," he exclaimed, "though in truth she is, and has been discovered to be, the child of parents whose identity you know!"
>
> Now Charikleia came running from the pavilion and, oblivious of the modesty incumbent on her sex and years, raced like a maenad in her madness towards

[1] Northrop Frye, *Anatomy of Criticism*, Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1957, 163ff.

Charikles and fell at his feet.

"Father," she said, "to you I owe as much reverence as to those who gave me birth. I am a wicked parricide; punish me as you please; ignore any attempts to excuse my misdeeds by ascribing them to the will of the gods, to their governance of human life!"

A few feet away, Persinna held Hydaspes in her arms. "It is all true, my husband," she said. "You need have no doubts. Understand now that this young Greek is truly to be our daughter's husband. She has just confessed as much to me, though it cost her much pain."

The populace cheered and danced for joy where they stood, and there was no discordant voice as young and old, rich and poor, united in jubilation.[2]

The greatest modern version of this narrative cunningly marshals its two immense trajectories (the plights of each lover) to map the geographical and the class levels of a whole historical society: at the same time, *I promessi sposi* now, at the end of the Christian era, includes the reflexive and philosophical questions about the providential and the salvational as its very content. At that price, the reunion of the young lovers turns out to include a temporal perspective far vaster than the triumph of youth over age.[3]

The point to be made is that the salvational is not a religious but a philosophical category. We must not grasp the tradition I want to propose as the mere secularization of a theological drama. Indeed, Blumenberg has famously taught us that this concept is a paralogism, designed either to discredit the alleged religious presuppositions of secularizations (such as Marxism), or to assert the unconscious persistence of religion throughout the seemingly modern and modernized world.[4] In reality, we have here to do with forms, which, inherited, are reappropriated for wholly new meanings and uses that have nothing to do with the historical origins of their borrowed articulations. Thus the very theme of resurrection itself—theologically the most glorious of all salvational representations—is scarcely to be understood in any religious sense: from its figural deployment in Proust ("*l'adoration perpétuelle*") to its literal celebration in Stanley Spencer's paintings (let alone in *The Winter's Tale*), resurrection expresses the euphoria of

[2] B. P. Reardon, *Collected Ancient Greek Novels*, Berkeley: University of California Press, 1989, 586–7.

[3] See also Jameson, "Magical Narratives: On the Dialectical Use of Genre Criticism," in *The Political Unconscious: Narrative as a Socially Symbolic Act*, Ithaca: Cornell, 1981, 103–50.

[4] Hans Blumenberg, *The Legitimacy of the Modern Age*, Cambridge: MIT Press, 1966.

a secular salvation otherwise inexpressible in material or social terms, religious language here offering the means of rendering a material possibility rather than the other way round.

It is this possibility that the providential work embodies: and if I claim that it does so philosophically, I mean by that to imply that (unlike the long-existing theological concept) no philosophical concept for the matter exists independently, and that therefore it is only by way of aesthetic representation that this reality can be grasped. But I also mean the word "philosophical" to imply that the local representation—the story of individuals, the empirical reality—must always in this form be shadowed by a more transcendental philosophical idea—just as I would assert that the naturalist rendering of bad luck and inevitable degradation is presided over by a constellation of more abstract and totalizing class and scientific ideologies (from entropy to the bourgeois terror of proletarianization, as well as that of the "decline of the West").

It will be appropriate to illustrate the process in the very different register of Science Fiction: indeed, at the heart of one of Philip K. Dick's grimmest novels, *Martian Time-Slip*, we encounter a salvational episode of the most radiant beauty.

Like so much paraliterature (the relationship between modern detective stories and specific cities is well-known), SF is often a literature of place and landscape, albeit imaginary ones: Dick's Mars is the prototype of his characteristic desert of misery, in which the most dismal features of a provincial 1950s America are unremittingly reproduced and perpetuated against a backdrop of ecological sterility and the intensive use of low-yield machinery. Cultural reminiscences of Australia waft off this unpromising colony, which still has remnants of its aboriginal population (here called Bleekmen) and nourishes Tasmanian fantasies of extermination. Dick's multiple alternating plots (whose virtuoso practice recalls Dickens or Altman), which typically include political corruption and dysfunctional families, mental illness and professional failure, would not be complete without the opening onto nightmare and hallucination, here incarnated in the autistic child Manfred, whose speech consists in the single word "gubble." It expresses Manfred's view through the appearances of things to "the skull beneath the skin," the horrible amalgams of machinery and garbage that constitute the deeper reality of the outside world and its population. It is a glimpse theorized by Lacan in his notion of *das Ding*, the monstrous indeterminate and

inexpressible Other that bides its time in that "outside world" inside each of us.[5]

But in fact Manfred's situation is a time-travelling one: the real life of the mentally paralyzed child is "in reality" the aged, infirm, hospitalized old man he will in many years become, imprisoned in an early version of that "Black Iron Prison" ("the Empire never ended") which haunted Dick's later life and work.[6] But here a redemptive solution is still possible, owing to the temporal simultaneity of the Bleekmen (patterned on the aboriginal cosmos), who, fleeing their own immanent genocide, are able to save another orphan by rescuing the aged Manfred from his terminal confinement and carrying him off into the eternal Dreamtime:

> She and Jack pushed past the child, and into the house. Silvia did not understand what she saw, but Jack seemed to; he took hold of her hand, stopped her from going any farther.
>
> The living room was filled with Bleekmen. And in their midst she saw part of a living creature, an old man only from the chest on up; the rest of him became a tangle of pumps and hoses and dials, machinery that clicked away, unceasingly active. It kept the old man alive; she realized that in an instant. The missing portion of him had been replaced by it. Oh, God, she thought. Who or what was it, sitting there with a smile on its withered face? Now it spoke to them.
>
> "Jack Bohlen," it rasped, and its voice issued from a mechanical speaker, out of the machinery: not from its mouth. "I am here to say goodbye to my mother." It paused, and she heard the machinery speed up, as if it were laboring. "Now I can thank you," the old man said.
>
> Jack, standing by her, holding her hand, said, "For what? I didn't do anything for you."
>
> "Yes, I think so." The thing seated there nodded to the Bleekmen, and they pushed it and its machinery closer to Jack and straightened it so that it faced him directly. "In my opinion..." It lapsed into silence and then it resumed, more loudly, now. "You tried to communicate with me, many years ago. I appreciate that."[7]

[5] *L'Ethique de la psychanalyse* (*Le Séminaire*, livre VII), Paris: Seuil, 1986, chapters iv and v, 55–86.

[6] Philip K. Dick, *Valis*, New York: Vintage, 1991, 48 (chapter 4). I am grateful to Kim Stanley Robinson for this reference; he adds that "The Building, in *A Maze of Death* (chapter 9), is certainly a nightmare of a building, in a nightmare of a book. Then in *A Scanner Darkly* the ending happens in a forbidding mental hospital, 'Samarkand House,' and in *Galactic Pot-Healer*, the final Jungian project is to bring up The Black Cathedral (à la Debussy)."

[7] Philip K. Dick, *Martian Time-Slip*, New York: Ballantine, 1964, 218–19 (chapter 16). For more on the relationship of this episode to Dick's world generally, see my essay "History and Salvation in Philip K. Dick," *Archaeologies of the Future: The Desire Called Utopia and Other Science Fictions*, New York: Verso, 2007.

It is a deliverance into which one can no doubt read Dick's later religious mysticism; yet the theme of modes of production (the modern and the archaic) also reminds us to reverse this direction and to sense a social and historical redemption at work behind the individual one.

2.

And this is in fact the other axis that complicates our philosophical framework, and which runs, not from success to failure and back, but from the individual to the collective.

Kant's empirical/transcendental "doublet," and in fact the providential conundrum itself, organized as it is around categories of the individual subject, does not seem to me thinkable (which is not to imply that the thinkable can ever satisfactorily be resolved) unless we reconnect it with that other theological motif which takes history rather than individuality as its field of problems and paradoxes.

For rather than providence and the providential, the notion of predestination can illustrate our point here: for even in the realm of theology itself, this notion has been a "hard saying" that often and traditionally "sticks in the craw." Yet predestination illustrates Kant's two levels of the empirical and the transcendental[8] almost better than any other attempt at a concept, for it claims to solve this dilemma (which it merely names)—namely that of the distinction between the realm of freedom and that of necessity, that of the noumenon and that of the phenomenon, that of the transcendental and that of the empirical—by paradoxically locating the latter in the power of the divine, and the former in that of human subjectivity. What the concept of predestination asserts, in other words, is that an iron necessity governs my empirical acts and my personal destiny—this iron necessity is that of God's providence and of his determination of that destiny from all eternity, and before time itself.[9] I am, in empiri-

[8] See the Introduction to the *Critique of Pure Reason*, Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1997, 117–52. For the contemporary relevance of this distinction, see Michel Foucault, *The Order of Things*, New York: Vintage, 1994, 241–4.

[9] For the modern revival of Augustine's doctrine, see Bernard M. G. Reardon, *Religious Thought in the Reformation*, London: Longman, 1981.

cal reality, one of the elect or one of the damned, and I can exercise no freedom in influencing these outcomes. No individual act of mine exerts any kind of causality in their predetermined course. However, on the level of my individual consciousness or soul (Kant's noumenal realm of freedom), things stand utterly differently, and I can have no subjective sense of my election or my damnation: here I am left alone with my existential freedom and must necessarily choose my acts and make my decisions as though I were completely free.

This version of the problem now involves a dialectic of the sign or even of the symptom which is very contemporary indeed. It is resumed in the famous phrase "the outward and visible signs of inward election"; and this rather casuistical cutting of the Gordian knot can be summarized as follows: Nothing we do can ensure our election (rather than our damnation), but if in fact we happen to be one of the elect (chosen from all eternity) our behavior on earth will reflect this condition. It will therefore constitute an empirical sign of our noumenal and unknowable salvation in the transcendental realm. Hypocrisy is the tribute vice pays to virtue, someone famously said: and thus, even though it can have no causal effect, no genuine effectivity, we would do well to behave virtuously on the off chance our fate will be harmonious with this conduct. Only the more logical negative conclusion here—that if election is from all eternity, then it does not matter how I behave—has offered truly remarkable novelistic possibilities, above all in James Hogg's *Personal Memoirs and Confessions of a Justified Sinner* (1824). But the dilemma gets more productively restaged on the political and historical level.

Here we move from the individual destiny to the collective one; and the salvation of the soul is replaced by that of the human race itself, or in other words by Utopia and socialist revolution. But the well-known alternative within the Marxist tradition between voluntarism and fatalism absolutely coincides with the theological antinomy, which can thus be said to anticipate and to "prefigure" its more secular problematic in a distorted, still figurative and theological, and essentially individual way. The Mensheviks and the Bolsheviks are themselves mere personifications of this primordial opposition, in which a conviction as to the objective movement of history is opposed by a militant sense of the power of human beings to make history. Clearly, nothing is more debilitating than an opposition of this kind, which tends to sort itself out into a passive/active one in which neither alternative is satisfactory. For to oppose a placid Second-International

confidence in the "inevitable" movement of history towards a socialist state is not necessarily only to show faith in the shaping powers of human beings; it is also to encourage the most mindless forms of suicidal attempts to "force" history, to break through its logic prematurely, to encourage young people to die in what are causes lost in advance owing to the fact that "the situation is not yet ripe," not yet a revolutionary one. As with predestination, however, there is nothing to guide us in this choice and no empirical signs are available to allow us to have any certainty of "election," that is to say, of the possibility of revolution as the one supreme salvational or providential Event.

But in this secular and collective version, in fact there is a kind of solution, and one not unrelated to the unconvincing theological one in such a way as to demonstrate that the latter was only really a distorted anticipation of the former. For here, what is taken as voluntarism—that is, the collective will to force history—is itself seen, not as a subjective choice, but as an objective symptom, in that sense very precisely an objective component of that history itself. Thus, an infantile leftism or anarchist voluntarism now becomes that "external sign" that revolution is not yet on the agenda and that the situation has not yet politically "matured." What was not solvable on the level of Hogg's theological hero here becomes a piece of historical evidence, a historical sign fully as significant as all the others. It is in the old theological spirit that one may also say that the passive "inevitabilism" of the Second International was itself a sign of immaturity and of an insufficiently developed political situation. This new symptomal interpenetration of the subjective and the objective thus now suddenly signals a transcendence of the old antinomy, and a moment in which the providential has become empirical, and Kant's two realms of transcendence and empiricism overcome as specific historical ratios. It thus also designates a new kind of social content for the novel as form, and the possibility of new kinds of narration.

It is to these that we must now turn, with the help of such findings: these last in effect signal the fundamental difference in possibility between the individual and the collective and suggest that we reinterrogate the novelistic form for just such consequences. The debate between revolutionaries about voluntarism and fatalism becomes, to be sure, a limited kind of specialized content for some officially political novel—what I have elsewhere called a kind of Third International literary dialectic in which this specific dilemma, most fully exacerbated by the peculiar position of Stalinist revolution in one country,

gets played out.[10] (Sartre's works are some of the most interesting versions of these tragic paradoxes, which tend to be invisible in an anti-communist focus). But as with the theological material, it is not this specific content, but rather the larger form in general which interests us here.

3.

I now therefore want to return to the mainstream realist novel in order to make a few further remarks about the form-generating and form-producing value of the providential within realism itself. For the moment what is crucial for us is the distinction between the individual perspective and the collective one, when it comes to providence or happy endings. This turns out to be an evolutionary matter, for as in the purely theological realm, there is a decided historical movement from the individual destiny to the collective one (or from issues of individual salvation to those of political and revolutionary transformations, as in our preceding discussion).

But there are intermediate steps, and as it were external operators, which move us from the individual narrative to the collective one. To be sure, the first theological transfers take place naturally enough in the framework of an individual destiny, and it has been universally recognized that the very prototype of a truly individualized and isolated individual destiny, *Robinson Crusoe*, is saturated with providential impulses of various kinds.[11] The novel uniquely enables the interiorization of the various external adventures and episodes which had hitherto formed the space in which the happy or the tragic ending was played out—the realm of accidents, the contingent, chance of a meaningful kind, etc. Later on, these will be simply omens and not causes, as when Julien Sorel finds a prophetic scrap of paper in a church early in *The Red and the Black*. The interiorization of chance now means that contingency can offer the opportunity for an inward experience or development. But I think that the debate as to whether Defoe himself was a Christian is misplaced: we have here rather the

[10] See my Introduction to Peter Weiss, *The Aesthetics of Resistance*, Volume 1, Durham: Duke University Press, 2005.

[11] The classic discussions are those of G. A. Starr, *Defoe and Spiritual Autobiography*, Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1965; and J. Paul Hunter, *The Reluctant Pilgrim*, Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1966.

template for the organization of experiences in a new way, in which religious influence is itself a mere external and enabling condition. Such developments need to be seen synchronically, in obedience to Blumenberg's warning about the pseudo-concept of "secularization." To be sure, it is not wrong to say that the *Bildungsroman* is then a secularization of this earlier, already secular "spiritual autobiography" of Defoe; but neither stage retains the meaning of the preceding one, but only the form. Thus it would be wrong to say that the *Bildungsroman* is still religious in its (now secular) concern for the state of the individual soul: no, what is deployed now is a mere form which organizes its new social material in an analogous way.

For our topic, it may be said that *Wilhelm Meister* is the decisive turning point, and as it were the true beginning of the nineteenth-century novel, the end of something as well as the beginning of something else, which is however its mutation and its adaptation to the new post-revolutionary society (a society which did not, of course, yet exist in Germany and scarcely elsewhere yet at that). This is a peculiarly central evaluation for such an odd and garbled book, immensely influential and yet a kind of literary white elephant, boring and fascinating all at once, and a perpetual question mark for the French and British traditions in which, as a text, it has played so small a role, yet which are incomprehensible without it, as we shall see.

The novel of formation, the novel of education?[12] It would be better to translate *Bildungsroman* as the novel of a calling or vocation, a *Beruf*, to use that word which Max Weber charged with its most intense Lutheran accents in order to make his point about the new inner-worldliness of Protestant behavior and virtue. Not that Wilhelm is at all secure in his ultimate vocation: the critics are at least sure that the latter is no longer the artistic calling or the surrender to genius that had been projected in the first draft (the *Theatralische Sendung*). Yet the rhetoric of the ending—so glorious and so determinate for several generations of *Bildungsromane* if not of providential narrative itself—is strangely at odds with the actual situation (Wilhelm is about to set off on a trip just like Goethe himself):

[12] The perspective adopted here does not allow me to endorse Franco Moretti's ideological analysis of the form, in *The Way of the World* (London: Verso, 1987), which remains the most stimulating and comprehensive discussion of this novelistic sub-genre. It will be apparent below that mine is rather an ideological indictment of what I call "ontological realism" as such.

To my mind thou resemblest Saul the son of Kish, who went out to seek his father's asses, and found a kingdom.[13]

Indeed, the principal role of "providence" here would seem to be a negative one: "Flee, youth, flee!" (313). Above all, he is not to become a mere actor, and his one-time success in *Hamlet* is owing, as Boyle rightly insists, to the pre-established harmony between his own personality and that of the Prince.[14] But for the greater part of the play the Prince is also tormented by the question of what to do, and what the superego—the father's Ghost (which also plays a significant part in *Meister*)—commands. Wilhelm's real father, however, proposes a life of commerce and trade, which, along with theatricals, is the one vocation quite decisively repudiated.[15] I will suggest in passing that by the end of the novel the authority of the Father has been displaced by that of the brothers; but I do not want to overemphasize this theme of the Big Other, which does not seem particularly important for Goethe here or elsewhere.

That "providence" is a fundamental theme of the novel, however, can be judged from recurrent discussions, which seem to propose a philosophical alternative between destiny and chance: "I easily content myself, and honor destiny, which knows how to bring about what is best for me, and what is best for everyone" (says Wilhelm). To which the first of his mysterious acquaintances replies:

Leider höre ich schon wieder das Wort Schicksal von einem jungen Manne aussprechen. Wehe dem, der sich von Jugend auf gewöhnt, in dem Notwendigen etwas Willkürliches finden zu wollen, der dem Zufälligen eine Art von Vernunft zuschreiben möchte, welcher zu folgen sogar eine Religion sei. Heisst das etwas weiter, als seinem eignen Verstande entsagen und seinen Neigungen unbedingten Raum geben? Wir bilden uns ein, fromm zu sein, indem wir ohne Überlegung hinschlendern, uns durch angenehme Zufälle determinieren lassen und endlich dem Resultate eines solchen schwankenden Lebens den Namen einer göttlichen Führung geben. (71)

[13] References to *Wilhelm Meister* in the text are adapted from Thomas Carlyle's English translation of the novel (New York: Heritage, 1959), in this instance, book 8, chapter 10, p. 657; and in the German original, to *Wilhelm Meisters Lehrjahre* (Frankfurt: Insel, 1982), p. 626.

[14] Nicholas Boyle, *Goethe: The Poet and the Age*, Volume II, Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2000, 336.

[15] Ibid., 239–40; and see also Giuliano Baioni, "Gli anni di apprendistato," in *Il Romanzo*, Volume II, Einaudi, 2002, 127–33.

It gives me pain to hear this word destiny in the mouth of a young person … Woe to him who, from his youth, has become accustomed to search for something like will within necessity; to ascribe to chance a sort of reason, which it is a matter of religion to obey. Is conduct like this aught else than to renounce one's understanding, and give unrestricted scope to one's inclinations? We think it is a kind of piety to move along without consideration; to let accidents that please us determine our conduct; and, finally, to bestow on the result of such a vacillating life the name of providential guidance. (63–4)

That this is not merely the expression of a standard Enlightenment denunciation of superstition and religion, and an appeal to secular reason, may be externally deduced by the obedience to one's daimon, so dear to this author, as is apparent from texts like "Urworte Ophisch." Here, however, it is enough to point out that the warning of this stranger inserts itself into the very web of chance and coincidence that make up the novel's stream of events: which is therefore itself drawn inside the theme, and interrogated for its own function as that predestined chance we call providence.

We thus arrive at the work's well-known secret: innumerable characters (although mostly divided socially between the wandering theater people, whose triviality estranged Goethe's first intellectual readership, and the aristocracy of this Germany of the principalities in which Goethe was to make himself so eminent a place); a veritable orgy of interpolated stories and Gothic destinies, full of rather random recognition scenes and rediscovered kinships of various sorts; love affairs meanwhile, of the tentative sort riddled with flights and avoidances with which Goethe's biography and psychology have familiarized us. These materials scarcely seem to add up to any very consistent focus of representation or stylization, nor are any of them particularly powerful or commanding in their own right. But now, at the center of the text, a long dream, in which characters from a host of different plot strands come together:

Sonderbare Traumbilder erschienen ihm gegen morgen. Er fand sich in einem Garten, den er als Knabe öfters besucht hatte, und sah mit Vernügen die bekannten Alleen, Hecken und Blumenbeete wieder; Marianne begegnete ihm, er sprach liebevoll mit ihr und ohne Erinnerung irgendeines vergangen Mißverhältnisses. Gleich darauf trat sein Vater zu ihnen, im Hauskleide; und mit vertraulicher Miene, die ihm selten war, hieß er den Sohn zwei Stühle aus dem Gartenhause holen, nahm Mariannen bei der Hand und fürhte sie nach einer Laube.

Wilhelm eilte nach dem Gartensaale, fand ihn aber ganz leer, nur sah er Aurelien an dem entgegengesetzten Fenster stehen; er ging, sie anzureden, allein sie blieb unverwandt, und ob er sich gleich neben sie stellte, konnte er doch ihr

Gesicht nicht sehen. Er blickte zum Fenster hinaus und sah, in einem fremden Garten, viele Menschen beisammen, von denen er einige sogleich erkannte. Frau Melina saß unter einem Baum und spielte mit einer Rose, die sie in der Hand hielt; Laertes stand neben ihr und zählte Gold aus seiner Hand in die andere. Mignon und Felix lagen im Grase, jene ausgestreckt auf dem Rücken, dieser auf dem Gesichte. Philine trat hervor and klatschte über den Kindern in die Hände, Mignon blieb unbeweglich, Felix sprang auf und floh vor Philinen. Erst lachte er im Laufen, als Philine ihn verfolgte, dann schrie er ängstlich, als der Harfenspieler mit großen, langsamen Schritten ihm nachging. Das Kind lief grade auf einen Teich los; Wilhelm eilte ihm nach, aber zu spät, das Kind lag im Wasser! Wilhelm stand wie eingewurzelt. Nun sah er die schöne Amazone an der andern Seite des Teichs, sie streckte ihre rechte Hand gegen das Kind aus und ging am Ufer hin, das Kind durchstrich das Wasser in gerader Richtung auf den Finger zu und folgte ihr nach, wie sie ging, endlich reichte sie ihm ihre Hand und zog es aus dem Teiche. Wilhelm war indessen näher gekommen, das Kind brannte über und über, und es fielen feurige Tropfen von ihm herab. Wilhelm war noch besorgter, doch die Amazone nahm schnell einen weißen Schleier vom Haupte und bedeckte das Kind damit. Das Feuer war sogleich gelöscht. Als sie den Schleier aufhob, sprangen zwei Knaben hervor, die zusammen mutwillig hin und her spielten, als Wilhelm mit der Amazone Hand in Hand durch den Garten ging und in der Entfernung seinen Vater und Mariannen in einer Allee spazieren sah, die mit hohen Bäumen den ganzen Garten zu umgeben schien. Er richtete seinen Weg auf beide zu, und machte mit seiner schönen Begleiterin den Durchschnitt des Gartens, als auf einmal der blonde Friedrich ihnen in den Weg trat und sie mit großem Gelächter und allerlei Possen aufhielt. Sie wollten demungeachtet ihren Weg weiter fortsetzen; da eilte er weg und lief auf jenes entfernte Paar zu; der Vater und Marianne schienen vor ihm zu fliehen, er lief nur desto schneller, und Wilhelm sah jene fast im Fluge durch die Allee hinschweben. Natur und Neigung forderten ihn auf, jenen zu Hilfe zu kommen, aber die Hand der Amazone hielt ihn zurück. Wie gern ließ er sich halten! Mit dieser gemischten Empfindung wachte er auf und fand sein Zimmer schon von der hellen Sonne erleuchtet. (458–9)

Strange dreams arose upon him towards morning. He was in a garden, which in boyhood he had often visited: he looked with pleasure at the well-known alleys, hedges, flower-beds. Mariana met him: he spoke to her with love and tenderness, recollecting nothing of any by-gone grievance. Erelong his father joined them, in his weekday dress; with a look of frankness that was rare in him, he bade his son fetch two seats from the garden-house; then took Mariana by the hand, and led her into a grove.

Wilhelm hastened to the garden-house, but found it altogether empty: only at a window in the farther side he saw Aurelia standing. He went forward, and addressed her, but she turned not round; and, though he placed himself beside her, he could never see her face. He looked out from the window: in an unknown garden, there were several people, some of whom he recognized. Frau Melina,

seated under a tree, was playing with a rose which she had in her hand: Laertes stood beside her, counting money from the one hand to the other. Mignon and Felix were lying on the grass, the former on her back, the latter on his face. Philina came, and clapped her hands above the children: Mignon lay unmoved; Felix started up and fled. At first he laughed while running, as Philina followed; but he screamed in terror when he saw the harper coming after him with large, slow steps. Felix ran directly to a pond. Wilhelm hastened after him: too late; the child was lying in the water! Wilhelm stood as if rooted to the spot. The fair Amazon appeared on the other side of the pond: she stretched her right hand towards the child, and walked along the shore. The child came through the water, by the course her finger pointed to; he followed her as she went round; at last she reached her hand to him, and pulled him out. Wilhelm had come nearer: the child was all in flames; fiery drops were falling from his body. Wilhelm's agony was greater than ever; but instantly the Amazon took a white veil from her head, and covered up the child with it. The fire was at once quenched. But, when she lifted up the veil, two boys sprang out from under it, and frolicsomely sported to and fro; while Wilhelm and the Amazon proceeded hand in hand across the garden, and noticed in the distance Mariana and his father walking in an alley, which was formed of lofty trees, and seemed to go quite round the garden. He turned his steps to them, and, with his beautiful attendant, was moving through the garden, when suddenly the fair-haired Friedrich came across their path, and kept them back with loud laughter and a thousand tricks. Still, however, they insisted on proceeding; and Friedrich hastened off, running towards Mariana and the father. These seemed to flee before him; he pursued the faster, till Wilhelm saw them hovering down the alley almost as on wings. Nature and inclination called on him to go and help them, but the hand of the Amazon detained him. How gladly did he let himself be held! With this mingled feeling he awoke, and found his chamber shining with the morning beams. (402–3)

Here suddenly we glimpse a principle of a wholly different formal nature at work: all these various characters are to be united in a central phantasmagoria just as musical themes are intertwined, in the contemporaneous emergence of the sonata form. The demonstration of a deeper unity now no longer has to be made in any logical or enlightenment or even causal way, but by the very logic of the dream as a formal moment, the moment of the reprise. Here is a form of closure utterly distinct from plot, allegorical of oppositions, yet demanding its own verisimilitude: do we not now finally believe that all this holds together in some new principle of coherence? It is enough to think of Joyce's prodigious reassemblage of all his daytime motifs in the Nighttown scene in *Ulysses* (beyond which everything is anticlimax), or in cinema, that remarkable final hour of Fassbinder's *Berlin Alexanderplatz* in which everything that has happened in thought or

deed returns oneirically in a new unity, to grasp what is formally original in this extraordinary moment of *Wilhelm Meister*.

But in Goethe, the oneiric superstructure is doubled by a very different infrastructural unity as well, and it is this which sets *Wilhelm Meister* apart from all the generic norms and justifies its unique position as a synthesis of "world" and "soul" in Lukács' *Theory of the Novel*.[16] Nor would I want to characterize this alternate unification—although certainly redolent of the eighteenth century, of Freemasonry and of the *The Magic Flute* of 1790—as narrowly Enlightenment: its basis is not Reason as a faculty but the collective as such.

For it famously transpires that the various chance events and contingencies that have marked Wilhelm's youthful career so far are all planned out in advance, as necessary errors (shades of the Hegelian dialectic!), and are the doing of a shadowy group of conspirators known as the Society of the Tower, whose principal figures he will come to know at the end of the book, and whose existence—with a certain Masonic hocus-pocus ("all you saw in the tower was but the relics of a youthful undertaking" [512/564])—will be revealed to him. The plot is thus turned inside out: from a series of chance happenings it is suddenly revealed as a plan and as a deliberately providential design. And the Enlightenment emphasis on reasoned persuasion and pedagogy here reaches a kind of bizarre climax in which life itself becomes the "*leçon d'objets*," the theoretically calculated pattern of test and error which the old theological concept ("justify the ways of God to man") only dimly foreshadowed in distorted fashion. The Society of the Tower is a better pedagogue than God, and far more self-conscious and theoretical about its teaching method.

But it is important not to let all this slip (in the content) into a vapid kind of humanism and celebration of eighteenth-century virtue (there is very little of Plutarch and Rousseau here), although there is another kind of slippage, a purely formal one, which we will want to take more seriously. Yet it is significant that the Lukács of *Theory of the Novel*, only a year or so before his commitment to politics and to communism, should not have glimpsed the political significance of this "white conspiracy," which very obviously anticipates the structure of the Party itself, and the dialectic of a collective leadership which both reflects the social order and works back upon its already present tendencies to develop them. Lothario and his friends have just returned

[16] Georg Lukács, *Theorie des Romans*, Neuwied: Luchterhand, 1963, Part II, chapter 3.

from the New World, and the revolution of the colonists against the tyranny of the ancien régime. Their political party is not only out to transform the old social world by the modernization of agriculture—"Here or nowhere is America!" (407/446); it therefore carries within itself the explosive spark of that element of the American Revolution which was to expand into the French one, and to become an international movement for the transition from feudalism to the Republic—a movement then further elaborated in *Wilhelm Meisters Wanderjahre*, with Goethe's customary restraint (as befits that member of the late feudal bureaucracy he also was). This is the collective task into which Wilhelm is to be initiated, exchanging that microcosm of the social which is the theater—Faust's "*kleine Welt*"—for the "great world" of the socio-political. It is a unique solution to the formal problem of the political novel, which, a kind of *hapax legomenon*, can never be repeated, nor can it serve as a model, flawed in its very exemplarity, as though designating itself not as the concrete solution but rather merely the intent to find one. But this calls for a larger theoretical speculation about novelistic form, one which no doubt is deeply indebted to Lukács, but seeks to replace the notion of the unified subject or soul in his text with a less "humanistic" thematics.

Even before that, however, we need to bid farewell to that whole novelistic development of providential interiority which led from Defoe to *Wilhelm Meister* in the first place. The future of this formal path will no longer be subjective but objective, nor longer individualistic but rather collective. But it is important to see that Goethe himself liquidates this earlier tradition within his novel, in what has always struck readers of whatever period and generation as the most peculiar of his extrapolations, namely Book Six, or the *Confessions of a Beautiful Soul*, which from Hegel's famous discussion in the *Phenomenology* onwards often been taken as a pathology of introspection. The form itself imitates, precisely by way of this self-sufficient extrapolation, the solipsism of interiority and of the subjectivity that seeks to enact its own virtue, even when issuing from a collective (the *Herrnhuter*), which still includes the ancient, almost extinguished vibrations of the great religious revivals and revolutions. Goethe has as it were sealed this noxious individualism away in a kind of cyst or crypt,[17] in which the subjectivity can be separated out from the plot

[17] Jacques Derrida, "Fors," in Nicholas Abraham and Maria Torok, *Le Verbier de l'homme aux loups*, Paris: Flammarion, 1999.

of his novel and as it were formally excised (even though the episode's author is as tightly knit by kinship into his cast of characters as all the other chance storytellers of the novel). Thus sealed off, the "confessions" then mark the grave of the "spiritual autobiography" and any reading of providence as an inward or psychologico-theological phenomenon.

4.

But, as Lukács so usefully warns us, the "novel" as a form is never a successful solution to any of its problems, and they merely change their terms when an older problematic individualism has been removed. The new terms in which I wish to codify the possibilities in a kind of structural permutation scheme will be the more Kantian ones (contemporaneous with Goethe himself) of transcendence and immanence.

But perhaps it is better to start with the more familiar older Hegelian terminology which passed into New Criticism without taking any of its dialectical baggage with it: namely the so-called concrete universal, or alternately the thoroughgoing fusion of form and content such that you cannot tell one from the other any longer.[18] This aesthetic was probably a neo-classical inspiration, produced by the return to antiquity popular in Goethe's circles, which Hegel frequented when he worked in Jena and with which he sympathized ever after. (Not many novels ever find mention in Hegel, who died just as the first great wave of modern fiction, with Balzac in the forefront, was about to hit land; Goethe of course famously reads Stendhal.[19]) Anyway, the unity of form and content thus far simply means that nothing stands out, there are no excesses either way, wherever you inspect the artifact: no extra stylistic frills, no "extrinsic" or extraneous content poking out of the pillowcase: all this very much in the spirit of epic; and of course the ambiguity of the German word *episch*, also used for the novel and for narrative in general, means that the novel gets no special treatment.

So this aesthetic of fusion can very conveniently be adapted to the language of immanence. *Episch* is immanent, in the sense that

[18] W. K. Wimsatt, "The Structure of the Concrete Universal in Literature," *PMLA* 62 (1947).

[19] *Conversations with Eckermann*, January 17, 1831.

meaning is inherent in all its objects and details, all its facts, all its events. They are meaningful in and of themselves, and require no outside commentary or explanation, as might be the case when you introduce modern technology of some sort, or events like financial crises, which are not self-explanatory and whose very nature as "events" in the first place is not secured in advance: which have to be explained in order to come into visible existence as temporal phenomena. Yet when this miraculously happens—not in older modes of production, but in our own—we call it realism, and have an interest in accounting for such texts, which we understand as being unusual and few in number. They are better explained, however, if we add the word transcendence to our repertoire in order to identify what is no longer present in them.

Or trying another alternative, that of Barthes' in a famous offhand sentence, that there is an incompatibility between meaning and existence in modern literature.[20] Transcendence is meaning, the immanent is existence itself, and so it is also best to enrich this layer of terms with an ontological significance. What is, whether in the text or in the life world, is not always meaningful (it is often therefore what we call contingent); what is meaningful is not always there as an existent, in the world, as is the case with Utopia or nonalienated relationships. What we may now perhaps call ontological realism is found where these two coincide to the point at which we cannot tell them apart any longer or worry about the distinction.

What would be the opposite of all this? What would be a truly transcendent kind of text? Myths, religious texts of all sorts? But after all, we are here working within the framework of the already secular novel, and have ruled those texts out in advance; we have thus presupposed a certain immanence to begin with by way of novelistic form.

Within this frame then, we can assume that what we call ontological realism is to be characterized as a truly immanent kind of immanence. In that case, and for purposes of differentiation, what would be a transcendental immanence? I think we can make a beginning by imagining this to be a kind of ethical literature, or a narrative in which the categories of ethics—vice, virtue, evil, kindness and

[20] Roland Barthes, "L'Effet de réel," *Oeuvres complètes*, Volume II, Seuil, 1994, 485: "La 'représentation' pure et simple du 'réel', la relation nue de 'ce qui est' (ou a été) apparaît ainsi comme une résistance au sens; cette résistance confirme la grande opposition mythique du vécu (du vivant) et de l'intelligible."

sympathy, and on into anger, melancholy and the like—are just at a slight distance from the narrated emotions and feelings of the characters or from their characterological properties. In this situation of a barely perceptible gap between the characters' existence and what they seem to mean, the old dualism of the immanent and the transcendent reinscribes itself, however faintly. The "ethical" characters are not yet mere examples or illustrations, nor have they gone all the way towards those allegories in which nameless figures bear their ethical designations on their backs in the form of signs: I am Envy, I am Complacency; but we are close; and the mere glimpse of such a possibility is enough to cast an unsettling doubt over the assurances of a hitherto ontological realism. No sensible secular and historical person can any longer believe that the ethical categories are "in nature," are in any way inscribed in being or in human reality; and for the most part an ethical literature has come to reflect the closure of class—whether it is that of Jamesian aristocrats or of Bunyan's tinkers. Ethical maxims and categories only work within a situation of homogeneous class belonging; when operative from one class to another, they absorb the signals of class struggle and tension itself and begin to function in a very different, socio-political way. At any rate, for the corpus of novels we are here considering, the novel which deploys ethical categories will be characterizable as betraying something like a transcendental immanence, that is to say, the promotion into a quasi-transcendental status of social elements—the ethical categories and judgements—which looked like intrinsic and even banal elements of the social situation itself, until closer inspection revealed their operation to be somehow and barely perceptibly trans-social, meta-social.

In that case, would it make any sense to propose a parallel category of transcendental transcendence? I think so, provided we understand once again that we are operating within a secular corpus from which all genuine transcendence has been eliminated. We no longer have to do with religious or sacred texts, with texts bearing within them anything having to do with the divine or the angelic or even the supernatural (although at some point very early in our historical segment—the history of the novel—the ghost story reappears, with Defoe's Mrs. Veal, or Schiller's *Geisterseher*). So the transcendence we are evoking will be a transcendence bound and limited by secular immanence, a transcendence within our own "realistic" and empirical world: what form can it possibly take, and what would possibly

be above this realistic world and yet still of a piece with it and flesh of its flesh?

I think that such transcendence could only be detected in one possible place, namely in the space of an otherness from what is, a dimension freed from the weight of being and the inertia of the present social order. It seems possible to me that this transcendence could conceivably operate in the past, by way of the historical reconstruction of societies that no longer exist. Yet insofar as, no longer existing, they nonetheless have been, the law of an ontological realism would presumably still be binding on them, and there is a way in which *Salammbô*, or Walter Scott, or *Romola*, or *The Tale of Two Cities*, are no less realistic than their contemporary counterparts. At any rate, there here opens up the very interesting problem of the historical novel as such, which we can no longer pursue here.

But when we have to do with the future, with what does not yet and may never exist, it is a different story, and we are confronted with politics itself. Here we confront the knotty problem of the political novel and political literature in general, and their very possibility of existence. Is it conceivable, within the world of immanence, for this or that existent, this or that already existing element, to breathe "the air of other planets," to give off even the slightest hint of a radically different future? That the realistic novel absolutely resists and repudiates this possibility can be judged from its conventional treatment of political characters, of figures whose passion is political, who live for the possibilities of change and entertain only the flimsiest relationship with the solid ontology of what exists right now. We need only pass in review a few of the most famous representations of such figures to be convinced, and I will adduce three exhibits here.

There is Dickens's treatment of the "missions": all the crazed philanthropists who crowd the pages of *Bleak House* around the central character of Mrs. Jellabee with her African mission, and who wreak damage on all the people close to them. (Her husband literally pounds his head against the wall, her children are filthy and neglected, her oldest daughter escapes into a marriage of whose drawbacks she is scarcely cognizant, her own daily life is a shambles, ill-dressed, living only for the African correspondence and the African cause). When it is remembered that politics for Dickens, in any case in his supremely "liberalist" and free-market society, can only be embodied in philanthropy (but at best the personal, "ethical" type represented by Mr. Jarndyce, rather than this wholesale collective type), then it will be

understood not only that these are figures of the political, but also that they represent the intellectual as well: the political intellectual, to whom these twin bugbears of abstraction and non-living, of the loss of ontological life and human reality to pure thought and idle speculation on the not-yet existent, must be conjoined.[21]

Once we learn to read these figures of the political, and to detect them throughout realism and in other places than the officially political—the parliamentary novels of Trollope, for example, where the political as such is a perfectly proper and respectable specialized dimension of life and being as such—we find that the satire of the anti-ontological is everywhere in ontological realism and indeed goes hand in hand with the very structure of the form and is inseparable from it.

Thus Henry James's feminists (in *The Bostonians*) are supremely emblematic of the political intellectual, and a far nastier and more malicious repudiation of politics than anything in the experiment of *The Princess Casamassima*, or indeed the contemporary treatment of anarchism generally (although Conrad's *Secret Agent* certainly comes close behind).

Finally, the whole animus spills over in Flaubert and is very far from being a mere personal ideology or idiosyncrasy. Whoever has read the extensive representations of the great political meetings in *L'Éducation sentimentale*—imitations in 1848 of the Jacobin clubs of the great revolution and far too long to quote here in the savorous detail they merit—knows of how much bile the political intellectuals are the recipients in Flaubert, who sees them as obsessives and maniacs necessarily plural in their nature, repetitions of each other and groups rather than individuals. Whatever the psychoanalytic interpretations of this unique passion and loathing of Flaubert, such scenes must also be taken as empty forms, structures of empty heterogeneity, which are reproduced throughout his work, most notably in *St. Anthony* but also in the *comices agricoles* in *Madame Bovary*, in court scenes in *Hérodias*, and at various key points in *Bouvard and Pécuchet*. As such, Flaubert has solved the formal problem of how to represent the unrepresentable posed here: in other words, how to

[21] Miss Wisk offers the generalized philosophy of the "mission" itself, being intent on showing "the world that woman's mission was man's mission; and that the only genuine mission, of both man and woman, was to be always moving declaratory resolutions about things in general at public meetings." (*Bleak House*, London: Penguin, 1996, 482 [chapter 30]).

lend ontological weight to the representation of figures and elements defined virtually in advance as lacking being, as having little ontological weight in their own right, either as characters or as meanings. The empty form of the obsessive exchange and multiplication of maniacs and their words (rather than thoughts) thus allows a representation to be set in the place of the ontologically thin and unreal (and indeed, in this respect, Flaubert's solution folds back over Dickens's, which equally relies on the multiplication and proliferation of such maniacs to fill in his canvas and give it the requisite density).

All of this, not merely to document the fragility of the new category of transcendental transcendence in the history of the novel, but also to make the usual point about the structural and inherent conservatism and anti-politicality of the realist novel as such. An ontological realism, absolutely committed to the density and solidity of what is—whether in the realm of psychology and feelings, institutions, objects or space—cannot but be threatened in the very nature of the form by any suggestion that these things are changeable and not ontologically immutable: the very choice of the form itself is a professional endorsement of the status quo, a loyalty oath in the very apprenticeship to this aesthetic. But since politics does exist in the real world, it must be dealt with, and satiric hostility is the time-honored mode of dealing novelistically with political trouble-makers. Only Stendhal and Galdós offer mild exceptions to this rule, the one on the basis of the youthful inexperience of his characters (and also Stendhal's internationalism and relative abhorrence of narrower French "realities"), and the other no doubt in part as a result of the extraordinary political changeability of Spain. But neither one loosens the lines that hold his work firmly to the ground of being, however much the narrative balloon surges and eddies in the winds of history. Were such lines cut, however, we would no doubt be confronted with truly Utopian forms, such as Chernyshevsky's *What's to be Done*, which would slowly drift out of the province of realism altogether.

Perhaps these two transcendental categories—the transcendental immanence of ethics and allegory, the transcendental transcendence of the political temptation—also open up a new space in which that formal and discursive phenomenon untheorizable in terms of realism might be grasped: I mean modernism, whose novels are, as I've insisted elsewhere, not at all to be understood as some opposite number of realism but in a very different and incommensurable aesthetic and formal fashion. Thus there are modernisms which can

also be perfectly well interrogated with the categories and within the limits of realism as such—one thinks of *Ulysses* for example, certainly a prime example of a stubborn and hard fought attempt to hold onto the absolute being of the place and day, the untranscendable reality of a specifically limited secular experience. But such categories may no longer be the best ones to convey everything which is unique about such modernist works.

Yet there remains a fourth category in our scheme that has not so far been specified. We have positioned "great realism" in the space of immanent immanence, a kind of miraculous unity of form and content, a unique ontological possibility, on which we will waste no more effusions. We have then identified two slight yet menacing and perilous deviations from this formal plenitude, the first one in a kind of transcendental immanence in which certain of the categories of being—the ethical ones primarily—separate themselves out from reality and hover above it as a kind of organizing device which threatens to turn the events and narrative actions into so many examples and illustrations. And we have glimpsed a further possible deviation, the political one—transcendent transcendence—according to which the whole existing fabric of being is threatened by revolutionary and systemic overhaul and transformation.

But we have not yet taken into consideration the possibility that there could be something we might call immanent transcendence, in which a transformation of being would be somehow implicit in being itself, like a strange kind of wave running through matter, or a kind of pulsation of energy throbbing in the things themselves, without necessarily altering them or depriving them of their ontological status. The reader will have guessed that it is towards this final category that we have been working and that the immanent transcendence we have in mind is nothing less than the providential as such, its production what we have sporadically been calling the providential novel. Here truly we find what Lukács imagined himself to be describing when he evoked a realism of tendencies, which he understood as a representation of ontological change.[22] The examples were very precisely the passage of history throughout the regime changes of the early nineteenth century, as in

[22] See especially *Writer and Critic* and the *Studies in European Realism*. I believe that the theory of realism promoted in these essays is best grasped in terms of the way plot is able to represent historical tendencies, rather than as any static notion of "typical" social individuals.

La Cousine Bette, which ranges from Napoleon to the first Algerian expeditions in the late 1820s; yet no one ever suggested that ontological realism could not handle history or the passage of time. It is systemic change that we have tended to rule out; yet Lukács' description of the "tendency" seems far better to describe the providential drifts at work in the novels we have been describing than anything else.

We may now return to those, and, in the light of this "ontological typology" and also mindful of the unique structural properties of the *Wilhelm Meister* experiment, will now need to offer some conjectures as to the historical development of these possibilities, that is to say, their concrete evolutionary realizations in those historically determined "evolutionary niches" (Moretti)[23] that the secular societies uniquely offered, in their various contingent ways.

The replacement of Providence by uniquely human energies was always a temptation for Balzac: the very character of Vautrin himself, as he desperately races to release Lucien (at the end of *Splendeurs et misères des courtisans*), just as he has magisterially pulled strings to secure the latter's good fortune in the early moments of this novelistic series—this image of supreme know-how and savoir-faire mesmerized the author of *La Comédie humaine* throughout his life, offering an image of action to be narrated as well as a subject-position for the novelist himself. In this sense, we must accustom ourselves to rethinking the pallid category of the "omniscient narrator" in terms of sheer passion, as an obsession to know everything and all the social levels from the secret conversations of the great all the way to the "*mystères de Paris*" and the "*bas fonds*." Balzac was supremely what the Germans call a "*Besserwisser*," a know-it-all at every moment anxious to show off his inside expertise (which he was unfortunately less able to put into practice). But surely Dickens had the virus as well, who was so proud of knowing all the streets in London; and we may safely attribute an analogous concupiscence of knowledge to all the other great encyclopedic fabulators, from Trollope to Joyce.

What interests us more for the moment is the way this conception of absolute knowledge spills over into the intrigue itself. Vautrin's status as the superman is sealed by his ultimate failure (with its human reward in his eventual promotion to chief of police—like the real-life Vidocq): but this failure simply marks the sterility of the dialectic of

[23] See his *Atlas of the European Novel 1800–1900*, London: Verso, 1998.

the One and the Many. What if the task of knowing the Many were rather assigned to the Many themselves, in the form of a Meister-like Society of the Tower?

This is precisely what happens in Balzac, beginning with the *Histoire des Treize* (1833):

> Il s'est rencontré, sous l'Empire et dans Paris, treize hommes également frappés du même sentiment, tous doués d'une assez grande énergie pour être fidèles à la même pensée, assez probes entre eux pour ne point se trahir, alors même que leurs intérêts se trouvaient opposés, assez profondément politiques pour dissimuler les liens sacrés qui les unissaient, assez forts pour se mettre au-dessus de toutes les lois, assez hardis pour tout entreprendre, et assez heureux pour avoir presque toujours réussi dans leurs desseins; ayant couru les plus grands dangers, mais taisant leurs défaites; inaccessibles à la peur, et n'ayant tremblé ni devant le prince, ni devant le bourreau, ni devant l'innocence; s'étant acceptés tous, tels qu'ils étaient, sans tenir compte des préjugés sociaux; criminels sans doute, mais certainement remarquables par quelques-unes des qualités qui font les grands hommes, et ne se recrutant que parmi les hommes d'élite. Enfin, pour que rien ne manquât à la sombre et mystérieuse poésie de cette histoire, ces treize hommes restés inconnus, quoique tous aient réalisé les plus bizarres idées que suggère à l'imagination la fantastique puissance faussement attribuée aux Manfred, aux Faust, aux Melmoth; et tous aujourd'hui sont brisés, dispersés du moins. Ils sont paisiblement rentrés sous le joug des lois civiles, de même que Morgan, l'Achille des pirates, se fit, de ravageur, colon tranquille, et disposa sans remords, à la lueur du foyer domestique, de millions ramassés dans le sang, à la rouge clarté des incendies.
>
> In Paris under the Empire, thirteen men came together. They were all struck with the same idea and all endowed with sufficient energy to remain faithful to a single purpose. They were all honest enough to be loyal to one another even when their interests were opposed, and sufficiently versed in guile to conceal the inviolable bonds which united them. They were strong enough to put themselves above all law, bold enough to flinch at no undertaking; lucky enough to have almost always succeeded in their designs, having run the greatest hazards, but remaining silent about their defeats; impervious to fear; and never having trembled before public authority, the public hangman or even innocence itself. They had all accepted one another, such as they were, without regard to social prejudice: they were undoubtedly criminals, but undeniably remarkable for certain qualities which go to the making of great men, and they recruited their members only from among men of outstanding quality. Lastly—we must leave out no element of the sombre and mysterious poetry of this story—the names of these thirteen men were never divulged, although they were the very incarnations of ideas suggested to the imagination by the fantastic powers attributed in fiction to the Manfreds, Fausts and Melmoths of literature. Today this association is broken up, or at least dispersed. Its members have peacably submitted to the yoke of civil law, just as Morgan, that

> Achilles among pirates, gave up buccaneering, became a colonist and, basking in the warmth of his domestic fireside, made profitable use, without any qualms of conscience, of the millions he had amassed in bloody conflict under the ruddy glare of burning ships and townships.[24]

Here, this promising conspiracy results in little more than episodes (although they are among the most remarkable episodes in all of Balzac). Elsewhere, however, a rather different dialectic sets in motion, which suggests that the providential conspiracy is trans-ethical. It is beyond good and evil, to the degree to which it can serve feudal or individualistic passions (as in the *Histoire des Treize*) or philanthropic ones indifferently. So it is that Balzac will fantasize a white conspiracy with equal enthusiasm, this one however nourished by the more conservative traces of the religious orders, rather than the sulphurous fumes of the Carbonari and the other great political confraternities of Balzac's youth. Charity also needs its Machiavellis; as the organizational figure in *L'Envers de l'histoire contemporaine* (1842–1847) serves:

> N'avons-nous pas à déjouer la conspiration permanente du mal? à la saisir dans ses formes changeantes qu'on les croirait infinies? La Charité, dans Paris, doit être aussi savante que le vice, de même que l'agent de police doit être aussi rusé que le voleur. Chacun de nous doit être candide et défiant; avoir le jugement sûr et rapide autant que le coup d'œil.
>
> Is it not our task to undermine the permanent conspiracy of evil? to apprehend it beneath forms so mutable as to seem infinite? Charity, in Paris, must be as cunning as the thief. Each of us must be at one and the same time innocent and mistrustful; we must have powers of judgement that are as reliable and as swift as a glance.[25]

But if these "*frères de la Consolation*" are less exciting than the Thirteen, this has less to do with the moralism of the former than it does of the increasing "transcendence" of the providential conspiracy, which little by little comes externally to intervene in a situation to which it has a merely contemplative relationship of pity and moral judgement. Here, then, we can observe the slippage of more purely immanent plots into

---

[24] Honoré de Balzac, *La Comédie humaine*, Volume V, Paris: Pléiade, 1977, 787 (first paragraph of *Ferragus*). Balzac, *History of the Thirteen*, trans. Herbert J. Hunt, Middlesex: Penguin, 1974, 21.

[25] Ibid., Volume VIII, 323 (*L'Envers de l'histoire contemporaine*, premier episode), trans. mine.

their transcendental opposite numbers. Whether this movement can be reversed, and develop into some more original novelistic structure, is a question better addressed to Dickens.

Our Mutual Friend—for many readers the darkest and most exciting, Willkie Collins–like of Dickens's completed novels, and also the one in which the salvational note is most satisfyingly sounded, and the lifting of sentimentalism into a truly providential realm of being—this late novel testifies to the temptation of conspiracy in Dickens as well, and to the "master-strokes of secret arrangement"[26] whereby the great feuilletonist attempts to hold together plot strands so numerous as to defy memory itself. But here conspiracy reveals its structure by promoting itself to a heightened power: for that systematic promotion of illusion fostered by the symbolically eponymous protagonist ("mutual" also means a participation in several plots at once)[27] when he decides to take on a second existence after his alleged and public death—something that cannot yet be called a conspiracy exactly—now promotes a deception on the part of Mr. Boffin, the Golden Dustman (or junk collector) and ostensible heir of the miser's fortune. Here, then, we enter the realm of genuine conspiracy, not diminished by its moral uses as test and lesson. It will no doubt promote the fortunes of the good and the discomfiture of the wicked, who do indeed recognize this human agency for Providence as such: such is for example the last glimpse of meaning of the obsessed Bradley Headstone, one of the darkest characters in Dickens, as he comes to understand his failure to dislodge his rival for Lizzie (the "separation" referred to in the following):

> For then he saw that through his desperate attempt to separate those two for ever, he had been made the means of uniting them. That he had dipped his hands in blood, to mark himself a miserable fool and tool. That Eugene Wrayburn, for his wife's sake, set him aside and left him to crawl along his blasted course. He thought of Fate, or Providence, or be the directing Power what it might, as having put a fraud upon him—overreached him—and in his impotent mad rage bit, and tore, and had his fit.[28]

Yet however glorious the apotheosis of the Golden Dustman in this salvational dénouement (which Dickens, evidently uncertain

[26] Charles Dickens, *Our Mutual Friend*, New York: Modern Library, 1960, 794 (Book IV, chapter 13).

[27] See p. 116: "'I may call him Our Mutual Friend,' said Mr. Boffin" (Book I, chapter 9).

[28] Ibid., 816 (Book IV, chapter 15).

of himself, then redoubles in his postscript, in which Mr. and Mrs. Boffin miraculously survive a destructive railway accident), it cannot for most readers match the outcome of *Bleak House* itself, which will therefore have some lessons as to the providential slippages of the later work.

Dustbins, to be sure, they have in common, and old Krook—he of the spontaneous combustion, as in Zola—is no doubt a match for Mr. Boffin.[29] But we will understand nothing of the providential if we imagine it has only to do with the conventional happy ending and the marriage of Esther to her true beloved. On the contrary, the supremely providential moment, the truly sublime note of salvationality, lies elsewhere: it is an Event, in the most august sense of the term, and one that people feel approaching in the street:

> an unusual crowd ... something droll ... something interesting ... everyone pushing and striving to get nearer ... and presently great bundles of paper began to be carried out—bundles in bags, bundles too large to be got into any bags, immense masses of papers of all shapes and no shapes, which the bearers staggered under, and threw down for the time being, anyhow, on the Hall pavement, while they went back to bring out more.[30]

Laughter, universal glee, is the sign of this event, in which a whole old world is swallowed up and a new one born: and no reader who has worked through the thousand pages and nineteen installments of this extraordinary novel will fail to be electrified by the outcome:

> Even these clerks were laughing. We glanced at the papers, and seeing Jarndyce and Jarndyce everywhere, asked an official-looking person who was standing in the midst of them, whether the cause was over. "Yes," he said; "it was all up with it at last!" and burst out laughing too.[31]

And this in an ante-penultimate chapter entitled "Beginning the World"!

These passages return us to the euphoria of our initial quotations, with a few additional findings. For one thing, it has become clear that the jubilation will necessarily be a collective one, it will tell the

[29] Edgar Johnson compiles an impressive list of the items collected in such "dust bins," among them "soot, cinders, broken glass, bottles, crockery, worn-out pots and pans, old paper and rags, bones, garbage, human feces and dead cats," etc. Ibid, xi, note 6.

[30] Charles Dickens, *Bleak House*, 973–4 (chapter 65).

[31] Ibid., 974 (chapter 65).

climax of the story of the Many rather than the One. In that sense, it bears a strong relationship to Kant's idea of enthusiasm, which he associated with the French Revolution, and whose jubilation at least partly underscores its kinship with the Sublime, a parallel we cannot further explore here, save to recall the profound ambivalence of the Sublime, for Kant as for Burke, which must awaken monstrous feelings of terror and revulsion fully as much as those of the expansion of joy.[32]

5.

But we must also recall the fundamental shift, in the evolution of this kind of novel, from the question of individual salvation to the interweaving of many plots and many destinies. George Eliot is subversively outspoken on the matter of point of view, democratically insisting on everyone's right to this narrative centrality, and reminding us, in the middle of a chapter gravitating to Dorothea as naturally as water finding its own level, that her unattractive spouse, Mr. Casaubon, also "had an intense consciousness, within him, and was spiritually a-hungered like the rest of us."[33] Such reminders are virtually a social Bill of Rights (or *Droits de l'homme*) for the novel as a form, and will be programmatically enacted by later novelists like Joyce or Dos Passos.

What this implies most immediately, however, is the shift from the diachronic to the synchronic: now not the fateful destiny of this or that privileged or at least narratively favored protagonist, but rather the immense interweaving of a host of such lots or fates will involve a prodigious shifting of the axes of the novel, and usher in the serials of Dickens we have been examining no less than the late work of George Eliot herself, virtually our central exhibit in this discussion.

For not only the fact that the very word "providence" is dropped fatefully in the course of virtually every chapter of *Middlemarch*, sometimes by the characters, sometimes by the author herself; but the deeper sense of this recurrence—the drawing into the light of this

[32] See Immanuel Kant, "General Comment on the Exposition of Aesthetic Reflective Judgements" (it follows paragraph 29), in *Critique of Judgement*, Indianapolis: Hackett, 1987, 126–40; and also J.-F. Lyotard's interesting commentary in *Le Différend*, Paris: Minuit, 1983, 238–40 (Kant 4).

[33] George Eliot, *Middlemarch*, London: Penguin, 1994, 278 (chapter 29).

omnipresent ideology of providence and destiny, of the providential character of good or bad fortune—makes of this great work a reflexive practice of providential realism as such. This is to say, using a term that is more meaningful when sparingly appealed to, that *Middlemarch* can be seen as an immense *deconstruction* of the ideology of providence as such, a tracking down of its religious overtones and undertones, and an almost surgical exploration of its results and effectivities. I insist on the term "ideology," for other ideas of interrelationship and inextricability would have been possible in this period of the Paris Commune and the unification of Germany: Darwinian visions, nationalist programs, the bitter experience of class antagonisms—all of these, along with later ethnic or gender forms, might well have presided over the narrative of collective necessity, and in fact sometimes did. But Eliot's peculiar identification of this essentially social experience uniquely reflects the survival and ideological function of religion in the English class compromise, and allowed her to double a remarkable narrative synchronicity with a secondary investigation of the concepts through which the participants thought their experiences. (The term "deconstruction" was chosen to underscore the non-partisan nature of the investigation, which does not overtly denounce these religious survivals, as outright ideological analysis would surely have wanted to do).

But her word "spiritual" is also misleading, to the degree to which it suggests otherworldliness. To be sure, there is here a remarkable emphasis on intellectual labor. Earlier novelists were willing to tolerate glorified images of various artists, reunited under the general Romantic rubric of "genius": Balzac even indulged in alchemical inventors of genius (*La Recherche de l'absolu*), and thinkers of genius (*Louis Lambert*), but can scarcely be said to have had the sympathy for what would later in the century develop into scientific research (as Eliot follows it, with technical curiosity, in the story of Lydgate). "Idealistic" in Hegel's usage, we may recall, simply means "theoretical"; and Eliot brings a passionate curiosity to her depiction of all kinds of productive activity (including Garth's engineering).[34]

But what is certainly central in *Middlemarch*, and non-theoretical fully as much as non-spiritual, is the "cash nexus" and the synchronic role of money in the play of these individual destinies (which bear the name of a collectivity). The novel is a historical one, no doubt (set in 1830), and the intensifying grip of a money economy over the

[34] Ibid., 250–1 (chapter 24).